A DISSERTATION

The Weight of the *Dead*

Necrometabolism, Planetary Mourning, and the Anamnetic Self in Final Fantasy VII



OCTOBER 2026

Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst
Das Rettende auch.

But where danger is, the saving power also grows.

FRIEDRICH HÖLDERLIN, "PATMOS" (1803)

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that *Final Fantasy VII* (Square, 1997; directed by Yoshinori Kitase, produced by Hironobu Sakaguchi, scenario by Kitase and Kazushige Nojima) is organized, at every scale of its fiction and its form, by a single problem it never names: how the living metabolize their dead. In a cosmology where the spirit energy of every deceased being returns to a planetary current, the Lifestream, and where that current is refined into mako to illuminate the megalopolis of Midgar, energy, memory and identity are not analogous substances but one substance in three phases: flowing (the Lifestream), crystallized (materia) and embodied (persons). It follows that the planetary crisis (the industrial combustion of the Lifestream) and the psychic crisis (Cloud Strife's counterfeit self, assembled from a dead friend's memories) are not plot and subplot but one crisis rendered at two scales. Cloud is to Zack as Midgar is to the Lifestream: each is a structure of borrowed light, powered by the dead.

The dissertation names this structure *necrometabolism*, the totality of processes by which a living system (organism, psyche, city, planet or franchise) incorporates, transforms and returns the energies, remains and memories of its dead, and distinguishes four modes through which the game's agents enact it. The *combustive* mode belongs to the Shinra Electric Power Company, which burns the dead for light and returns nothing to the stream. The *sovereign-incorporative* mode belongs to Sephiroth, who would devour the totality of the dead in order to become a god. The *mimetic-counterfeit* mode belongs to Jenova, which wears the faces of the beloved dead to colonize the living. The *anamnetic-reciprocal* mode belongs to the Lifestream itself, to Aerith Gainsborough and to the party, who remember, return and release.

Methodologically, the study stratifies its evidence into three tiers: attested genealogy (developer testimony, franchise precedent, onomastics), ambient discourse (the Japan of 1995–97: the Hanshin earthquake, the Aum Shinrikyō sarin attack, post-bubble deflation, the Monju reactor scandal, the Nostradamus boom, the national memory of industrial pollution) and hermeneutic resonance (philosophical traditions brought into dialogue without claims of influence). Through these tiers it reconstructs the Lifestream as a planetary transposition of the Japanese ancestral commons described by Yanagita Kunio and of the Yogācāra storehouse consciousness that Vasubandhu describes as flowing like a torrent; reads Midgar as the superimposition of Bentham's panopticon upon the eight-petalled court of the Womb Realm mandala, a sacred cosmogram inverted into a disciplinary machine; interprets Sephiroth, through Kabbalah, Gnosticism, Mary Shelley, Milton, Freud and the Japanese cult of vengeful spirits, as a melancholic false gnostic

manufactured by enlightenment science; and reads Cloud's recovery, through Locke, Parfit, Winnicott, Abraham and Torok, Nishitani Keiji and Paul Ricoeur, as the Freudian work of mourning, grounded not in the restoration of memory's sameness (*idem*) but in the ipseity of a kept promise. The final salvation, in which Holy fails alone and the Lifestream rises to complete it, is analysed as a soteriology of other-power (*tariki*) that answers Heidegger's dialectic of danger and saving power with Arendt's natality.

The study culminates in thirteen theses proposing *planetary kuyō* (acknowledgment, return, release and the protection of the conditions of birth) as the game's original ethical bequest and as a frame for an Anthropocene whose fossil economy is, without metaphor, the combustion of the deep-time dead. A closing turn applies the analysis to the game's own afterlife, reading the *Compilation of Final Fantasy VII* and the Remake project as franchise-scale necrometabolism: every remake is either a reactor or a rite.

FRONT MATTER

Note on Sources, Editions and Conventions

The primary text is the original PlayStation release of *Final Fantasy VII* (Japan, 31 January 1997; North America, 7 September 1997; Europe, 17 November 1997), consulted in its Japanese script and in its 1997 English localization, whose infelicities are notorious and occasionally consequential; where the two diverge on a point of interpretation, the divergence is noted. The *International* edition (Japan, October 1997) is cited only for material absent from the original. The works gathered under the *Compilation of Final Fantasy VII* (*Before Crisis*, 2004; *Advent Children*, 2005; *Dirge of Cerberus*, 2006; *Crisis Core*, 2007) and the Remake project (*Final Fantasy VII Remake*, 2020; *Final Fantasy VII Rebirth*, 2024) are treated as afterlives and paratexts, not as authorities over the 1997 text; Chapter Nine makes their status an object of analysis in its own right. Lore systematized in the *Final Fantasy VII Ultimania Omega* (Studio BentStuff, 2005) is cited as developer-sanctioned gloss rather than as scripture.

Game dialogue is paraphrased rather than quoted, because the Japanese and English scripts frequently differ in wording and nuance, because the argument concerns structures of meaning rather than verbal particulars, and because extended quotation from a copyrighted script would not be appropriate here; the same consideration governs the paraphrase of modern scholarship. Pre-modern and public-domain texts are quoted in their original languages wherever the wording carries argumentative weight; modern scholarship is paraphrased and cited by author and date.

Character names follow current official romanization (Aerith, not the 1997 English "Aeris"). Japanese terms follow modified Hepburn romanization with macrons. Japanese scholars and authors are named family name first (Yanagita Kunio, Nishitani Keiji, Watsuji Tetsurō, Ōtsuka Eiji, Azuma Hiroki); developers whose credits circulate internationally in Western order are so named (Yoshinori Kitase, Hironobu Sakaguchi, Kazushige Nojima, Tetsuya Nomura, Nobuo Uematsu). A date in parentheses after a work refers to its first publication, performance or release.

The study observes an explicit evidentiary discipline, formalized in Chapter One. Every claim belongs to one of three tiers: *attested genealogy* (what the makers said, borrowed or named), *ambient discourse* (what the culture of production was saying around them) and *hermeneutic resonance* (what the work can be shown to think in conversation with traditions its makers need never have read). No claim of the third tier is presented as a claim

of the first. Developer testimony is reported as testimony, that is, as recollection offered in interviews and guidebooks years after the fact, and weighted accordingly.

Two terms are coined or adapted here. *Necrometabolism* is defined in the Introduction and formalized in Chapter Ten. *Planetary kuyō* extends the Japanese Buddhist term *kuyō* (供養), the memorial offering made for the dead and, in Japanese practice, also for animals, for laboratory specimens and even for worn-out implements, to name the ethics the dissertation attributes to the game.

INTRODUCTION



A Civilization That Burns Its Dead for Light

I. The city lit by the dead

Every lamp in Midgar burns the dead. Eight reactors ring a central tower, and each draws from beneath the earth the substance the game calls mako (魔晄, literally "demonic radiance"). The game's cosmology, articulated in fragments by the astronomer-sage Bugenhagen and by the recorded testimony of the Cetra woman Ifalna, leaves no doubt about what that substance is. Mako is the refined form of the Lifestream: the current of spirit energy into which every living thing dissolves at death and from which every living thing is drawn at birth. The neon of the Wall Market, the elevators of the Shinra Building, the trains shuttling between plate and slum are all powered by the condensed and combusted remainder of the Planet's dead. Midgar is a necropolis in the most literal sense available to fiction: not a city of tombs but a city whose metabolism is its dead.

The fact is stated early, repeatedly and in plain terms, yet its full consequence has rarely been drawn. Critical and popular reception has tended to divide the game into two registers. The first is planetary and political: Barret Wallace's insistence, in the opening hour, that the Planet is dying; the eco-sabotage of AVALANCHE; the corporate sovereignty of Shinra; the apocalypse of Meteor and the counter-apocalypse of Holy. The second is psychological and intimate: the slow disclosure that Cloud Strife, the taciturn mercenary through whose eyes the player sees, is not who he believes himself to be; that his memories of serving as an elite SOLDIER belong to his dead friend Zack Fair; that his personality is a prosthesis assembled from another man's stories, his own unrealized wishes and the alien cells injected into him. The first register is usually read as allegory (of industrial modernity, of nuclear power, of climate), the second as character study (of trauma, of dissociation, of masculine performance). When the two are related at all, the relation is one of narrative convenience: the ecological spectacle supplies the stakes, the identity drama supplies the intimacy.

This dissertation argues that the relation is one of identity. The game builds its macrocosm and its microcosm out of the same substance and subjects them to the same pathology. Midgar is a structure of borrowed light, illuminated by the energy of the dead, which it consumes without return. Cloud's self is a structure of borrowed memory, animated by the recollections of a dead man, which he has absorbed without mourning. Both are artifacts of combustive and counterfeit relations to the dead. Both are threatened by the same sovereign will, Sephiroth's, which seeks to complete their logic by devouring the dead entire. And both are healed, in the game's most audacious formal decision, in the same medium and by the same agency. Cloud's identity is restored when he falls into the Lifestream at Mideel and, accompanied by Tifa Lockhart, revisits his memories one by one inside the planetary current of the dead. The Planet is saved when, at the climax, Holy proves insufficient and the Lifestream itself erupts from the earth to drive Meteor back

from Midgar. In both cases the dead are neither fuel, nor throne, nor mask: they are agents. The healing of the self and the saving of the world are one event at two scales.

II. Necrometabolism

To name the structure the game builds, this dissertation coins the term *necrometabolism*. Its two halves carry distinct genealogies. "Metabolism" entered modern scientific vocabulary through the cell physiology of the 1830s and 1840s, where it named the chemical transformations by which living matter maintains itself. It acquired a political-economic valence when Marx, drawing on Justus von Liebig's agricultural chemistry, described labour as the process that mediates the *Stoffwechsel*, the exchange of matter between society and nature, and diagnosed in capitalist agriculture an irreparable rupture in that exchange, a reading John Bellamy Foster has reconstructed as the theory of "metabolic rift" (Foster 2000). It acquired ontological depth in Hans Jonas's philosophy of the organism, where metabolism is not one vital function among others but the mode of being through which a living thing maintains its identity by ceaselessly exchanging its substance, a "needful freedom" in which the self persists only by passing through what is not itself (Jonas 1966). The prefix is borrowed, with a deliberate displacement, from Achille Mbembe's necropolitics, the sovereign power to dictate who may live and who must die (Mbembe 2003). Where necropolitics concerns the production of the dead, necrometabolism concerns their use.

Necrometabolism, then, denotes the totality of processes by which a living system (an organism, a psyche, a household, a city, a civilization, a planet or, as Chapter Nine argues, a media franchise) incorporates, stores, transforms and returns the energies, remains and memories of its dead. Every living system has one. The question is never whether the living feed on the dead, for they always do: soil is composed of them, languages are composed of them, every self is composed of inherited recollection. The question is how. *Final Fantasy VII* distinguishes four modes, and the distinctions turn on four criteria: what is taken from the dead; what, if anything, is returned; what becomes of the singularity of the dead; and what temporality the relation inhabits.

1. The **combustive** mode, embodied by Shinra, takes energy and returns waste. It is indifferent to the singularity of the dead, which it reduces to undifferentiated fuel, and it inhabits the linear time of progress and depletion.
2. The **sovereign-incorporative** mode, embodied by Sephiroth, takes everything and returns nothing. One singularity absorbs all others, and the relation inhabits the eschatological time of the end.
3. The **mimetic-counterfeit** mode, embodied by Jenova, takes faces and memories and returns masks. It falsifies singularity and inhabits a parasitic time of repetition without difference.

4. The **anamnetic-reciprocal** mode, embodied by the Lifestream, by Aerith and by the party, takes the dead into remembrance and returns them as gift, agency and new life. It honours singularity and then releases it into a commons, and it inhabits the cyclical and natal time of return and beginning.

The decisive structural fact is that Cloud passes through all four modes. He is infused with mako in Hojo's laboratory (combustion); he becomes the instrument through which Sephiroth obtains the Black Materia and summons Meteor (incorporation); he wears Zack's history as his own (counterfeit); and he becomes, in the Lifestream, the subject who remembers truly (anamnesis). The Planet passes through the same four phases: it is drained by Shinra, wounded by Sephiroth's Meteor, haunted by Jenova's two-thousand-year counterfeit, and saved by the anamnetic eruption of its own dead. The protagonist is a microcosm of the cosmos in the strict Hermetic sense formulated by the *Tabula Smaragdina*: *quod est inferius est sicut quod est superius*, what is below is like what is above.

III. An origin in grief

The game began, by its producer's repeated account, in a son's grief. Hironobu Sakaguchi has told interviewers that his mother died while he was working on *Final Fantasy III* (1990), and that the loss led him to want to make life itself the theme of a later game, approaching death not as a dramatic device but as a question to be thought through: where the dead go, what remains of them, how the living stand toward them. The Lifestream is that question given cosmological form. Yoshinori Kitase, directing, has recounted a parallel resolve regarding the death of Aerith: that it should arrive abruptly and without the consolations of heroic sacrifice, because real deaths come without speeches and leave behind not meaning but absence. These are recollections, and Chapter One weighs them as such. But they establish that the problem this dissertation identifies was not imposed on the work from outside. The makers were thinking about the dead, and they built a world in which the dead are the medium of everything.

Japanese religious life possesses a word for the act by which the living stand in right relation to the dead: *kuyō* (供養), the memorial offering. Its scope in Japanese practice is remarkably wide. *Kuyō* is performed for parents and ancestors, but also for animals, for the fish of a fishing port, for the laboratory animals sacrificed by research institutes, and even for broken needles, worn brushes and discarded dolls, as if every thing that has served the living were owed acknowledgment before its release. This dissertation argues that *Final Fantasy VII* is, among other things, a *kuyō*, and that the ethics it proposes, against the three pathological modes of necrometabolism, is a *planetary kuyō*: acknowledgment of what has been taken, return of what can be returned, release of the dead into the commons from which new life is drawn, and protection of the conditions of birth.

IV. Stakes

The argument carries consequences for five domains. For the criticism of *Final Fantasy VII*, it dissolves the apparent bifurcation of the work into ecological parable and identity drama, and it relocates the work's ethical centre from either nature or selfhood to the relation between the living and the dead that both presuppose.

For game studies, it demonstrates that the game thinks through its systems as well as its story. The materia economy, in which the player equips crystallized fragments of the Lifestream and harvests their growth, enacts in miniature the combustive relation the narrative condemns; the gap between the reversible death of the battle system and the irreversible death of the narrative is itself a philosophical statement about the difference between incapacitation and loss.

For ecological thought, the argument yields a reframing of the Anthropocene. Coal is the compressed remains of the swamp forests of the Carboniferous; petroleum is, in large part, the transformed bodies of Mesozoic marine plankton. Industrial modernity has lit itself, without metaphor, by burning the deep-time dead. Shinra's mako is therefore less an allegory of fossil energy than its mythic literalization, and the climate crisis can be described as a necrometabolic crisis: a civilization that has burned an inheritance accumulated over hundreds of millions of years and returned to the stream only its exhaust (Crutzen and Stoermer 2000; Chakrabarty 2009; Malm 2016).

For the philosophy of personal identity, the game stages, with uncanny exactness, the thought experiments of the analytic tradition, above all Derek Parfit's cases of memory transfer, and declines both the reductionist conclusion that identity does not matter and the essentialist conclusion that a true self lies buried beneath the false. It proposes instead that selfhood is an anamnetic commons, sustained by fidelity to a promise and by a witness who remembers with us.

For Japanese studies, finally, the game offers a case of ancestral cosmology and memorial practice persisting at the core of a commodity engineered for global circulation, a work celebrated for its cultural "odourlessness" whose metaphysics is saturated with the Japanese imagination of the dead.

V. The work in brief

The narrative unfolds across three compact discs. On the first, the ex-SOLDIER mercenary Cloud Strife is hired by AVALANCHE, a cell of eco-saboteurs led by Barret Wallace, to bomb the mako reactors of Midgar. He falls, literally, into the life of Aerith Gainsborough, a flower seller in the slums who is the last of the Cetra, an ancient people able to hear the Planet. Shinra retaliates against AVALANCHE by collapsing the upper plate onto the Sector 7 slum, killing its inhabitants and blaming the rebels. Infiltrating the Shinra Building to rescue Aerith, the party finds the company's president impaled and the headless specimen called Jenova escaped, and learns that Sephiroth, a legendary SOLDIER believed

dead, has returned. Cloud recounts, in a playable flashback, the destruction of his hometown Nibelheim five years earlier, when Sephiroth discovered the documents of his own engineered origin, declared himself heir to the Cetra and burned the village. The party pursues Sephiroth across the world, through the desert prison beneath an amusement park, the observatory of Cosmo Canyon, a rebuilt and repopulated Nibelheim, the rocket town of an abandoned space programme and the Temple of the Ancients, until, in the Forgotten Capital of the Cetra, Sephiroth kills Aerith as she prays.

On the second disc, at the Northern Crater where an alien calamity struck the Planet two thousand years earlier, Sephiroth reveals to Cloud that he was never a SOLDIER and that his memories are fabrications. Cloud surrenders the Black Materia, Meteor is summoned, and the Planet's ancient defenders, the WEAPONs, awaken. Cloud vanishes and is later found catatonic from mako poisoning in the island town of Mideel, where an eruption of the Lifestream plunges him and Tifa into its current; there, together, they reconstruct his true past. The third disc carries the party into the Crater for a final confrontation, the release of Holy, and the eruption of the Lifestream that saves the Planet. An epilogue set five hundred years later shows the canine sage Red XIII and his cubs gazing on the ruins of Midgar, overgrown with green, and leaves the survival of humanity undetermined.

VI. Plan of the dissertation

Chapter One establishes the method: the three evidentiary tiers, the problem of collective authorship and the state of scholarship. Chapter Two reconstructs the Lifestream as a philosophical cosmology through Lovelock's Gaia, the ancient doctrine of the world-soul, Vasubandhu's storehouse consciousness, Yanagita Kunio's ethnology of the ancestors, Platonic and Lurianic accounts of crystallized knowledge, and the myth of the Cetra and their Promised Land. Chapter Three analyses mako and Midgar as combustive necrometabolism through Heidegger's critique of technology, Wagner's *Ring*, Marx's metabolic rift, Weber, Adorno and Horkheimer, Goethe's *Faust*, the panopticon and the mandala, and the history of Japanese industrial pollution and energy politics. Chapter Four reads Sephiroth and Jenova as the sovereign and counterfeit modes through Kabbalah, Gnosticism, *Frankenstein*, Milton, Nietzsche, Freudian melancholia and the Japanese cult of vengeful spirits. Chapter Five reads Cloud through the philosophy of personal identity, psychoanalysis, existentialism, the Kyoto School and Ricoeur's hermeneutics of the self. Chapter Six reads Aerith's death and intercession through Japanese mediumship, Pure Land soteriology, Christian iconography and Benjamin's theory of storytelling. Chapter Seven reads AVALANCHE, Shinra's counter-terror and the party as a fellowship of the bereaved through Benjamin's critique of violence, the deep-ecology debates and the postwar Japanese imagination of defeat. Chapter Eight situates the game's cosmography within Norse eschatology, Eliade's history of religions, fin-de-siècle Japanese millennialism and a com-

parative field running from Miyazaki and *Evangelion* to *Dune* and Philip K. Dick. Chapter Nine reads the game's systems as arguments and its afterlives as a franchise-scale necrometabolism. Chapter Ten formalizes the theory, tests it against objections and states it in thirteen theses. The Conclusion returns to the five hundred years.

CHAPTER ONE

Method and Archive

Attested Genealogy, Ambient Discourse, Hermeneutic Resonance

A game produced by a large studio team over several years cannot be read as the expression of a single mind, and a game that takes its names from Kabbalah, Norse cosmology and Reformation history cannot be read as innocent of the traditions it names. This chapter establishes how the dissertation steers between the two errors: the biographical fallacy that would reduce *Final Fantasy VII* to its makers' stated intentions, and the free-associative fallacy that would attach to it any philosophy it happens to resemble. Its instrument is a stratification of evidence into three tiers, each licensing a different kind of claim.

1.1 The collective author and the status of intention

The New Critical prohibition on appeals to authorial intention (Wimsatt and Beardsley 1946), Roland Barthes's announcement of the death of the author (1967) and Michel Foucault's reconstruction of the author as a historically variable "function" of discourse (1969) together frame the problem with unusual sharpness for a work like this one. There is a pleasing irony in invoking the death of the author for a study of the dead, but the irony is instructive: Barthes's author dies so that the text may become a space of circulating, impersonal citation, and *Final Fantasy VII* is a work whose cosmology makes exactly that claim about persons. In the Lifestream, individual voices dissolve into a common current from which new utterances are drawn. The game's theory of the dead is also, implicitly, a theory of authorship.

In industrial game production the author-function is distributed by design. The credits divide responsibility among direction and scenario (Yoshinori Kitase), original concept and production (Hironobu Sakaguchi), scenario (Kazushige Nojima, who is generally credited with the architecture of Cloud's concealed past), character design and battle visuals (Tetsuya Nomura), art direction (Yusuke Naora) and music (Nobuo Uematsu), among many others. The present study treats this collective as an author-function in Foucault's sense: a principle of grouping that licenses attributions of coherence without implying a unified consciousness behind them. Testimony from individual makers is used as *evidence about the archive*, not as a *verdict on meaning*. Wimsatt and Beardsley forbid intention from settling what a work means; they do not forbid testimony from illuminating what a work was made from.

A further complication is linguistic. *Final Fantasy VII* exists as at least two texts, the Japanese script of January 1997 and the English localization of September 1997, which differ in register, connotation and occasionally in substance. The English text's infelicities became part of the work's Anglophone reception, so that the "text" of *Final Fantasy VII* is a polyglot field rather than a single document. This dissertation reads from the Japanese wherever a distinction carries weight and treats the variance between versions as itself a

minor instance of the work's theme: memory passed through another voice is never returned unchanged.

1.2 Tier I: attested genealogy

The first tier comprises what the makers said, borrowed or named. Five kinds of evidence belong here.

Testimony. Sakaguchi's account of his mother's death during the development of *Final Fantasy III*, and of his consequent wish to make life and death the subject of a later game, is the most frequently repeated piece of developer testimony about the work and the most consequential for this study. Kitase's account of wanting Aerith's death to be abrupt and unheroic belongs here as well. Nojima's earlier scenario work at Data East on the *Glory of Heracles* series reportedly included a protagonist stripped of his memory and forced to reconstruct who he is, a motif that recurs throughout his career; whether or not the reports are precise, amnesia and the reconstruction of selfhood are demonstrably his signature preoccupations, from *Final Fantasy VII* through *Kingdom Hearts*. Nomura has described design decisions bearing on the theme of doubles, including the reworking of Cloud's appearance to differentiate him sharply from Sephiroth and a preference for keeping Sephiroth largely offstage, felt through others rather than seen. All such testimony is retrospective, filtered through promotional contexts and translation, and is weighted accordingly.

Abandoned concepts and sibling projects. Accounts of the game's development describe early concepts set in a near-future New York and, separately, a proposal by Tetsuya Takahashi and Kaori Tanaka (Soraya Saga) judged too dark and complex for the series, which became *Xenogears* (1998). The latter is significant here because *Xenogears* deploys, overtly and at length, the apparatus this dissertation reads latently in *Final Fantasy VII*: Gnostic cosmogony, Kabbalistic nomenclature, Freudian and Jungian structures of the psyche, Nietzschean ambition and a protagonist split into dissociated personalities. The two games are siblings conceived within the same studio in the same years; *Xenogears* is the explicit philosophical shadow of the implicit philosophy studied here.

Franchise precedent. *Final Fantasy VII* concludes an argument the series had been conducting for several instalments. In *Final Fantasy V* (1992) the elemental crystals that sustain the world shatter because human kingdoms have amplified their power for prosperity. In *Final Fantasy VI* (1994), co-directed by Kitase, the Gestahlian Empire drains captive Espers of their magical essence to fuel Magitek weaponry, and the jester Kefka achieves godhood by seizing the statues of the Warring Triad, plunging the world into ruin. The extraction of the sacred for industrial power and the apotheosis of a nihilistic will are therefore not novelties of 1997; they are the series' own inheritance, which *Final Fantasy VII* radicalizes by making the extracted substance not an elemental or divine power but the dead themselves.

Music. Uematsu's "One-Winged Angel" sets Latin phrases drawn from the medieval poems of the *Carmina Burana* manuscript, among them the Archpoet's "Estuans interius" and the Fortuna lament set by Carl Orff in 1937. The borrowing is attested and its source is datable to the twelfth and thirteenth centuries; Chapter Four reads it as the hinge between Sephiroth and the medieval iconography of the wheel of Fortune.

Onomastics. Names are the most visible borrowings and the most treacherous evidence. They establish that the makers drew upon a mythographic archive; they do not establish how deeply. Japanese popular culture has long used Western esoteric vocabulary as aesthetic texture (the production staff of *Neon Genesis Evangelion* have said that its Christian and Kabbalistic iconography was chosen in part for its exotic visual appeal), and the same caution applies here. The table below records the principal names and the resonance each bears. The left column is Tier I; the right column is, for the most part, Tier III.

Name in the game	Attested or evident source	Resonance developed in this study
Sephiroth	*Sefirot*, the ten divine emanations of Kabbalah (a plural noun)	A single person bearing a plural name; the many-in-one of the Jenova "Reunion" (Ch. 4)
Midgar	Old Norse *Miðgarðr*, the enclosed middle world of humans	The walled human world as an enclosure against, and a parasite upon, the Planet (Ch. 3, 8)
Nibelheim	Norse *Niflheimr*; Wagner's subterranean *Nibelheim* in *Das Rheingold*	The site where gold is forged into a ring of power becomes the site where a man reads his origin and burns his home (Ch. 3, 4)
Shinra (神羅)	Characters for "divinity" and "net" or "gauze"; homophone of *shinra* in *shinra banshō*, "all of creation"	A net cast over the gods; the corporation as Heidegger's *Gestell* (Ch. 3)
Heidegger	A Shinra executive, head of the security apparatus	The philosopher of technology's critique, turned into a functionary of the apparatus he described (Ch. 3, 7)
Bugenhagen	Johannes Bugenhagen (1485–1558), Wittenberg reformer and Luther's pastor	The reformer of a church becomes the sage of a planetary religion (Ch. 2, 7)
Hojo	The Hōjō regents who ruled behind the Kamakura shoguns	Power exercised from behind the visible sovereign; science behind the throne (Ch. 4)
Lucrecia	Evokes Lucretius, poet of the soul's dispersal at death	The mother of the god-aspirant frozen in grief in a crystal cave (Ch. 4, 7)
Gaea's Cliff, Junon, Cosmo Canyon	Greek *Gaia*; Roman *Juno*; *kosmos*	A cosmography assembled from the names of earth, sovereignty and order (Ch. 8)
Cait Sith, Masamune, Bahamut, Kujata	Celtic folklore; the Kamakura swordsmith; Arabic cosmology	A syncretic archive of the world's myths, rendered as equipment (Ch. 8, 9)

Medium. Square's announcement in 1996 that the game would appear on Sony's CD-based PlayStation rather than Nintendo's cartridge-based successor made possible the pre-rendered backgrounds, full-motion video and three-disc structure that the game's argument exploits. Chapter Nine reads the change of disc after Aerith's burial as a material caesura in the act of play.

1.3 Tier II: ambient discourse

The second tier comprises what the culture of production was saying around the makers, the "structures of feeling" in Raymond Williams's phrase (1977), which shape what a work can imagine without being its sources. The development of *Final Fantasy VII* coincided with an extraordinary concentration of Japanese catastrophe and scandal.

On 17 January 1995 the Hanshin–Awaji earthquake destroyed much of Kobe and killed more than six thousand people. On 20 March 1995, on the orders of the movement's founder, Asahara Shōkō, five members of the new religious movement Aum Shinrikyō released sarin on five trains of the Tokyo subway, killing thirteen people (a fourteenth victim died in 2020) and injuring thousands. The act of apocalyptic terror was carried out against the commuter arteries of the capital by a movement that had recruited scientists, manufactured the nerve agent itself and fused esoteric Buddhism, yoga, Christian apocalyptic and Nostradamian prophecy into a doctrine of purification by catastrophe (Lifton 1999). The same movement had released sarin in the city of Matsumoto in June 1994, killing eight people, and in November 1989 had murdered the lawyer Sakamoto Tsutsumi, who was acting for the families of its members, together with his wife and infant son. On 8 December 1995 a sodium coolant leak and fire occurred at the Monju prototype fast-breeder reactor, and the concealment and editing of video of the accident by its operator, the state-owned Power Reactor and Nuclear Fuel Development Corporation (Dōnen), became a national scandal. In February 1996 the health minister, Kan Naoto, apologized on behalf of the state after his ministry released files it had long withheld. Between 1,400 and 2,000 people by different counts, most of them with haemophilia, had been infected with HIV in the 1980s through unheated blood-clotting products that the Green Cross Corporation and other firms went on selling after safer heat-treated products existed, while the Ministry of Health and Welfare failed to stop them; by 2001 more than five hundred had died. In 2000 three former Green Cross executives, one of them a former senior official of the same ministry, were convicted of professional negligence resulting in death, and Matsumura Akihito, who had headed the ministry's biologics division in those years, was convicted in a separate trial (Feldman 2000). All of this unfolded against the deflation that followed the collapse of the asset bubble in 1990–91 and the consequent delegitimation of the "iron triangle" of bureaucrats, politicians and corporations that had administered postwar growth.

Deeper sediments lay beneath these events. Gotō Ben's *Nosutoradamusu no daiyogen* (1973), a sensational interpretation of Nostradamus that became one of the great best-sellers of postwar Japan, had taught a generation to expect a catastrophe descending from the sky in the seventh month of 1999. The national memory of industrial pollution, crystallized in Minamata disease (officially identified in 1956), the other "big four" pollution diseases and the "Pollution Diet" of 1970 that enacted a raft of environmental legislation, had made the poisoning of communities by corporations a central plot of modern Japanese history (George 2001; Walker 2010). The energy policy that followed the oil shock of 1973, including the three laws of 1974 that subsidized municipalities hosting power plants, had bound peripheral towns to reactors by the logic of compensation. Internationally, the identification of the Chicxulub crater in 1991 as the site of the impact that ended the Cretaceous, and the collision of Comet Shoemaker–Levy 9 with Jupiter in July 1994, had made celestial impact a vivid object of public imagination.

The media environment completed the field. Susan Napier has described an "apocalyptic mode" running through postwar anime (Napier 2001); Miyazaki Hayao completed the manga of *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* in 1994; *Neon Genesis Evangelion* aired from October 1995 to March 1996, during the game's development; Oshii Mamoru's *Ghost in the Shell* appeared in 1995. These works are cited in this study as contemporaries and comparanda, not as sources. Ambient discourse explains why certain shapes were available to the imagination of 1995–97; it does not prove that any particular shape was borrowed.

1.4 Tier III: hermeneutic resonance

The third tier comprises what the work can be shown to think in dialogue with traditions its makers need never have read. Its justification is the hermeneutic principle, articulated by Hans-Georg Gadamer, that understanding occurs as a fusion of horizons between the interpreter's situation and the work's (Gadamer 1960), and Paul Ricoeur's complementary claim that a text possesses a surplus of meaning and projects a "world in front of the text" that exceeds what its author intended (Ricoeur 1976). To read *Final Fantasy VII* with Heidegger or Vasubandhu is not to claim that Kitase read them; it is to claim that the game's world, once projected, enters into conversation with theirs, and that the conversation reveals features of the game otherwise invisible.

The tier is disciplined here by three constraints. The first is *textual anchoring*: every resonance must attach to particulars of the game (a name, a scene, a mechanic, a structural rhyme), not to a general mood. The second is *multi-scalar generativity*: a resonance earns its place only if it illuminates more than one level of the work, for instance both the planetary and the psychic plots, or both narrative and system. The third is *defeasibility*: a reading must be capable of being contradicted by the game, and where the game resists it, the resistance is reported.

The boundary between tiers is porous in instructive ways. The Yogācāra doctrine of the storehouse consciousness, central to Chapter Two, was never a learned curiosity in Japan; it entered Japanese Buddhism through the Hossō school of Nara and persists in religious vocabulary. Yanagita Kunio's account of how the individual dead merge into a collective of ancestors describes practices that were, in 1997, a lived inheritance. Such material sits between Tier II and Tier III: a diffuse cultural heritage rather than a consulted source. Conversely, the name of the Shinra executive Heidegger is a Tier I fact whose significance is wholly Tier III; nothing suggests the makers intended the philosopher's critique of technology, yet the name sits at the centre of the apparatus that critique describes.

Tier	What it comprises	Typical evidence	Claims it licenses	Example in this study
I. Attested genealogy	What the makers said, borrowed or named	Interviews, guidebooks, credits, names, franchise precedent, quoted texts	That a source or concern entered the work's making	Sakaguchi's bereavement; the *Carmina Burana*; *Sefirot*
II. Ambient discourse	What the culture of production was saying	Events, bestsellers, media, policy, public controversy	That a shape was available to the imagination of the period	Aum Shinrikyō; Monju; the Nostradamus boom
III. Hermeneutic resonance	What the work thinks in dialogue with traditions	Philosophy, theology, comparative literature	That a reading illuminates the work at more than one scale	Heidegger's *Gestell*; Vasubandhu's storehouse; Ricoeur's promise

1.5 The ludic text

A videogame is not only a narrative to be read but a system to be operated, and its meanings are produced in part by what the player is made to do. Espen Aarseth's theory of ergodic literature, published in the year of the game's release, defined such texts by the nontrivial effort required to traverse them (Aarseth 1997). Ian Bogost's procedural rhetoric holds that rule systems make arguments (Bogost 2007); Jesper Juul's account of games as "half-real" locates their meaning in the interplay of real rules and fictional worlds (Juul 2005); Alexander Galloway reads games as allegories of informatic control (Galloway 2006). The methodological consequence is that the game's systems count as evidence: the materia economy, the Limit Break, the distinction between battle incapacitation and narrative death, the chocobo stables, the hidden affection values that determine a date at the Gold Saucer. Where narrative and system diverge, the divergence is read not as a flaw (Clint Hocking's "ludonarrative dissonance", 2007) but as a site where the work may be thinking against itself.

1.6 State of the field

Final Fantasy VII occupies a secure place in histories of the medium, where it figures as the work that carried the Japanese role-playing game to a mass Western audience and established cinematic presentation as a norm (Kohler 2004; Consalvo 2016). Studies of Japanese

game culture have read the series against national history and ideology (Hutchinson 2019). The popular-philosophy literature has addressed the franchise's themes of identity, ethics and fate in accessible essays (Blahuta and Beaulieu 2009). Ecocritical scholarship on games has made environmental representation and simulation a recognized field (Chang 2019), within which the game's mako economy is a frequently cited touchstone. Anime and media studies supply the frames for the work's Japanese contexts: Napier's apocalyptic mode, Iwabuchi Koichi's analysis of the "culturally odourless" export (Iwabuchi 2002), Ōtsuka Eiji's theory of narrative consumption (1989), Azuma Hiroki's database animals (2001) and Marc Steinberg's account of the media mix (2012).

To these must be added an informal archive of exceptional scale: three decades of collaborative fan exegesis, script comparison, translation criticism and data-mining, conducted outside the academy with a rigour the academy rarely acknowledges. This dissertation draws on that archive only where its claims are verifiable against the game, but notes its existence as itself an instance of the phenomenon under study. A community that has spent thirty years remembering a dead character, testing rumours of her revival and annotating every line she spoke is an anamnetic commons in the precise sense developed in Chapter Ten.

Across these literatures a pattern holds. Readings divide by register: ecological readings privilege Shinra, mako and the Planet; psychological readings privilege Cloud; mythological readings privilege Sephiroth and the names. No existing account identifies the relation between the living and the dead as the principle that organizes all three registers at once. That is the gap this dissertation proposes to fill.

CHAPTER TWO

II

The Lifestream

Planetary Life, the Ancestral Commons and the Storehouse of the Dead

The Lifestream is the game's answer to Sakaguchi's question about where the dead go, and it is a more exact and more philosophically demanding answer than its popular reputation as a "nature spirit" suggests. It is a theory in which life is a single planetary current, individual lives are temporary condensations of that current, death is dissolution back into it, and memory and knowledge, though they lose their owners, are neither annihilated nor preserved intact but stored, transformed and returned. This chapter reconstructs the theory, distils it into four axioms and places it among the traditions it most resembles: the Gaia hypothesis, the ancient doctrine of the world-soul, the Yogācāra storehouse consciousness, the Japanese ethnology of the ancestors, and the Platonic and Kabbalistic theories of knowledge as remembered light. The aim is not to find the Lifestream's source but to show what kind of thought it is.

2.1 The cosmology as given

The game delivers its metaphysics in fragments, as testimony rather than exposition. At Cosmo Canyon the aged Bugenhagen, custodian of a discipline the English localization calls the Study of Planet Life (星命学), explains to the party that the Planet is alive; that a current of spirit energy circulates through it; that living beings are born from that current and return to it at death; and that the mako reactors, by drawing the current off for fuel, are shortening the Planet's life. In his observatory he lets them hear what he calls the Planet's cry. Later, in the recorded testimony that Professor Gast made of his wife Ifalna, one of the last Cetra, the history behind the cosmology is supplied: the Cetra were a migratory people born of the Planet and able to converse with it; two thousand years ago an entity fell from the sky, wounded the Planet and destroyed most of the Cetra by imitating their dead and infecting them; the survivors sealed it, and the Planet, gathering its spirit energy to heal the wound, created the WEAPONs to defend itself. Materia, the crystals through which the characters work magic, are described as condensations of the Lifestream that contain the knowledge of the Ancients.

The gaps in this account matter as much as its claims. The game never states that personal consciousness survives death; its default is dissolution. The only figures who persist as recognizable wills within the Lifestream, Aerith and Sephiroth, are exceptional, and their exceptionality defines the rule: one persists in order to intercede, the other in order to refuse. Nor does the game resolve whether the Planet is a person, an organism or a system. It speaks of the Planet's cry, its will and its defenders, yet never personifies it as a god.

From these materials four axioms can be distilled.

1. **Unity.** All life is one current, temporarily individuated in bodies.
2. **Conservation.** Nothing that lives is lost; at death it returns to the current, though not as itself.

3. **Mnemonic substance.** The current carries memory and knowledge as well as vitality; energy and information are not yet distinguished in it.
4. **Agency.** The current can act, as defence (the WEAPONs), as healing (the gathering at the Northern Crater) and, finally, as intervention (the rising at Midgar).

The third axiom is the most original and the most consequential. It means that to extract energy from the Lifestream is also to extract memory, and that every technology of power in this world is simultaneously a technology of remembrance or forgetting.

2.2 Gaia: homeostasis, immunity and the problem of the pathogen

The resemblance most frequently noted is to the Gaia hypothesis, which James Lovelock developed in the late 1960s while designing life-detection experiments for NASA's Mars programme and formalized with the microbiologist Lynn Margulis: the proposal that the biota and their environment constitute a self-regulating system that maintains conditions favourable to life (Lovelock and Margulis 1974; Lovelock 1979). The name was suggested to Lovelock by his neighbour, the novelist William Golding. The Daisyworld model (Watson and Lovelock 1983) answered the charge of teleology by demonstrating how planetary homeostasis can emerge from simple feedbacks without any planetary intention.

The Planet of *Final Fantasy VII* borrows Gaia's systemic vocabulary (the English script's Gaea's Cliff names it outright) but adds an immunology. The WEAPONs are the Planet's antibodies, generated against the alien infection of Jenova and left dormant when the Cetra sealed it; awakened by the wound of Meteor, they attack indiscriminately, levelling Junon and assaulting Midgar. Holy, the ultimate white magic, is described as the Planet's final homeostatic correction, a power that will eliminate whatever threatens it. Here Bugenhagen introduces the game's most unsettling ambiguity: if humanity is itself the threat, Holy may eliminate humanity. The Planet's immune system does not distinguish between invader and inhabitant.

This ambiguity anticipates a turn in Gaian thought itself. Lovelock's late writing described a Gaia that would defend its homeostasis at humanity's expense (Lovelock 2006), and the phrase "the revenge of Gaia" crystallized a misanthropic temptation latent in the hypothesis from the start: the reading of the human species as a planetary disease. Bruno Latour and Isabelle Stengers have argued against both the maternal and the vengeful images, describing Gaia instead as a ticklish, intrusive assemblage of feedbacks that neither loves nor punishes but responds (Stengers 2009; Latour 2015). Stengers's phrase "the intrusion of Gaia" could serve as a caption for the WEAPONs' attacks on Shinra's coastal city. The game divides Gaia into two faces: the Lifestream, a nurturing commons, and the WEAPONs and Holy, an immune apparatus that intrudes. It refuses to say which face is

primary, and the epilogue, in which Midgar lies overgrown and no human appears, keeps the question of the pathogen open.

2.3 The world-soul, from the *Timaeus* to the noosphere

Behind Gaia stands the far older doctrine of the *anima mundi*. Plato's *Timaeus* describes the cosmos as a living creature endowed with soul and intelligence, *zōon empsychon ennoun* (30b), crafted after the model of the eternal Living Being. The Stoics made the cosmos a rational animal pervaded by *pneuma*, a fiery breath that holds every body together, and taught a periodic conflagration (*ekpyrōsis*) in which the cosmos returns to fire before being reborn (*palingenesia*). Plotinus described a procession from the One through Intellect to a World-Soul of which individual souls are parts, and a return (*epistrophē*) by which the soul retraces its descent (*Enneads* IV.3). Spinoza's *Deus sive Natura* abolished the distinction between creator and creation, and his account of the mind as the idea of the body led him to the claim that something of the mind remains which is eternal: *sed eius aliquid remanet, quod aeternum est* (*Ethics* V, prop. 23).

Each of these anticipates part of the Lifestream. The *Timaeus* supplies the living cosmos; the Stoics supply a pervasive vital substance and, in conflagration and rebirth, the shape of the game's ending, in which Meteor and Holy threaten fire and the epilogue shows regeneration. Plotinus supplies procession and return. Spinoza supplies the conjunction of an impersonal persistence with the dissolution of the person: what remains of the mind is not the remembering individual but its participation in an eternal order.

The twentieth century naturalized the doctrine. Vladimir Vernadsky described the biosphere as the planetary envelope in which life acts as a geological force (Vernadsky 1926). Pierre Teilhard de Chardin added a noosphere, a thinking layer enveloping the earth, which would converge toward an Omega Point of hyper-personal unity (Teilhard 1955). The Lifestream occupies a position between the two. It is not Vernadsky's chemistry of life, because it carries memory; it is not Teilhard's convergent mind, because it dissolves persons rather than gathering them into a super-person. It might be called a *mnemosphere*: a planetary stratum in which the energetic and the mnemonic are not yet distinguished. The difference from Teilhard proves decisive in Chapter Four. Sephiroth's project, to draw the totality of the Planet's spirit energy into a single point and become a god, is a counterfeit Omega Point, a convergence of all life into one person that the Lifestream's logic of dissolution forbids.

2.4 The storehouse that flows like a torrent: Vasubandhu

The closest philosophical analogue to the Lifestream is not Western at all. The Yogācāra school of Indian Buddhism, systematized in the fourth and fifth centuries by Asaṅga and Vasubandhu, posited beneath the six sense-consciousnesses and the defiled mentation

that clings to a self an eighth layer: the *ālaya-vijñāna*, the storehouse consciousness (Japanese *araya-shiki*, 阿頼耶識). Every action and experience deposits seeds (*bīja*) in this storehouse, perfuming it (*vāsanā*) as incense perfumes cloth. The seeds persist, ripen and give rise to future experience, including the experience of a new life. The storehouse thereby explains the continuity of karma across lives without positing a substantial self: what passes from life to life is not a person but a current of impressions.

Vasubandhu's *Thirty Verses* (*Triṃśikā*) describe the storehouse with an image the Lifestream literalizes: *tac ca vartate srotasaughavat*, it proceeds like the flood of a torrent (v. 4). The storehouse is not a container but a flow; it stores by streaming. The parallels with the Lifestream are exact on several points. Both are impersonal reservoirs of the impressions left by all past lives. Both are the medium from which new lives arise. Both carry memory without carrying selves. And both can be defiled. In Yogācāra, defiled seeds perpetuate suffering; in the game, Jenova's cells, carried into the current through Sephiroth, are a defiled seed in the planetary storehouse, an elaboration the *Compilation* makes explicit when *Advent Children* depicts a plague transmitted through the Lifestream itself.

Yogācāra also names the remedy. Liberation is described as *āśraya-parāvṛtti*, the revolution or transformation of the basis, in which the storehouse is purified and converted into what East Asian Buddhism calls the great perfect mirror wisdom (大円鏡智, *daien-kyōchi*), a cognition that reflects all things without distortion. Chapter Five will argue that Cloud's reconstitution inside the Lifestream is precisely such a revolution at the basis: his counterfeit self, built on defiled seeds, dissolves in the storehouse and is reconstituted as an accurate mirror of what happened. The doctrine reached Japan through the monk Dōshō, who studied under Xuanzang in Tang China and returned in the seventh century to found the Hossō lineage at Nara, and the vocabulary of the *araya-shiki* has remained part of Japanese religious and literary culture. It is therefore not an exotic import but a sediment of the culture in which the game was made, a heritage of the kind Chapter One placed between ambient discourse and hermeneutic resonance.

2.5 The ancestral commons: Yanagita Kunio and the Japanese dead

The second Japanese analogue is ethnological rather than doctrinal. In *Senzo no hanashi* (*About Our Ancestors*), written in 1945 under the air raids of the war's last months and published in 1946, the founder of Japanese folklore studies, Yanagita Kunio, reconstructed what he took to be the indigenous Japanese understanding of the dead. In his account the newly dead, still individual and still dangerous, are received by the household through a sequence of memorial observances stretching over years. At the final observance, the *tomurai-age*, held commonly in the thirty-third year, the individual dead person ceases to be remembered as an individual and merges into the collective ancestral spirit, the *sorei*, which dwells in the hills near the village, watches over the household, returns to visit at

the summer festival of Obon and at the New Year, and may in time be identified with the tutelary *kami* of the community. Robert J. Smith's ethnography of household ancestor rites documented the persistence of these practices in postwar Japan (Smith 1974).

The structure is strikingly close to the Lifestream's. In both, death begins as individuality and ends as communion; the individual dead are not preserved forever as themselves, nor are they annihilated, but dissolved into a protective commons that nourishes the living and periodically returns. The game transposes the ancestral commons of the household to planetary scale: the *ie* becomes the Planet, the hills become the Lifestream, Obon's visits become the final rising of the dead to save the living.

Yanagita's scheme also includes the dead who fail to become ancestors. The *muenbotoke*, the unconnected dead with no descendants to perform their rites, wander hungry and dangerous; the *goryō*, the vengeful spirits of those who died in rage or injustice, must be pacified by enshrinement lest they visit disaster on the living. In this light the Planet's cry acquires a precise sense. Shinra extracts the dead before they can complete their return; it performs no rites; it converts the ancestral commons into fuel. The cry Bugenhagen lets the party hear is the cry of dead who have been prevented from becoming ancestors. Chapter Four will read Sephiroth, conversely, as a *goryō* on a cosmic scale, a dead will that refuses dissolution and demands to rule.

The Japanese practice of *kuyō* extends this ethic beyond human kinship. Memorial observances are performed for animals; research institutions in Japan conduct memorial services for the laboratory animals sacrificed in their experiments; needles, dolls and other implements that have served the living are given rites before disposal. The world of *Final Fantasy VII* contains a laboratory, Hojo's, in which experimental subjects are numbered, bred and discarded, and in which no such acknowledgment is ever made. The absence is part of what the game asks its player to notice.

2.6 Dissolution and gathering: Lucretius, Freud and the colour green

The Lifestream reconciles two accounts of death usually held to be opposed. For Lucretius, following Epicurus, the soul is a fine material body that disperses at death like smoke, and the consolation of philosophy is that dispersion ends experience: where death is, we are not (*De rerum natura* III). For Yanagita's ancestors, death is a gathering into a community. The Lifestream is both at once. The person disperses, as Lucretius taught; what disperses is gathered, as the ancestral cult believed. Dissolution and communion are not alternatives but two descriptions of a single passage.

Freud's late speculation supplies a third description. In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) he proposed that organic life harbours a drive to return to the inorganic state from which it arose: *Das Ziel alles Lebens ist der Tod*, the aim of all life is death. The Lifestream transfigures the death drive into a homecoming. To die is to return to the source, but the source is not inorganic nullity; it is the living current from which life is again drawn.

What Freud figured as a regression to stillness the game figures as a re-entry into circulation.

Shinto vocabulary supplies a further register. The generative binding power the classical texts call *musubi* describes what the Lifestream does at birth; the polarity of pollution (*kegare*) and purification (*harae*, *misogi*) describes what it does to wounds and contamination. The Lifestream heals the Planet's wound and, in Cloud's case, washes away a counterfeit self. Its colour, finally, is not incidental. The Lifestream, mako and the materia of magic are all green, and the epilogue shows Midgar reclaimed by green growth. The medieval Benedictine Hildegard of Bingen gave a name to the divine vitality that greens the world: *viriditas*, greenness, the life-force by which creation flourishes. The game's palette is a theology of *viriditas*. Its green is the colour of the dead returning as life.

2.7 Materia: crystallized memory

Materia are condensations of the Lifestream, formed naturally where the current concentrates and produced artificially by Shinra's reactors, and the game describes them as containing the knowledge of the Ancients. To equip a materia is to draw on the Planet's power through the remembered knowledge of the dead. Three traditions illuminate the conception.

The first is Platonic. In the *Meno* (81c–d) and the *Phaedo* (72e–77a), Socrates argues that learning is recollection (*anamnēsis*): the soul, having existed before birth, already knows, and inquiry is the retrieval of what it has forgotten. Materia make anamnesis an object. Knowledge is not learned but equipped; the memory of the dead is slotted into a sword and grows with use. The game thereby literalizes Plato while inverting his ethics, for Socratic recollection is the soul's own labour, whereas materia are crystals one can buy, steal or manufacture.

The second is Kabbalistic. In the Lurianic Kabbalah of sixteenth-century Safed, as transmitted by Ḥayyim Vital and reconstructed by Gershom Scholem (1941), creation begins with a divine contraction (*tsimtsum*), proceeds through an emanation of light into vessels too fragile to contain it, and suffers a catastrophe, the breaking of the vessels (*shevirat ha-kelim*), which scatters sparks of divine light (*nitsotsot*) into the material world, where they are trapped in husks (*kelipot*). The human task of repair (*tikkun*) consists in raising the sparks. Materia are sparks in husks: fragments of the light of the dead encased in crystal and scattered across the world. The player who gathers them is engaged in a *tikkun* or a desecration, depending on what is done with them, a question Chapter Nine pursues.

The third is alchemical, and it lies in the name. *Materia* is the Latin of the alchemists' *prima materia*, the undifferentiated first matter from which the great work begins. The game's two decisive crystals, the Black Materia that summons Meteor and the White Materia that summons Holy, rehearse the first two stages of the alchemical opus, the black-

ening (*nigredo*) and the whitening (*albedo*), which C. G. Jung read as stages of psychic transformation (Jung 1944). Chapter Ten returns to the opus and its completion.

The materia system's colours encode a small ontology of knowledge. Magic materia, green, carry elemental knowledge; summon materia, red, carry the gods; command materia, yellow, carry techniques; independent materia, purple, alter the body; and support materia, blue, carry no power of their own but modify whatever materia they are linked to. Blue materia embody relational knowledge: knowledge that exists only in conjunction. When a materia reaches mastery, it gives birth to a new one. In this world even crystallized memory reproduces.

2.8 The Cetra: nomads, settlers and the Promised Land

Ifalna's history contains a fall narrative. The Cetra journeyed across the Planet, cultivating it and moving on, toward a Promised Land of supreme happiness that would be found at the journey's end. Some of them grew weary of travel, built houses and settled; these became the ancestors of humanity and lost the capacity to hear the Planet. The settled life is thus the origin of human deafness.

The narrative condenses several traditions. It recalls Rousseau's account of the origin of inequality: *Le premier qui, ayant enclos un terrain, s'avisa de dire: Ceci est à moi … fut le vrai fondateur de la société civile* (1755). It recalls Genesis, where Cain the tiller of the ground, having killed Abel the keeper of sheep, becomes the first builder of a city (Genesis 4:17); Midgar, the city founded on the dead, is a city of Cain. It anticipates by five years Daniel Quinn's *Ishmael* (1992), with its opposition between "Takers", the agricultural civilization that claims the world, and "Leavers", the peoples who live within it. And it maps onto the distinction Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari drew between nomadic and sedentary formations, between the smooth space traversed by the nomad and the striated space partitioned by the state (1980). Midgar, a city of plates, sectors, walls and checkpoints, is the most striated space in the game; the Cetra's journey is its smooth antithesis.

The Cetra also belong to a literary type: the elder race attuned to the world, fading as a younger race inherits it. Tolkien's Elves, departing into the West as the age of Men begins, are the canonical instance. The Cetra are reduced to a single survivor, and Aerith, unlike Tolkien's Arwen, does not choose mortality in order to remain; she is mortal already, and remains in order to pray.

The Promised Land itself is never shown. Its name invokes the land promised to Israel, a land given rather than taken (Exodus 3:8), and its attribute of supreme happiness echoes the Pure Land of Amida, Sukhāvatī, the Land of Bliss, rendered in Japanese as *gokuraku jōdo*, the Pure Land of Utmost Bliss, entered not by one's own power but through the Buddha's vow. Three readings of the Promised Land compete within the game, and they align with the modes of necrometabolism. President Shinra imagines it as a land so fertile it must overflow with mako and plans to build a Neo-Midgar upon it: the eschaton mis-

read as a frontier, in the manner of every colonial reading of a sacred geography as a resource. Sephiroth claims it as his inheritance and his throne. Only Aerith appears to understand it as a mode of return rather than a territory, and the game's ending suggests that the Promised Land is not a place to be found but a way of going home: the Lifestream itself, entered rightly.

2.9 The dead as medium

The Lifestream is thus a cosmology in which the dead are not elsewhere. They are not in a heaven or an underworld; they are the medium in which the living move, the energy that lights the city, the knowledge that empowers the sword, the substance from which every new body is drawn. In such a world there is no neutral act of power, knowledge or memory. Every act of illumination is a use of the dead; every act of learning is a borrowing from the dead; every self is a condensation of the dead. This is why the game's politics, psychology and theology cannot be separated. They are three names for one relation. The next chapter examines the first and most systematic perversion of that relation: the city that burns the dead for light.

CHAPTER THREE

III

Mako and Midgar

Enframing, Metabolic Rift and the Necrometabolic City

Shinra's crime is not technology as such but combustion without return: the conversion of the Planet's dead into a standing reserve of energy that is consumed and never given back. This chapter reads mako and Midgar as the paradigm of the combustive mode of necrometabolism. It proceeds from the name of the substance to the philosophy of technology, from Wagner's *Ring* to Marx's metabolic rift, from the vertical city of modernist dystopia to the radial geometry of Midgar's plan, and finally to the Japanese industrial history against which the game's depiction of a corporation that poisons, conceals and compensates acquires its full weight.

3.1 Mako: demonic radiance

The English word *mako* transliterates a Japanese compound, 魔晄, whose first character means demon, magic or the uncanny and whose second means brightness or radiance. The localization lost the demon. In the Japanese text the energy that lights Midgar is named, in every utterance, as a demonic or magical radiance, and its source is the spirit energy of the dead. The name concedes what the company's advertising conceals: that its light is unholy.

Mako appears in three material roles. As energy, it is drawn from the Lifestream by eight reactors and distributed through Midgar; the land surrounding the city is grey and barren, drained of the life the reactors draw off. As weapon, it is concentrated in the great cannons of Junon and, later, in the Sister Ray, a mako cannon fed by all eight reactors at once. As infusion, it is pumped into the bodies of SOLDIER operatives, whose eyes thereafter glow with its light. The third role is the most revealing. SOLDIER are living bodies in which the radiance of the dead has been installed; their strength is borrowed from the dead, and excess exposure produces mako poisoning, a dissolution of the self into the flood of alien memory that the current carries. Cloud's catatonia at Mideel is a clinical form of what Midgar suffers as a city: too much of the dead, taken in without mourning.

3.2 *Gestell* and the net cast over the gods

Martin Heidegger's lecture "Die Frage nach der Technik" (delivered in 1953, published 1954) remains the most penetrating account of what Shinra does. Technology, Heidegger argued, is not merely an instrument but a mode of revealing, a way in which beings come to show themselves. Ancient craft brought things forth (*hervorbringen*); modern technology challenges them forth (*herausfordern*), setting upon nature with the demand that it supply energy that can be extracted, stored, switched about and distributed. What is revealed by this challenging is no longer an object standing over against us but *Bestand*, standing-reserve, available on demand. The essence of modern technology, which is nothing technological, Heidegger called *Gestell*, enframing: the gathering of all setting-upon that orders the real as standing-reserve. His central example is a hydroelectric plant on

the Rhine, which no longer stands in the river as an old wooden bridge did but dams the river into itself, so that the Rhine appears as a supplier of water pressure. He contrasts it with the Rhine of Hölderlin's hymn.

Final Fantasy VII carries Heidegger's analysis one step further than he could take it. In his account the danger of enframing is that it will at last order human beings themselves as standing-reserve, as "human resources". In the game the step has already been taken, and in a form more absolute than Heidegger imagined: what is enframed is not the river but the dead. The ancestral commons, the medium of all life and memory, appears in Midgar as a supplier of electrical power. Every person who has ever died on the Planet has become, in principle, Shinra's stock.

The corporate name performs the analysis in two characters. Shinra is written 神羅: the character for divinity or spirit (神) joined to a character (羅) meaning silk gauze, a net, or to set out in a row. In sound it is identical to the *shinra* of the classical compound *shinra banshō* (森羅万象), the whole array of creation, all things in heaven and earth. The company's name thus says, with a precision no allegory could improve, what Heidegger's *Gestell* names: a net cast over the gods, an arrangement of all creation as stock. The German *Gestell* means, in ordinary usage, a frame, rack or stand; the Japanese 羅 means a net or an array. Both name the apparatus by which things are set in order for use.

The coincidence becomes almost unbearable in the composition of Shinra's executive board, whose head of security, a bellicose militarist charged with the company's armed force, is named Heidegger. Nothing suggests that the makers intended a philosophical joke, and the name probably served as German-sounding colour, as did others in the cast. But the effect, read at Tier III, is that of an inscription. The name of the philosopher who diagnosed enframing is set on the board of enframing, attached to its most brutal function; and the setting recalls the philosopher's own history, his membership of the National Socialist party from 1933 until 1945, his rectorship at Freiburg in 1933–34, during which he placed the authority of philosophy at the service of the new regime, his postwar refusal to repudiate it in plain terms, and the antisemitic passages in the private notebooks published from 2014 as the Black Notebooks (*Schwarze Hefte*). The thinker of the apparatus who served an apparatus survives in the game as its servant. The irony is not that Shinra has misread Heidegger, but that Heidegger's name, emptied of his thought, has been absorbed into the very standing-reserve he described.

3.3 The gold of the Rhine: Wagner's *Ring*

If Heidegger's Rhine is dammed, Wagner's is robbed. In *Das Rheingold* (1869; the cycle complete 1876) the dwarf Alberich renounces love in order to seize the gold guarded by the Rhine daughters, descends to the subterranean realm of Nibelheim and there forges a ring that confers mastery of the world, enslaving his people to mine and smith for him. The god Wotan, who has contracted with giants to build his fortress Valhalla, steals the

ring to pay his debt. In the prologue to *Götterdämmerung*, the Norns recall an older wound: Wotan broke a branch from the World Ash Tree to make the spear on which his treaties are carved, and the tree sickened and the spring beneath it ran dry; later he had the dying tree felled and its logs heaped around Valhalla, which burns at the cycle's end.

The *Ring* was read as an allegory of industrial capitalism almost from the start. George Bernard Shaw's *The Perfect Wagnerite* (1898) made Alberich a plutocrat and Nibelheim a factory of sweated labour. *Final Fantasy VII* takes the names Midgar and Nibelheim from the Norse cosmology that Wagner also drew upon, and its structure answers his at point after point. The Lifestream is both the gold of the Rhine and the sap of the World Ash Tree: a natural treasure seized for power, and a vital current whose wounding withers the world. Shinra combines Alberich's renunciation of love for mastery with Wotan's contractual sovereignty, financing its fortress (the Shinra Building, Midgar's Valhalla) with what it has stolen from the source. And Nibelheim, in the game, is the place where a man descends into a basement library, discovers the documents of his own manufacture and burns the village down: Wagner's smithy of the ring transposed into a smithy of the self.

The decisive correspondence lies in the endings. The *Ring* closes when Brünnhilde returns the ring to the Rhine. The river rises, the Rhine daughters reclaim the gold, the curse is lifted by restitution, and Valhalla burns. Wagner's cosmic drama resolves not through victory but through *return*: what was taken from the stream goes back to it. *Final Fantasy VII* closes when the Lifestream rises from the earth, converges on Midgar and drives back Meteor, and the epilogue shows the city of the reactors overgrown. The two works share an ethical structure that the rest of this dissertation will call anamnetic: the curse of extraction is lifted only by return to the source.

3.4 Metabolic rift, general economy and fossil capital

Marx's account of the metabolic interchange (*Stoffwechsel*) between humans and nature, developed in the first and third volumes of *Capital* (1867, 1894) under the influence of Liebig's agricultural chemistry, describes capitalist agriculture as a system that removes the constituents of the soil to the cities in the form of food and fibre and never returns them, producing at once the exhaustion of the land and the pollution of the town. Foster's reconstruction of the argument as a theory of metabolic rift (2000) has made it a foundation of ecological Marxism. Midgar is a metabolic rift rendered as a city plan. The current of the dead is drawn from beneath the land, converted into light and heat in the city, and dissipated; nothing returns; the land around the city dies. The rift is temporal as well as spatial. The Lifestream is the accumulated vitality of every generation that has ever lived; Shinra consumes in decades what the Planet gathered over millennia.

Georges Bataille's general economy, set out in *La Part maudite* (1949), supplies a complementary frame. For Bataille the fundamental fact of life on earth is excess: the sun gives energy without return, and living systems inevitably accumulate a surplus that

must be expended, whether gloriously in festival, art and sacrifice or catastrophically in war. A restricted economy, which seeks only accumulation and utility, does not abolish the surplus; it defers its expenditure until it erupts as catastrophe. Shinra is a restricted economy in Bataille's sense, converting everything into productive use, and its surplus erupts accordingly as military expenditure, in the Junon cannon and the Sister Ray. The Planet, by contrast, behaves at the climax as a general economy. The rising of the Lifestream is a lavish, unconditional outpouring of the dead, spent without reserve to save the world.

Andreas Malm's history of fossil capital adds a distinction the game embodies in its very vocabulary. Malm argues that the nineteenth-century British transition from water power to coal-fired steam was driven less by efficiency than by the advantages a stock of energy gave to capital over a flow: coal could be transported, stored and burned wherever labour was cheapest and most controllable, while rivers could not be moved (Malm 2016). The Lifestream is, by name, a stream, a flow. Mako is a stock: drawn off, condensed, tanked, piped, fired from cannons. Shinra's founding act is the conversion of a flow of the dead into a stock of fuel, which is the founding act of fossil modernity.

3.5 Disenchantment upside down: Weber's iron cage

Max Weber's account of modernity turned on two images. In the lecture "Wissenschaft als Beruf" (delivered 1917, published 1919) he described the *Entzauberung der Welt*, the disenchantment of the world: the conviction that there are in principle no mysterious incalculable forces, that all things can be mastered by calculation. In *Die protestantische Ethik und der Geist des Kapitalismus* (1904–05) he described the rationalized economic order as a *stahlhartes Gehäuse*, a casing hard as steel, rendered in English as the iron cage.

Midgar literalizes the second image and inverts the first. Its upper city stands on a steel plate that hangs over the slums like a lid: a casing hard as steel in the most concrete sense, which shuts out the sky. Yet the rationalized order that the plate supports runs on magic. In this world enchantment has not vanished from modern life; it has been captured, refined and piped. Disenchantment appears not as the absence of magic but as its conversion into utility, the reduction of the sacred to a calculable supply. The re-enchantment Morris Berman called for in 1981 would then consist not in the return of magic, which never left, but in the restoration of its agency. That is precisely what the ending stages: the dead cease to be a supply and become, once again, actors.

3.6 The domination of nature and the domination of human beings

Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer's *Dialektik der Aufklärung* (1944, revised 1947) argued that the enlightenment project of mastering nature through instrumental reason ends by mastering human beings, including the masters themselves, and that the subject

who dominates nature must first dominate the nature within. Shinra is a working model of the dialectic. The domination of the Planet in the reactors is reproduced as the domination of the poor in the slums, of bodies in SOLDIER, of experimental subjects in Hojo's laboratory and of a neighbouring nation in the Wutai War. The logic is the same at every scale: what lives is treated as material for the purposes of power. C. S. Lewis's *The Abolition of Man* (1943) made the same diagnosis from a different tradition, arguing that humanity's conquest of nature culminates in the conquest of humanity by a caste of "Conditioners" who have stepped outside all value; Hojo is a Conditioner in the strict sense. Chapter Four follows the dialectic to its second movement, Adorno and Horkheimer's claim that enlightenment reverts to mythology, in the figure of the god Shinra's science manufactured.

3.7 The vertical city: *Metropolis*, Morlocks, Omelas and Faust

Midgar's spatial form belongs to a lineage of vertical cities. Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927) set the gardens of a ruling class above an underground city of workers who feed a machine the film depicts, in a hallucination, as the devouring idol Moloch; at its centre rises the master's headquarters, the New Tower of Babel. H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895) had already projected class into vertical speciation, with the delicate Eloi above and the subterranean Morlocks below. Midgar unites both: an upper city of affluence on the plate, slums of rust and scrap beneath, and at the hub a tower from which the company rules. Its Moloch is not a machine that consumes workers but eight reactors that consume the dead.

Ursula K. Le Guin's parable "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) describes a city whose perfect happiness depends on the misery of a single child kept in a basement, a condition every citizen learns and most accept. Midgar is Omelas made legible: the brightness of the plate depends on the darkness beneath it and, below the slums, on the suffering of the Planet. Le Guin's parable ends with those who, learning the truth, walk away from the city into a place the narrator cannot describe. The party, too, walks away from Midgar into the world, and the game, like the parable, leaves the destination undescribed.

The most exact precedent for Shinra's violence, however, is Goethe's. In the fifth act of *Faust II* (1832) the aged Faust has become a developer, reclaiming land from the sea on a vast scale. An old couple, Philemon and Baucis, refuse to leave their cottage and chapel, which stand in the way of his panorama. Faust orders them removed; Mephistopheles and his henchmen burn the cottage with the couple inside; Faust, hearing of it, protests that he wanted an exchange, not a robbery. Marshall Berman read the episode as the tragedy of development, in which the modernizing will sweeps away whatever impedes it while disclaiming responsibility for the means (Berman 1982). The collapse of the Sector 7 plate, ordered by Shinra to destroy AVALANCHE together with the slum that sheltered it and then blamed on AVALANCHE itself, is Philemon and Baucis at the scale of a district.

Reeve, Shinra's head of urban development, the one executive in whom the game develops a conscience and who eventually turns against the company, is the developer's conscience arriving, as Faust's does, too late to save the cottage.

Watsuji Tetsurō's *Fūdo* (1935) argued that human self-understanding is formed through climate and milieu, the *fūdo* in which a people dwells. The slums beneath the plate are a milieu without sky; their heaven is a ceiling of steel. When Aerith, who grew up there, finally stands under the open sky, she confesses that it frightens her. The detail measures the deformation Midgar works on the human being. A person raised beneath the casing hard as steel experiences the heavens as a threat.

3.8 Panopticon and anti-mandala

Midgar's plan is radial: a disc divided into eight sectors, each with its reactor, around a central tower. Two diagrams share this geometry, and the city superimposes them.

The first is Jeremy Bentham's Panopticon (1791), a prison of cells arranged around a central inspection tower from which every inmate can be observed without knowing when, a design Michel Foucault made the emblem of disciplinary power (Foucault 1975). The Shinra Building is Midgar's inspection tower: the highest point in the city, at its exact centre, housing the president's office at its summit and the apparatus of surveillance, the Turks and the department of public security, within. Midgar is a city designed to be seen from its centre.

The second is the Womb Realm mandala (Taizōkai mandara) of Shingon esoteric Buddhism, transmitted to Japan by Kūkai in the ninth century. At its heart lies the Central Dais of Eight Petals (*chūdai hachiyō-in*): the cosmic Buddha Mahāvairocana, in Japanese Dainichi Nyorai, the Great Sun, seated at the centre of a lotus, with four buddhas and four bodhisattvas on its eight petals. The mandala is a cosmogram of radiation, the light of the Great Sun emanating outward through the eight directions to all beings.

Midgar takes the mandala's geometry and reverses its flow. Where the Great Sun at the centre of the lotus radiates light to the eight directions, the tower at the centre of Midgar draws a demonic radiance inward from eight reactors. The sacred cosmogram becomes a machine of extraction and inspection; the womb becomes a sink. Midgar is an anti-mandala, a black sun. The reading is Tier III, and no claim is made that the designers had the Taizōkai in view. But the superimposition is exact, and it states in a single figure the chapter's argument: modernity has not abolished the sacred order of the cosmos but inverted its direction, so that what once gave now takes.

3.9 Shinra as polity

Shinra is not a company within a state; it is the state. It maintains its own army in SOLDIER and its infantry, its own police and intelligence service in the Turks and the depart-

ment of public security, its own space programme, weapons division, urban planning department and scientific establishment. Midgar has a mayor, but he is a figurehead without power. Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) described the sovereign as an artificial person composed of the multitude it protects; Shinra is a privatized Leviathan, sovereign by virtue of controlling the energy on which every life in its domain depends.

The Japanese referent most often proposed is the prewar *zaibatsu*, the family-controlled conglomerates (Mitsui, Mitsubishi, Sumitomo, Yasuda) that combined finance, industry, mining and trade and stood close to the state and the military, dissolved under the Allied Occupation and partly reconstituted as the postwar *keiretsu*. The domestic energy order supplies a second referent: regional electric utilities with monopoly franchises, deep political influence and, in the nuclear field, a nexus of utilities, ministries, manufacturers and academics later given the derisive name of the "nuclear village". On 11 March 2011 an earthquake and tsunami caused meltdowns in three reactors at the Tokyo Electric Power Company's Fukushima Daiichi plant, and more than 150,000 people were evacuated. In 2012 the National Diet's Fukushima Nuclear Accident Independent Investigation Commission, the first independent commission chartered by the parliament, concluded that the accident was the result of collusion between the government, the regulators and TEPCO, described the relation between the regulator and the company as regulatory capture, and, in the words of its chairman, Kurokawa Kiyoshi, called it "a profoundly man-made disaster" that might have been foreseen and prevented. TEPCO's own investigation placed greater weight on the unforeseen scale of the tsunami. After the disaster, Japanese and international audiences read the game, and especially its 2020 remake, as uncannily prescient. This is reception, not genealogy, and it is recorded here as such; but reception is part of a work's life, and the game's prescience lies in its structural grasp of how an energy sovereign behaves.

The executive board reads as an allegory of the faculties of the technocratic state. President Shinra governs by money; his son Rufus, succeeding him, announces that he will govern by fear, restating in a sentence Machiavelli's counsel that *è molto più sicuro essere temuto che amato*, it is much safer to be feared than loved (*Il Principe*, ch. 17). Heidegger commands force; Scarlet develops weapons; Palmer directs a space programme starved of funds, the vestige of an ambition to leave the Planet rather than live on it; Reeve plans the city and harbours its conscience; Hojo directs science and embodies the abolition of man. The Turks, the company's agents of abduction, surveillance and killing, perform their work with professional courtesy and, on one memorable occasion in Wutai, decline to fight the party because they are on holiday. Hannah Arendt's phrase for the moral structure of such functionaries, the banality of evil (Arendt 1963), describes them exactly: evil done not from demonic conviction but from the thoughtless performance of a role.

The Sector 7 plate drop, approved by President Shinra and carried out by the Turks, with Reno triggering the plate's emergency release at the sector's support pillar, is the board's defining act. It exhibits what Mbembe calls necropolitics, the sovereign decision over which populations may be made to die (Mbembe 2003), joined to a second operation: the manufacture of an enemy to whom the deaths are attributed. Shinra broadcasts that terrorists destroyed the sector. The company that burns the dead for light also writes the history of the dead it makes.

3.10 Japanese industrial memory: Minamata, Corel, Nibelheim

The pattern of Shinra's conduct toward the communities it harms (contamination, denial, concealment, compensation, erasure) is the pattern of modern Japanese industrial pollution. From 1932 to 1968 the Chisso Corporation's factory at Minamata discharged methylmercury, a by-product of acetaldehyde production, into Minamata Bay. The poisoning it caused in fishing communities, neurological damage, deaths and the congenital disease of children exposed in the womb, was officially identified in 1956. In 1959 the company's own physician, Hosokawa Hajime, showed in experiments on cats that the factory's effluent produced the disease, and the result was kept within the company. The same year Chisso offered victims small "sympathy payments" (*mimaikin*) under a contract that barred further claims even if the factory were later proven to be the cause. The state formally acknowledged the cause only in 1968, and in 1973 the Kumamoto District Court held Chisso liable and declared the 1959 contract void (George 2001; Walker 2010). Minamata and the other major pollution diseases made the poisoning of the periphery by the industrial centre one of the defining narratives of postwar Japan.

Barret's history condenses this narrative. Corel was a coal-mining town; Shinra offered to build a mako reactor; Barret championed the project for the prosperity it promised; an accident occurred; Shinra, blaming the townspeople, sent troops to burn Corel, killing Barret's wife and maiming him and his friend Dyne. The episode recalls, at Tier II, the logic of the 1974 laws that subsidized towns hosting power plants, and the longer arc of Japan's energy transition, in which coal communities, after the great Mitsui Miike labour struggle of 1959–60, were abandoned in favour of imported oil and nuclear power. Barret's guilt is the guilt of a community that accepted the reactor.

The treatment of Nibelheim completes the pattern with an act of erasure. After the fire, Shinra rebuilt the village and populated it with employees instructed to behave as though nothing had happened; Cloud and Tifa return to find their burned home restored and inhabited by strangers performing normality. Jean Baudrillard's account of the simulacrum, a copy that conceals the absence of an original (1981), describes the rebuilt Nibelheim precisely. It is a memorial without mourning, a counterfeit of a town, built to make the dead disappear. The parallel with Cloud's counterfeit self, examined in Chapter Five, is exact: both are reconstructions that conceal a catastrophe by staging the life it ended.

The Gold Saucer adds spectacle to erasure. Built by an entertainment magnate above the desert where Shinra's outcasts are confined in Corel Prison, it offers races, arenas and theatre directly over the dispossessed. Guy Debord's society of the spectacle (1967), in which social relations are mediated by images and leisure becomes the continuation of domination by other means, and Baudrillard's reading of Disneyland as an imaginary space that conceals the hyperreality of the society around it, both find their figure in the amusement park above the prison.

3.11 Combustive necrometabolism

The combustive mode can now be stated with precision. What it takes from the dead is energy, their accumulated vitality stripped of memory and singularity. What it returns is nothing: exhaust, waste, barren ground, the crushed rubble of a sector. It treats the singularity of the dead with indifference, converting persons into an undifferentiated supply and the living into numbered resources. Its temporality is the linear time of progress, which is also the time of depletion, a line running from accumulation to exhaustion. Its essence is the refusal of mourning in its most banal form. The dead are not lost to Shinra; they are used up.

The combustive mode does not remain alone. Shinra's science, in pursuit of a living Cetra who could lead it to the Promised Land's imagined reserves, injected the cells of an alien calamity into an unborn child. The child became Sephiroth. The next chapter follows the dialectic by which the combustive mode, enlightenment's domination of nature, begot the sovereign mode, its reversion to myth.

CHAPTER FOUR

IV

Sephiroth and Jenova

False Gnosis, Melancholic Apotheosis and the Counterfeit Dead

Sephiroth and Jenova embody the two remaining pathologies of the relation to the dead. Sephiroth would incorporate the totality of the dead and become a god; Jenova wears the faces of the dead in order to colonize the living. The first is sovereignty over the dead, the second their counterfeit. This chapter argues that the two modes are complementary halves of a single apparatus; that Sephiroth is the product of the combustive science described in Chapter Three, so that enlightenment's domination of nature reverts, in him, to myth; that his revelation has the form of Gnostic illumination and the content of a forgery; and that his madness has the precise structure Freud called melancholia, a refusal of mourning in which the lost object is incorporated into the self. Raised to cosmic scale, melancholia becomes the sovereign-incorporative mode: the will to swallow all the dead rather than lose any.

4.1 A singular person with a plural name

In the Kabbalah the *sefirot* (singular *sefirah*) are the ten attributes or emanations through which the infinite, *Ein Sof*, manifests itself: Keter, Ḥokhmah, Binah, Ḥesed, Gevurah, Tiferet, Netsaḥ, Hod, Yesod and Malkhut. The term first appears as ten primordial "numbers" in the *Sefer Yetsirah*, a text of disputed antiquity, and the doctrine reaches its classical elaboration in the *Zohar*, composed in thirteenth-century Castile and attributed by modern scholarship chiefly to Moses de León (Scholem 1941). The sefirot are arranged as a tree and, in a correlated image, as the body of *Adam Kadmon*, the primordial human through whom the divine structure is figured.

The game's antagonist bears this name, and the name is plural. A single person is called by a word that means many emanations. The grammar is prophetic. Sephiroth is in fact a multitude: his cells are distributed through the numbered, black-robed men who stagger across the world toward the Northern Crater; his shape is worn by Jenova's body through most of the game; his will gathers the dispersed fragments of Jenova in what Hojo calls the Reunion, the tendency of separated Jenova cells to converge. The figure who seems the most sovereignly singular character in the work is a plurality held together by will, a Legion in the sense of the Gerasene demoniac: *My name is Legion: for we are many* (Mark 5:9). He is also, in the Kabbalistic correlate, an engineered Adam Kadmon, a primordial man manufactured in a laboratory to embody the divine structure in flesh.

Lurianic Kabbalah adds a darker image. In Isaac Luria's cosmogony the vessels formed to receive the divine light could not contain it and shattered, scattering sparks into the husks of the material world (Chapter Two). Sephiroth is a shattered vessel, a body made to contain a power that exceeded it, whose breaking scatters catastrophe. The names of his final forms extend the series of borrowings. The penultimate, Bizarro·Sephiroth, takes its prefix from the imperfect, inverted duplicate of Superman introduced in American comics in 1958: the god-aspirant passes, on the way to apotheosis, through the stage of

the defective copy. The final form, Safer·Sephiroth, has been connected by commentators to the Hebrew *sefer*, book, as in *Sefer Yetsirah*. The etymology is conjectural and is offered as such, but the image it yields is exact: a man who was made by reading ends as a book.

4.2 The library of origins: Frankenstein in Nibelheim

The scene that makes Sephiroth is a scene of reading. In the flashback of the Nibelheim incident, after discovering in the town's mako reactor the pods in which SOLDIER had been mutated into monsters, Sephiroth descends into the basement library of the Shinra Mansion and reads, for days, the reports of the Jenova Project. He emerges convinced that he was made from Jenova, whom the reports describe as an Ancient; that the Cetra were destroyed by a calamity while the ancestors of humanity hid and survived; and that the Planet belongs by right to the Cetra and therefore to him. He calls the specimen his mother. He sets the village on fire.

The structure repeats, with an exactness worth spelling out, the central revelation of Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818). The Creature, having taken clothing from Victor's laboratory, finds in its pocket the papers in which Victor recorded the progress of his work, and so learns the circumstances of his own manufacture. He has already educated himself on Milton's *Paradise Lost*, Plutarch's *Lives* and Goethe's *Werther*, and he identifies by turns with Adam, the creature abandoned by his maker, and with Satan, the creature who envies the happiness of others. Rejected by the De Lacey family, whom he has secretly served, he burns their cottage, and his vengeance against his maker begins. In both texts a manufactured being learns its origin from documents written by its makers; the discovery is a trauma of authorship, the realization that one's being was another's project; and the response is incendiary.

The divergence is equally instructive. Shelley's Creature reads truly. Sephiroth misreads. Jenova is not an Ancient but the calamity that destroyed the Ancients, and the lineage on which he founds his sovereignty is a forgery produced by the error of his makers. The modern Prometheus stole fire; Sephiroth steals a counterfeit fire and believes it true.

4.3 Enlightenment reverts to mythology

Adorno and Horkheimer compressed the dialectic of enlightenment into two propositions: myth is already enlightenment, and enlightenment reverts to mythology (1944/1947). The Jenova Project is the second proposition rendered as a research programme. Shinra's scientists, Gast and then Hojo, set out to manufacture an Ancient because only an Ancient could lead the company to the Promised Land, which it imagined as a reserve of mako. Instrumental reason, in pursuit of a resource, undertook to produce by technique a being capable of reading a myth. What it produced was a being who became the myth: a self-proclaimed god, the antagonist of the Planet, the cosmic will whose

theme is sung in medieval Latin by a choir. The laboratory became a theogony. The combustive mode of Chapter Three begot the sovereign mode of this chapter, and the begetting was literal.

Hojo is the type of the scientist through whom the reversion occurs. He belongs to the lineage of Victor Frankenstein and of H. G. Wells's Doctor Moreau (1896), who carves animals into simulacra of human beings on an island beyond law. He belongs also, by an onomastic accident the dissertation has already met twice, to the line of Faust's famulus Wagner, who in the laboratory scene of *Faust II* produces the Homunculus, an artificial man in a glass phial. Hojo's final act, injecting himself with Jenova cells and fighting the party in successively monstrous forms atop the Sister Ray, belongs to the tradition of Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886), in which the experimenter becomes his own specimen. His laboratory numbers its subjects (Red XIII is a designation, not a name; the clones bear tattooed numerals), as the government scientists of Ōtomo Katsuhiro's *Akira* number the psychic children in their custody. The numbering has a history, and Japan's part in it is precise. From the late 1930s until 1945 the Imperial Japanese Army's Unit 731, commanded by the army physician Ishii Shirō from a complex at Pingfang near Harbin in occupied Manchuria, conducted lethal experiments on prisoners, most of them Chinese and others Russian, Korean and Mongolian, whom the unit's staff called *maruta*, "logs". Prisoners were deliberately infected with plague, anthrax, cholera and other diseases, exposed to freezing to study frostbite, and subjected to vivisection; thousands died in the complex, and the unit's field operations, which spread plague among Chinese towns, killed many more, in numbers still disputed (Harris 1994). After the war the American occupation authorities granted the unit's leaders immunity from prosecution in exchange for their research data, and only a Soviet military tribunal at Khabarovsk in 1949 tried some of its members. Many of its physicians resumed careers in Japanese universities, medicine and industry. One of them, Naitō Ryōichi, founded the Japan Blood Bank, which became the Green Cross Corporation; Kitano Masaji, who had commanded the unit in the war's last years, later served as a director there, and Green Cross was the firm at the centre of the contaminated-blood scandal discussed below. The other modern emblem of persons turned into numbers is the serial number tattooed on prisoners at Auschwitz, where the SS physician Josef Mengele selected prisoners, twins above all, for experiments. To set a fictional laboratory beside these crimes is not to measure the one against the other, which would be obscene, but to name the historical grammar the fiction speaks: a science that renames persons as numbered material. No claim is made that the makers intended these references; the history belongs to the ambient field in which such a laboratory could be imagined. What can be said with certainty is that Hojo's laboratory is the place in the game where no *kuyō* is ever performed: the subjects are bred, mutated, discarded and forgotten.

4.4 False gnosis

The content of Sephiroth's revelation has the form of Gnostic illumination. In the classical Gnostic myth preserved in the *Apocryphon of John*, one of the codices recovered at Nag Hammadi in 1945, the transcendent Father emanates a pleroma of divine aeons; one of them, Sophia, conceives without her consort and produces a malformed being, Yaldabaoth, a lion-faced serpent, who creates the material cosmos, rules it through archons and boasts in ignorance that he is the only god. Sparks of the divine are trapped in human bodies, and salvation comes through *gnōsis*, the knowledge of one's true origin beyond the cosmos, which awakens the pneumatic few and sets them above the merely psychic or material majority.

Sephiroth's experience in the library follows this pattern point by point. He acquires secret knowledge of an origin beyond the ordinary human order; the knowledge elevates him above the humans around him, whom he now regards as usurpers and traitors; it produces in him the Gnostic sense of being a stranger in the world. But his gnosis is a forgery. The origin he discovers is not divine but parasitic, and the knowledge that seems to liberate him binds him to an alien entity. In Gnostic terms he has mistaken the archon for the Father. Jenova is the true intruder, the calamity from outside the cosmos that wounds the Planet and deceives its children; Sephiroth, believing himself its master, is its instrument, at least until the end, when the relation inverts and the will is revealed as his.

Hans Jonas, who wrote the classic modern study of Gnosticism before turning to the philosophy of life and the ethics of technology, argued that the Gnostic experience of the cosmos as alien and hostile anticipates modern nihilism and its existentialist articulations (Jonas 1958). Sephiroth's acosmism has this nihilistic character. He does not want to inhabit the Planet; he wants to use it. His stated plan is to wound the Planet with Meteor so that its spirit energy gathers at the wound, to place himself at the point of convergence, to absorb the energy and become a god, and thereafter to ride the Planet as a vessel through the cosmos as Jenova once did. Eric Voegelin described the modern mass movements as Gnostic attempts to immanentize the eschaton, to realize the final perfection of history within history through human action (Voegelin 1952). Sephiroth's project immanentizes the eschaton in the most literal sense: it brings the end down from the sky and stands at its centre.

The ambient discourse of 1995 supplied a recent and terrible instance of the logic. Robert Jay Lifton's study of Aum Shinrikyō bears the title *Destroying the World to Save It* (1999). Aum's founder, Asahara Shōkō, proclaimed himself a saviour and, in the early 1990s, published a book declaring himself the Christ; he recruited scientists to manufacture sarin, fused esoteric Buddhist and Christian apocalyptic motifs with Nostradamian prophecy and sought to force the end of the world in order to purify it. Lifton gives particular attention to the movement's use of the term *poa*, its rendering of the Tibetan Buddhist *phowa*, a meditative practice for transferring consciousness at the moment of

death, which Asahara turned into a doctrine that killing could benefit the victim's soul. The doctrine served to justify the movement's killings, among them the murder of the lawyer Sakamoto Tsutsumi and his wife and infant son in 1989, the sarin attack in Matsumoto in 1994 and the attack on the Tokyo subway in 1995. It is a necrometabolic perversion in the strict sense of this study, in which the killer claims to administer the souls of the dead for their own good. Asahara and twelve of his followers were executed in July 2018. No claim of influence is made here; the game's scenario was largely set before the attack's implications were understood. But the shape of Sephiroth's project, a self-deified will hastening apocalypse as a path to transcendence, was a shape Japanese society had just encountered in its own subway.

4.5 The Luciferian ascent

Sephiroth's ambition has a scriptural template. Isaiah's taunt against the king of Babylon, read by Christian tradition as the fall of Lucifer, gives it in five clauses: *How art thou fallen from heaven, O Lucifer, son of the morning! … For thou hast said in thine heart, I will ascend into heaven, I will exalt my throne above the stars of God … I will be like the most High* (Isaiah 14:12–14). Milton's Satan *trusted to have equall'd the most High* (*Paradise Lost* I.40) and declares it better to reign in Hell than serve in Heaven (I.263). The single black wing that gives Sephiroth's battle theme its title is the iconography of the fallen angel, and its singularity matters: one wing is a sign of incompletion. The angel with one wing cannot fly.

Friedrich Nietzsche's *Übermensch* is the modern figure most often invoked, and the comparison clarifies by contrast. Zarathustra's first teaching is that the overman is the meaning of the earth, and his first exhortation is fidelity to it: *Der Übermensch ist der Sinn der Erde … bleibt der Erde treu* (*Also sprach Zarathustra*, Prologue §3). Sephiroth's ambition is infidelity to the earth in its purest form: he would drain the Planet and leave it. He is not a Nietzschean but an anti-Zarathustra, a Gnostic who wears the costume of the overman. His self-justification, moreover, borrows the grammar Nietzsche analysed as ressentiment, the revaluation of values born from the grievance of the dispossessed (*Zur Genealogie der Moral* I.10). He presents himself as the heir of a wronged people whose world was stolen. The grievance is borrowed, the lineage counterfeit, and the slave revolt's grammar is placed in the service of a master's will.

Kierkegaard's typology of despair completes the portrait and anticipates the next chapter. *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) distinguishes despair in weakness, not willing to be oneself, from despair in defiance, willing to be oneself as a self of one's own making, which refuses any power that established it. Sephiroth is despair in defiance: the self that would be its own creator and the creator of all. Cloud, as Chapter Five shows, is despair in weakness. The game's antagonist and protagonist embody the two forms of the same sickness.

4.6 Melancholic apotheosis

In "Trauer und Melancholie" (1917) Freud distinguished two responses to loss. In mourning, reality-testing shows that the loved object no longer exists, and the libido is withdrawn from it, slowly and painfully, until the ego is free to love again. In melancholia the loss is not acknowledged; the ego, unable to let the object go, identifies with it and installs it within itself. Freud's image for the process is one of the most famous sentences in psychoanalysis: *Der Schatten des Objekts fiel so auf das Ich*, thus the shadow of the object fell upon the ego. Melancholia is incorporation in place of mourning.

Sephiroth's lost object is a mother he never knew. His biological mother, Lucrecia Crescent, was separated from him at birth and never held him; the mother named in the reports is a headless alien corpse in a tank. His discovery in the library is the discovery of a maternal absence, and his response is not mourning but incorporation. He severs Jenova's head and carries it. He speaks of her will as his own. By the end the relation has inverted entirely: the dispersed fragments of Jenova converge not on Jenova but on him, and Jenova becomes his instrument. The shadow of the object has fallen upon the ego until no difference remains. The melancholia is doubly false, for the object incorporated was never his mother. Meanwhile his real mother is preserved, unseen by him, in a crystal cave behind a waterfall, where she grieves him without end. Mother and son are paired melancholics who never meet.

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok extended Freud's theory with the concept of the phantom: a gap in the psyche of a subject left by a secret belonging to a parent, a buried shame that speaks through the descendant without ever being known (Abraham and Torok 1978). Sephiroth is haunted by a phantom in their exact sense. The secret of his manufacture belongs to Hojo and Lucrecia, and it returns to him not through memory but through documents, in the voice of the library. What drives him mad is not his own past but theirs.

The sovereign-incorporative mode is melancholia raised to sovereignty. Where the ordinary melancholic incorporates one lost object, Sephiroth would incorporate all of them: the whole Lifestream, every dead person who has ever lived on the Planet. His plan is a refusal of loss on a cosmic scale. Nothing is to be let go, because everything is to be swallowed.

The image of the severed maternal head carries further resonances. Perseus bears the head of Medusa, whose gaze turns onlookers to stone, and Freud read the Medusa's head as an image of terror whose display is apotropaic ("Das Medusenhaupt", written 1922, published 1940). Jenova's head is likewise a weapon: through its cells it controls those who bear them. Julia Kristeva's account of the abject maternal (1980) and Barbara Creed's analysis of the monstrous-feminine in horror cinema (1993) describe the cultural logic by which the maternal body, headless and suspended in fluid, becomes the image of a horror

that is also an origin. The game's gendering of the calamity as "Mother" belongs to that logic, and Chapter Ten returns to it critically.

Japanese religious history offers the most precise analogue for Sephiroth's post-mortem condition. Chapter Two noted that in Yanagita's scheme some dead fail to become ancestors, and that among them the *goryō*, the vengeful spirits of those who died in rage or injustice, must be pacified lest they visit calamity on the living. The court of Heian Japan attributed plague, fire and lightning to the wrath of the scholar-minister Sugawara no Michizane, who died in exile in 903, and pacified him by deification as Tenjin. Taira no Masakado, who rose in rebellion in 939 and proclaimed himself *shinnō*, "New Emperor", was killed in 940; his severed head, displayed in the capital, became the subject of legends, and his grave mound, the *kubizuka*, still stands in Ōtemachi, at the heart of Tokyo's financial district, tended with wary reverence by the corporations around it. Sephiroth is a *goryō* of cosmic scale: a self-proclaimed sovereign whose will survives his death as a coherent force within the Lifestream, refusing dissolution into the ancestral commons, demanding rule. The party's final campaign is, in this register, a *chinkon*, a pacification of the spirit. The *Compilation* makes the refusal explicit: in *Advent Children* Sephiroth departs with a vow that he will never become a memory. It is the *goryō*'s creed, the refusal of the final memorial after which the dead are ancestors and no longer themselves. Jacques Derrida's hauntology (1993), the logic of the revenant who returns because the account with him has not been settled, describes the same structure in another idiom.

4.7 Jenova: the counterfeit dead

Ifalna's testimony describes Jenova's method with terrible economy. The entity fell from the sky two thousand years ago and wounded the Planet. When the Cetra came to heal the wound, it approached them in the forms of their departed kin, and through that intimacy it infected them, turning them into monsters. Only a remnant survived to seal it. Shinra's scientists later found the sealed body in a geological stratum two thousand years old and mistook it for an Ancient.

This is the mimetic-counterfeit mode in its purest form. Jenova takes from the dead their faces and from the living their grief, and it returns masks. It does not consume the dead, as Shinra does, nor absorb them, as Sephiroth would; it counterfeits them, exploiting the desire of the bereaved to see their dead again as the vector of infection. It is the worst conceivable violation of the anamnetic mode, because it weaponizes remembrance itself. Every false memory in the game is a small Jenova, and the cells that give Cloud a borrowed past are, in the most literal sense, Jenova's.

The figure has a recognizable genealogy in speculative fiction. John W. Campbell's novella "Who Goes There?" (1938), filmed by John Carpenter as *The Thing* (1982), concerns an Antarctic expedition that thaws an alien organism capable of perfectly imitating any creature it absorbs, so that no member of the station can trust that another is who he ap-

pears to be. H. P. Lovecraft's *At the Mountains of Madness* (1936) sends scientists to the Antarctic to find the frozen remains of an ancient alien civilization and the protoplasmic mimics it engineered. Jenova, sealed in an arctic impact crater and discovered by scientists who mistake it for what it imitates, belongs to this polar lineage of the mimetic alien. Sena Hideaki's novel *Parasite Eve* (1995), which Square adapted as a game in 1998, imagined the mitochondria within human cells rising to assert sovereignty over their hosts: Lynn Margulis's endosymbiosis (1967), in which ancient parasites became cooperative organelles, run in reverse, so that the symbiont reclaims its independence. Jenova is a parasite that refuses symbiosis and seeks dominion through incorporation.

The 1990s supplied a viral imagination to match. Richard Preston's *The Hot Zone* (1994) and the Ebola outbreak at Kikwit in 1995 made emerging viruses a subject of popular dread, and in Japan the state's acknowledgment in 1996 that between 1,400 and 2,000 people, most of them with haemophilia, had been infected with HIV through unheated blood products that the Green Cross Corporation, a company founded by a veteran of Unit 731, had gone on selling after safer products existed, with the acquiescence of the Ministry of Health and Welfare, exposed institutions that had introduced a contaminant into the bodies in their care. SOLDIER, injected with Jenova cells by the company that employs them, are victims of an iatrogenic infection of exactly that kind.

Two further resonances belong to Tier III and are offered with appropriate caution. The arrival from the sky, two thousand years before the present of a game released in 1997, of a being who appears to the bereaved in the forms of their dead reads as a dark inversion of the Christian proclamation, in which the one who returns from death appears to the mourning as himself. And the calamity from the skies recalls the quatrain of Nostradamus that Gotō Ben's bestseller had made a national expectation: *L'an mil neuf cens nonante neuf sept mois, / Du ciel viendra un grand Roy d'effrayeur* (Centuries X.72), in the year 1999, the seventh month, from the sky will come a great King of Terror. The early, abandoned concept for the game was reportedly set in 1999.

The interlocking of the counterfeit and sovereign modes is the game's most elegant concealment. The Sephiroth whom the party pursues through two discs is not Sephiroth. At the Northern Crater it is revealed that the figure they have chased, who killed the president and Aerith, was Jenova's body shaped in his likeness and moved by his will, while the real Sephiroth has lain since the Nibelheim incident encased in crystal in the crater's depths. The pursuit of the villain was the pursuit of a counterfeit of a dead man. Jenova supplies the masks; Sephiroth supplies the will. Together they constitute a single apparatus: a corpse that rules through a mimic.

4.8 The wheel of Fortune: "One-Winged Angel"

The Latin that the choir sings in "One-Winged Angel" is drawn from poems of the *Carmina Burana* manuscript. Among its phrases are *Estuans interius ira vehementi*, burning inwardly

with violent anger, from the Archpoet's confession; *Sors immanis et inanis*, Fate, monstrous and empty, from the lament to Fortune that opens Orff's setting; and *Veni, veni, venias, ne me mori facias*, come, come, O come, do not let me die. The texts are medieval; their passage into the twentieth century ran through Carl Orff's cantata, first performed in Frankfurt in 1937, and from Orff into the popular imagination as the sound of epic fate. Uematsu set fragments of them over a rock-orchestral idiom for which he has cited Stravinsky's *The Rite of Spring* among his models.

The Fortune lament carries a philosophy. In Boethius's *Consolation of Philosophy* (c. 524), written in prison as the author awaited execution, Lady Philosophy teaches that Fortune turns her wheel without regard to merit, that those who cling to her gifts must suffer their loss, and that the wise locate their good beyond her reach. The *Carmina* inherit Boethius's wheel, and the medieval iconography shows kings rising, reigning, falling and lying beneath it. Sephiroth's ambition is to stop the wheel, to become not a king upon it but its hub. The choir sings of Fortune's monstrous emptiness while the one who would master Fortune rises on a single wing. Its plea not to be allowed to die is, in this context, the plea of the will that refuses mortality itself.

Walter Benjamin's ninth thesis on the concept of history (1940) describes Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history, facing the past, where he sees one single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage. He would like to stay, awaken the dead and make whole what has been smashed, but a storm blowing from Paradise has caught in his wings and drives him irresistibly into the future. The storm is what we call progress. Sephiroth is the inverse of Benjamin's angel. Benjamin's angel would awaken the dead and make them whole; Sephiroth would consume the dead to make himself whole. Benjamin's angel is the mourner overwhelmed by progress; Sephiroth is the will of the storm itself, an angel of progress who would ride the catastrophe rather than suffer it. The attack his final form unleashes, Supernova, renders the ambition as spectacle: a cinematic sequence in which a comet tears through the solar system, planets are destroyed and the sun explodes. It is the Kantian mathematical sublime (1790), the encounter with magnitudes that exceed imagination, converted into an assertion of personal power, the sublime as kitsch.

4.9 The melancholic machine

The two modes of this chapter can now be stated alongside the combustive mode of Chapter Three. The sovereign-incorporative mode takes everything and returns nothing. It permits only one singularity to survive, that of the sovereign, into whom all others are absorbed, and it inhabits the eschatological time of the end, which it seeks to hasten and to occupy. The mimetic-counterfeit mode takes faces, memories and grief and returns masks. It falsifies singularity, and it inhabits a parasitic time of repetition without difference, the time of the copy.

Together with the combustive mode they compose what may be called the melancholic machine: a dead will that refuses to become an ancestor, wearing borrowed faces, driven by a forged origin, manufactured by a science that burns the dead for light. Each part requires the others. Shinra's science made Sephiroth; Jenova gave him a mother and a mask; Sephiroth gave Jenova a will; and the whole apparatus aims at the Lifestream, the commons of the dead, which it would at last consume entire. The machine has one more component, without which it could not have summoned Meteor: a human subject in whom all three of its operations take place at once. That subject is Cloud Strife.

CHAPTER FIVE

V

Cloud Strife

The Counterfeit Self, the Crypt of Zack and the Ipseity of a Promise

Cloud Strife is the place where the three pathological modes of necrometabolism converge in a single body, and the place where the fourth, anamnetic mode is first achieved. He is a self assembled from the dead: lit by mako, inhabited by Jenova's cells, wearing a dead friend's history as his own, and used by a dead will as its courier. His recovery is therefore not a subplot but the prototype of the Planet's salvation, enacted first at the scale of a person and in the same medium. This chapter reads his case through the analytic philosophy of personal identity, which it stages with uncanny exactness; through psychoanalysis, which supplies the vocabulary the analytic tradition lacks; through existential and Kyoto School accounts of the self's collapse and reconstitution; through the myths of descent to the dead; and finally through Paul Ricoeur's distinction between sameness and selfhood, which locates the ground of Cloud's restored identity not in a recovered memory but in a kept promise.

5.1 The narrator who remembers wrongly

Wayne Booth named the unreliable narrator in 1961: a narrator whose account the implied author signals the reader not to trust. *Final Fantasy VII* makes unreliability ergodic. In the town of Kalm, early in the journey, Cloud tells the party the story of the Nibelheim incident, and the player does not merely hear it but plays it, walking Cloud through the village, up Mount Nibel and into the reactor, controlling a version of himself who is a SOLDIER First Class and Sephiroth's companion. The player's first long lesson in the world's history is a counterfeit told in good faith, and the player has performed it.

The counterfeit erodes by degrees. Cloud suffers headaches at moments of proximity to the truth. Tifa hesitates whenever his account touches what she witnessed. In the village of Gongaga an elderly couple ask whether he knew their son, a SOLDIER named Zack. In the rebuilt Nibelheim, strangers deny that the fire ever happened. At the Northern Crater, Sephiroth stages an illusion of the incident with a black-haired SOLDIER standing where Cloud had placed himself, and Hojo, glancing at Cloud, dismisses him as an unnumbered failure. The full truth emerges only in the Lifestream at Mideel. Cloud never became a SOLDIER. He enlisted in Shinra's infantry, came to Nibelheim as a common soldier escorting Sephiroth and Zack, and hid his face behind his helmet out of shame at returning home a failure. When Sephiroth burned the village and cut down Zack and Tifa, it was Cloud, the anonymous infantryman, who wounded him and hurled him into the reactor's depths. Afterward Hojo held Cloud and Zack for years as experimental subjects, infusing them with mako and Jenova cells. Zack escaped with the catatonic Cloud and was killed by Shinra troops within sight of Midgar. Cloud, wandering, reassembled himself from Zack's stories, his own unrealized longing and the mimetic tendency of the cells within him, and arrived in Midgar believing himself the man who had died to save him.

5.2 The memory criterion and its discontents

John Locke's chapter "Of Identity and Diversity", added to the second edition of the *Essay Concerning Human Understanding* in 1694, defined the person as *a thinking intelligent Being, that has reason and reflection, and can consider it self as it self, the same thinking thing in different times and places* (II.xxvii.9), and placed the identity of the person in consciousness: *as far as this consciousness can be extended backwards to any past Action or Thought, so far reaches the Identity of that Person*. Applied to Cloud, the criterion produces an absurdity. If personal identity extends as far as consciousness extends backward, then Cloud, whose consciousness extends backward into Zack's deeds, is Zack, and the man who wounded Sephiroth in the reactor is no one.

The classical objections anticipate the case. Joseph Butler argued in 1736 that memory presupposes identity rather than constituting it, so that the criterion is circular: I can remember only what I did. Cloud's apparent memories show that the circle can be broken from outside, since he seems to remember what he did not do. Thomas Reid's brave officer (1785), who remembers his youthful flogging as a boy but whose aged self has forgotten the officer's exploits, showed that memory is not transitive and therefore cannot ground a transitive relation such as identity. David Hume, rejecting any substantial self, described the mind as *nothing but a bundle or collection of different perceptions* (*Treatise* I.iv.6) and attributed the idea of personal identity to the imagination's propensity to smooth resemblance and causation into sameness. For Hume there would be no deep fact for Cloud's condition to violate: his bundle simply includes perceptions caused by another's experience.

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) gives the case its most rigorous formulation. To avoid Butler's circularity, Parfit introduced quasi-memory: an apparent memory of an experience that someone had, caused in the right kind of way by that experience, whether or not the person who seems to remember it is the person who had it. His illustration imagines a woman, Jane, who receives copies of memory-traces from a man, Paul, and thereafter seems to remember, from the inside, Paul's experiences in Venice. Cloud is Parfit's Jane realized as fiction. His q-memories of Zack's exploits were caused, within the game's world, by Zack's experiences, transmitted through Zack's stories and through the mimetic cells that Hojo injected into both men. Parfit concluded that personal identity is not what matters; what matters is Relation R, psychological connectedness and continuity with any reliable cause. On Parfit's view Cloud's connection to Zack's past would be a legitimate continuity, perhaps even a form of survival for Zack.

The game disagrees, and the ground of its disagreement is instructive. It treats Cloud's q-memories as a sickness, but not because they lack the metaphysical guarantee of a Cartesian soul. They are pathological because of how they were acquired: not by inheritance but by incorporation, not acknowledged as Zack's but appropriated as Cloud's own, and appropriated precisely so that Zack's death need never be faced. The distinction the

game draws is between a past received as a gift from the dead and a past swallowed in place of mourning them. The analytic debate, which asks only whether psychological continuity obtains, has no vocabulary for that distinction. Psychoanalysis does.

The science-fiction lineage of the implanted memory shows the same gap. In Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), filmed as *Blade Runner* (1982), the replicant Rachael learns that her childhood memories belong to her maker's niece; in Dick's story "We Can Remember It for You Wholesale" (1966) a clerk purchases false memories of adventure; in Oshii Mamoru's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995) a garbage collector discovers that the wife and daughter he remembers never existed, that the memories were planted by a hacker who used him as a tool. In each case false memory is inflicted by power. Cloud's case differs in one crucial respect: he is partly the author of his counterfeit. He wanted to be a SOLDIER, wanted to be Zack, wanted not to be the boy who failed. The problem is therefore ethical as well as epistemic; it concerns not only what happened to him but how he stood toward the dead.

Dick's *A Scanner Darkly* (1977) supplies a case closer still. An undercover narcotics agent, known to his superiors only by a code name and hidden from them by a "scramble suit", is assigned to surveil the man he himself is; a drug that damages communication between the hemispheres of the brain severs his two identities until he can no longer recognize himself, and the agency that assigned him turns out to have accepted, even planned, his ruin as the price of placing him where it needed him. Dissociation produced by a substance administered within an institutional apparatus, and a self split between a role and a person: Cloud's mako poisoning and Jenova cells occupy the structural place of Dick's Substance D, and Shinra's laboratory that of the agency for which a broken agent was an acceptable cost.

5.3 The false self, the mirror and the crypt

D. W. Winnicott described a false self that develops when an infant's environment fails to meet its spontaneous gestures and instead impinges upon it, so that the child builds a compliant surface to protect a true self that goes into hiding; in severe cases the false self is all that appears, and its signature is a sense of futility and unreality (Winnicott 1960). Cloud's mercenary persona has precisely this character: detached, laconic, professionally indifferent, given to the formula that he is not interested. It is a shell built over a boy who failed his entrance to SOLDIER, returned home in a helmet to hide his face and was then used as a laboratory specimen for years.

Jacques Lacan's mirror stage (1949) describes the formation of the ego as an identification with an external image, an imago that lends the fragmented subject a fictional unity. Cloud's ego was formed in the mirror of SOLDIER, a public legend embodied first in Sephiroth, the hero the boy idolized, and then in Zack, the friend who wore the role with ease. The uniform, the oversized sword that was Zack's, the stories of First Class exploits:

these are the imago that gives Cloud the appearance of a unified self. Chapter Two noted that in Yogācāra the purified storehouse becomes the great perfect mirror wisdom, a cognition that reflects all things without distortion. Cloud's journey runs from one mirror to the other, from the imaginary mirror of identification, which shows him whom he wishes to be, to the true mirror of recollection, which shows him what happened.

The decisive diagnosis, however, is Freud's. Zack died while Cloud lay catatonic beside him, poisoned by mako, unable to witness the loss in any way that would permit reality-testing. What cannot be witnessed cannot be mourned. Cloud did what the melancholic does: he identified with the lost object and installed it within himself. The shadow of Zack fell upon Cloud's ego. Here the symmetry with Sephiroth, traced in Chapter Four, becomes visible. Both are melancholics. Sephiroth incorporates a counterfeit mother in order to rule; Cloud incorporates a real friend in order to survive. The sovereign and the compliant are two forms of the same refusal to let the dead be dead.

Abraham and Torok sharpened Freud's distinction into an opposition between introjection and incorporation (1978). Introjection is the slow work by which the ego enlarges itself through what it has lost, assimilating the lost one's qualities as a living inheritance. Incorporation is the fantasy of swallowing the lost object whole, so that it need never be lost; it produces within the ego a crypt, a sealed intrapsychic tomb in which the unmourned object lives on in secret, speaking through the subject without being recognized. Cloud's psyche contains such a crypt, and Zack lives in it. When Cloud speaks of his exploits as a SOLDIER, the voice from the crypt is speaking. Sephiroth's mastery over Cloud is exercised through this crypt. When he calls Cloud a puppet and commands him, he addresses the sealed tomb within, the place where Cloud is not himself.

The *Compilation* later supplied, after the fact, the bequest the original withheld. In *Crisis Core* (2007), Zack, dying on the hill outside Midgar, presses his sword into Cloud's hands and charges him to live on as his legacy. The prequel thereby retells the incorporation as the distorted reception of a real gift: what Cloud swallowed in secret had in fact been offered to him in the open, and his recovery in the Lifestream becomes, in retrospect, the conversion of a crypt into an inheritance. Whether the revision honours the 1997 text or softens its harshest insight, that Cloud took what had not knowingly been given, is a question of the kind Chapter Nine asks of every return to the dead.

5.4 Despair, the They and the performance of identity

Kierkegaard's two forms of despair, introduced in the previous chapter, distribute themselves between the protagonist and the antagonist. Sephiroth is despair in defiance, the will to be a self of one's own making. Cloud is despair in weakness, the refusal to be oneself, the flight into another's identity because one's own seems unbearable. Kierkegaard's remedy is a self that, in relating to itself and in willing to be itself, rests transparently in the power that established it. The game's remedy, as Chapter Ten argues, has the same

form translated into another theology: a self that rests in the relation to others and to the commons of the dead from which it was drawn.

Heidegger's *Being and Time* (1927) described the everyday self as a They-self (*das Man-selbst*), a self that understands itself through what "one" does and says, the public interpretation of possibilities. Cloud's persona is drawn from the most public material available in his world, the legend of SOLDIER broadcast in Shinra's propaganda and repeated in every bar. He is the They-self in its purest form. Yet Heidegger's remedy, an anticipatory resoluteness in which Dasein, facing its own death as its ownmost possibility, wrests itself from the They, does not fit the game. Cloud is not healed by confronting his own death alone. He is healed by recovering the deaths of others in the company of another. The divergence anticipates the dispute, examined in Chapter Ten, between Heidegger's being-toward-death and Hannah Arendt's natality.

Jean-Paul Sartre's bad faith (1943), whose emblem is the café waiter who plays at being a waiter, captures the performative quality of Cloud's persona but presupposes a lucid freedom that Cloud, poisoned and colonized, does not possess. Judith Butler's account of gender as performative (1990), in which identity is not the source of its expressions but the effect of their repetition, describes it more exactly, and the game supplies its own demonstration. In the Wall Market, early in the first disc, Cloud must infiltrate the mansion of a crime boss who is choosing a bride, and he does so by being dressed, made up and coached until he passes convincingly as a woman. The sequence is played for comedy, but it is a *mise en abyme* of the entire plot. A wardrobe, a wig and a set of rehearsed gestures produce a convincing woman, just as a uniform, a sword and a set of borrowed stories produced a convincing SOLDIER. The game teaches the lesson first as farce and later as tragedy: identity is something performed, and a performance can be total.

5.5 Nihility and emptiness: Nishitani's three fields

Nishitani Keiji's *Religion and Nothingness* (1961), the central work of the second generation of the Kyoto School, describes the religious transformation of the self as a passage through three fields. On the field of consciousness, the self understands itself as a subject over against objects, a substance with properties, and this standpoint, though necessary, conceals the groundlessness of both self and world. On the field of nihility, the bottom falls out: the self discovers the abyss beneath its supposed substantiality and is absorbed in the nihilism that Nietzsche diagnosed. Nishitani insists that this field must be passed through, not avoided, because only on its far side does the field of emptiness open, *śūnyatā*, where self and things are encountered in their suchness, each existing through the others in a relation of mutual interpenetration rather than as isolated substances.

Cloud's arc traces the three fields with precision.

Nishitani's field	Cloud's condition	Where the game stages it	Necrometabolic mode
Consciousness	A substantial ego defined by a role: the SOLDIER, the mercenary, the man who was there	Midgar through the Northern Crater; the Kalm flashback	Counterfeit (the self as mask)
Nihility	The ego's ground collapses; the self dissolves into a flood of alien memory	Sephiroth's revelation at the Crater; catatonic mako poisoning at Mideel	Combustive and incorporative (the self consumed)
Emptiness	The self reconstituted as a nexus of relations, not a recovered substance	The descent into the Lifestream with Tifa	Anamnetic (the self as commons)

The second field is not a detour. Cloud has to collapse, and the game makes the collapse total: he surrenders the Black Materia, Meteor is summoned through his hands, and he is found weeks later in a wheelchair, murmuring fragments, unable to recognize the woman who sits beside him. Only from that bottom does the third field open. What Cloud recovers in the Lifestream is not a substantial self that had been buried beneath the false one. It is a pattern of relations: to Tifa, to his mother, to Nibelheim, to Zack, whose death he can now acknowledge as Zack's, and to his own failure, which he can now own.

Watsuji Tetsurō's ethics gives the result its Japanese name. The ordinary word for a human being, *ningen* (人間), is written with the characters for person and between, and Watsuji argued that the human being is constituted in betweenness, *aidagara*, rather than in a private interiority (Watsuji 1937). Cloud is reconstituted between persons. His selfhood after Mideel is not something he possesses alone.

5.6 The descent: Orpheus, Izanagi and the shared gaze

The Mideel sequence is a katabasis, a descent to the dead, and it inverts the two most famous descents in the traditions on which the game draws. In the version given by Virgil (*Georgics* IV) and Ovid (*Metamorphoses* X), Orpheus descends to the underworld to retrieve his dead wife Eurydice and is permitted to lead her back on condition that he not look at her before they reach the light; he looks, and loses her forever. In the *Kojiki* (712), the god Izanagi descends to Yomi, the land of the dead, to retrieve his dead consort Izanami. She asks him not to look upon her while she consults the gods of the underworld; he breaks a tooth from his comb, lights it, and sees her body putrefying. He flees, pursued, and seals the passage between the worlds with a great boulder. Across it Izanami vows to kill a thousand of his people each day; Izanagi answers that he will cause fifteen hundred to be born. Then, polluted by his contact with death, he purifies himself in a river, and from the purification are born the sun goddess Amaterasu, the moon god Tsukuyomi and the storm god Susanoo.

Tifa's descent inverts these myths on three counts. The first is gender: a woman descends to retrieve a man, a pattern with an ancient precedent in the Sumerian *Descent of*

Inanna, but rare in the traditions the game most visibly draws upon. The second is the prohibition: in the Lifestream looking is not forbidden but required. Tifa must look at what Cloud cannot bear to see, the scenes of his failure, his hidden face, the friend whose place he took, and he must look at them with her. The third is the outcome: the descent succeeds. It succeeds because the gaze is shared. Orpheus and Izanagi each look alone and see death; Tifa and Cloud look together and see what happened. Their emergence has the structure of Izanagi's purification: from the washing in the river of the dead a new figure is born, a Cloud who can lead.

The form of the sequence reproduces with remarkable exactness Freud's description of the work of mourning. Reality-testing, Freud wrote, shows that the loved object is gone and demands that the libido be withdrawn from it; but the demand cannot be met at once. It is carried out bit by bit, at great expense of time and energy, as each memory and expectation that bound the libido to the object is brought up, hypercathected and detached. Inside the Lifestream, Cloud and Tifa revisit his past not as a single revelation but scene by scene: the childhood on the mountain, the water tower, the helmet, the reactor, the laboratory, the station where Tifa found him. Each scene is brought up, examined together, corrected and released. The Lifestream sequence is the work of mourning made into a level of a game.

The decisive figure of the sequence is a child: the boy Cloud of the water tower, whose promise is the one memory that was never false. Jung described the child archetype as an image of futurity, of a wholeness not yet achieved, the part of the psyche from which renewal comes (Jung 1940). Cloud is reconstituted not from the hero he pretended to be but from the boy he was, and the reconstitution takes place in the presence of the girl to whom that boy made his promise.

Paul Ricoeur's late work on memory treats it as a testimonial and dialogical practice in which the witness, the one who says "I was there; believe me", is the hinge between individual recollection and shared history (Ricoeur 2000). Tifa is a witness of exactly this kind, and an imperfect one: she was in Nibelheim, but she never recognized the infantryman behind the helmet, and her own memory is incomplete. The truth emerges not from either memory alone but from their conversation. The anamnetic self is dialogical. It is constituted by two partial memories correcting each other in the presence of the dead.

5.7 The promise: *idem* and *ipse*

In *Oneself as Another* (1990), Ricoeur distinguished two meanings of identity. *Idem*-identity is sameness: numerical identity, qualitative similarity, the uninterrupted continuity of a thing through time. *Ipse*-identity is selfhood: the identity of the one who can answer "here I am" when called to account. The two overlap in character, the set of lasting dispositions by which a person is recognized. But Ricoeur identified a second model of permanence in time in which selfhood persists without the support of sameness: keeping

one's word. When I keep a promise, I maintain myself across time not because I have remained the same (my desires, opinions and circumstances may all have changed) but because I hold to what I said. Promise-keeping is selfhood without sameness.

Cloud's case is a demonstration of Ricoeur's distinction. His *idem*-identity fails completely: his remembered history is false, and his character, the laconic mercenary, is a mask. Yet something persists through the counterfeit and grounds the self that emerges from it. Before he left Nibelheim, the boy Cloud met Tifa beneath the water tower one starlit night and told her he was going to join SOLDIER; she asked him to promise that if she were ever in trouble he would come and save her, and he promised. At the beginning of the game, in the bar beneath the plate, Tifa invokes that promise to keep him in Midgar. The promise operates throughout the counterfeit, binding the false Cloud to the true Tifa. In the Lifestream the water tower is among the scenes recovered, and it is the one memory that was never false. After Mideel, Cloud is the one who keeps his word: to Tifa, and to Aerith, whose prayer he carries through to its completion. His selfhood is grounded not in continuity but in fidelity.

This is the deepest point of the chapter and of the dissertation's account of the self. The game rejects both of the answers the philosophy of personal identity tends to offer. It does not say, with the essentialist, that a true self lay buried beneath the false and was dug up intact; what is recovered in the Lifestream is a set of relations, not a substance. Nor does it say, with the reductionist, that identity does not matter and only psychological continuity counts; Cloud's continuity with Zack's experiences is real, and it is a sickness. It says that a self is constituted by the keeping of a promise in the presence of a witness, amid the dead whom it acknowledges. The anamnetic self is a fidelity, not a fact.

An ethic of care is embedded here, and with it a critical problem. Carol Gilligan (1982) and Nel Noddings (1984) articulated an ethics grounded in relationship, attentiveness and responsibility for particular others, historically associated with and often imposed upon women's labour. The anamnesis of Cloud rests on such labour. Tifa remains at Mideel beside a man who does not recognize her; she had withheld her doubts about his story out of fear of shattering him; her own losses, a father killed by Sephiroth and a home burned, are subordinated throughout to his restoration. The game's insight that selfhood is sustained by others comes bound to a gendered distribution in which a woman becomes the custodian of a man's memory. Tifa's agency is real (she chooses to descend, and her testimony is as necessary as his recollection), but the asymmetry is real as well, and Chapter Ten records it among the objections the dissertation does not fully dissolve.

5.8 The unnumbered, the psychomachia and the gift

When Hojo dismisses Cloud at the Crater as an unnumbered failure, he names, without intending to, the ground of Cloud's singularity. The counterfeit mode works through series: numbered clones, copied faces, repeated forms. Cloud stands outside the series. His fail-

ure to be counted is the condition of his freedom from the count, and the self he becomes is singular in a sense the clones cannot be, singular not as an isolated substance but as the unrepeatable knot of a particular set of relations and a particular promise.

The final battle of the game makes this singularity its subject. After the party defeats Safer·Sephiroth, Cloud alone faces Sephiroth within the Lifestream. The duel is a psychomachia in the sense of Prudentius's fifth-century allegory, a combat of virtues and vices within the soul, and it is fought in the medium of the dead, where Cloud was remade. It is also structurally weighted so heavily in his favour, his Limit gauge brimming from the outset, that it reads less as a contest than as a rite. The victory is not earned against a doubtful outcome; it is given. Chapter Ten reads this design as the ludic expression of other-power, *tariki*.

5.9 Cloud as microcosm

Cloud passes through all four modes of necrometabolism, and the Planet passes through the same four. The correspondence is the formal spine of the dissertation's argument.

Mode	Cloud	The Planet
Combustive	Infused with mako in Hojo's laboratory; his strength borrowed from the dead; poisoned by excess	Drained by eight reactors; the land around Midgar killed
Sovereign-incorporative	Made Sephiroth's puppet and courier; Meteor summoned through his hands	Wounded by Meteor so that its dead may be gathered and consumed
Mimetic-counterfeit	Wears Zack's history; colonized by Jenova's cells	Haunted for two thousand years by a calamity that wore the faces of the dead
Anamnetic-reciprocal	Remade in the Lifestream through shared recollection and a kept promise	Saved when the Lifestream rises and its dead act

What is below is like what is above. The game builds its protagonist as a model of its world and heals both in the same substance, because it holds that the sickness of the self and the sickness of the world are one sickness: the incapacity to stand rightly toward the dead. The next chapter turns to the figure through whom the game teaches what standing rightly might mean.

CHAPTER SIX

VI

Aerith Gainsborough

Death Without Spectacle and the Grammar of Intercession

Aerith is the anamnetic mode in a human form. She hears the dead without wearing their faces, prays on behalf of a world that hunts her, dies without ceremony and goes on acting after death. Her death is the most famous event in the history of the medium, and it has been discussed chiefly as an event of reception, a shock administered to a generation of players. This chapter treats it instead as the hinge of the work's philosophy. It argues that the death converts the narrative from a contest of powers into a rite of intercession; that Aerith is a medium in the exact sense of Japanese spirit-mediumship, and the true counterpart of Jenova's false one; that her prayer, completed before she dies and fulfilled after, is the game's model of an act that outlives its agent; that the scene opens a philosophical gap between the reversible death of the battle system and the irreversible death of the story; and that her posthumous agency is the first decisive appearance of the dead as actors, the appearance on which the ending depends.

6.1 Death without spectacle

In the deepest chamber of the Forgotten Capital, Aerith kneels on an altar surrounded by water and prays. Cloud descends toward her, and his hand moves to his sword under a will not his own; he resists. Sephiroth drops from above and runs her through. She falls forward. There is no final speech, no declaration of sacrifice, no exchange of last words. The prayer, as the party will learn much later, was already complete. The death interrupts nothing that needed her to remain alive; it simply ends her.

Kitase's recollected intention, that the death should come abruptly and without the consolations of heroic sacrifice, is realized in what the scene withholds. The genre of the role-playing game had trained its audience to expect that a companion's death would be meaningful in a specific way: chosen, announced and redemptive, a sacrifice that purchases something visible. Aerith's death purchases nothing visible. Its meaning is deferred until the end of the game and concealed until then, so that for most of the remaining journey her death appears exactly as a real death appears to the bereaved: senseless.

What follows makes the refusal of catharsis explicit. Before the party can grieve, a fragment of Jenova attacks, and the player must fight while the score plays Aerith's theme. Combat and lament are superimposed; the player is denied the posture of the mourner and forced into the posture of the fighter while the music mourns. Afterward, Cloud tries to speak his grief and can describe only its symptoms in his body, the tingling of his fingers, the dryness of his mouth, the burning of his eyes, as though the feeling had no subject. Sephiroth answers by mocking the pretence: a puppet, he tells Cloud, cannot grieve, and has no need to act as though it does. The exchange states the ethical thesis of the entire game in negative form. Sephiroth denies that Cloud can mourn because he denies that Cloud is a self. The game will answer by making Cloud's capacity to mourn the

proof of his selfhood. The counterfeit self cannot grieve; the anamnetic self is the one who can.

6.2 Name, flowers and the church in the slums

Her name, officially romanized as Aerith (the 1997 English localization had "Aeris"), lies a single letter from an anagram of *earth*, and the near-coincidence has been widely noticed. Her surname is her adoptive mother's, and it belongs to Thomas Gainsborough, the eighteenth-century English painter of portraits set in pastoral landscape. She is introduced selling flowers in the streets of Midgar, and her flowers are a miracle, because nothing grows in Midgar: the soil beneath the plate is dead. They grow in the nave of a ruined church in the Sector 5 slum, where Cloud, blown from a reactor, crashes through the roof and lands in her flowerbed. The church is the last remnant of the sacred in the anti-mandala, a place where life persists amid the necropolis.

The figure of the flower girl carries its own literary history. George Bernard Shaw's *Pygmalion* (1913) begins with Eliza Doolittle selling flowers in Covent Garden, whom a professor of phonetics undertakes to remake into a lady. Aerith is Eliza inverted. The professor who pursues her is not a phonetician who would refine her but a biologist who would breed her; Higgins wants to make a lady of a flower girl, Hojo wants to make a specimen of the last of her kind. That Shaw has appeared twice in this study, once as the reader of Wagner's *Ring* as an allegory of industrial capital and once as the author of the flower girl remade by a professor, is a coincidence that the reader may weigh as they like.

The flowers belong to two aesthetic traditions. Hildegard's *viriditas*, the greening power of the divine in creation (Chapter Two), names their theology: in a city that burns the dead, Aerith tends the green. The Japanese poetics of *mono no aware*, the pathos of things, which Motoori Norinaga (1730–1801) identified as the heart of classical Japanese literature, names their pathos: the poignant awareness of transience of which the flower is the canonical emblem. Aerith's flowers are transience made sacred, and their gardener is herself transient.

6.3 The last of the Cetra

Aerith is the daughter of the Cetra woman Ifalna and of Professor Gast, the scientist who first studied Jenova and turned against the project when he understood it. Hojo, Gast's successor and rival, imprisoned mother and child; Ifalna escaped with her daughter and died at a Midgar station, entrusting the girl to Elmyra Gainsborough, a woman whose husband had not returned from the war. Aerith grew up under surveillance, followed by the Turks, who wanted her as the only living key to the Promised Land.

When the Turks finally deliver her to the Shinra Building, Hojo places her in a specimen chamber with Red XIII in an attempt to breed the last Cetra with a creature of anoth-

er species. The scene is grotesque by design, and it exposes the logic of the laboratory with total clarity. Giorgio Agamben described the "anthropological machine" by which Western thought produces the human by separating it from the animal within and around it (Agamben 2002), and the figure of bare life, *zoē*, stripped of political existence and exposed to sovereign power without protection (Agamben 1995). Hojo runs the anthropological machine in reverse: he treats Aerith and Red XIII as two species to be crossed, and in doing so reduces the last member of a people to bare life. The Japanese term for the Cetra, *kodaishu* (古代種), literally "ancient species", uses the vocabulary of taxonomy for a people. The eugenic dream of the Jenova Project, which sought to manufacture Ancients, finds its counterpart in the attempt to breed the last authentic one.

In the typology of Chapter Two, Aerith is the last of the elder race, the final survivor of a people who heard the Planet. Unlike Tolkien's Arwen, who chooses mortality to remain with the man she loves, Aerith has no choice to make; she is already mortal, the daughter of a human father. What she chooses is to pray.

6.4 The medium: *itako*, *miko* and the voice of the Planet

Aerith hears what others cannot: the voice of the Planet and, the game implies, the voices of the dead within it. In the language of comparative religion she is a medium, and the Japanese tradition supplies a precise type. In northern Honshū, the *itako*, women traditionally blind and trained through severe ritual apprenticeship, practise *kuchiyose* (口寄せ), literally "drawing the mouth": they lend their voices to the dead so that the bereaved may hear them speak. Their most famous site is Mount Osore (Osorezan) in Aomori, a volcanic caldera of sulphurous vents and bleached stone long regarded as a threshold of the other world, where *itako* gather at the summer festival to receive the grieving. The *miko*, whose present role as attendants at Shinto shrines is the domesticated survival of an older vocation, were in earlier periods spirit mediums through whom *kami* spoke. Aerith is both. She listens to the Planet and the dead, and she prays at an altar on behalf of the world.

The typology clarifies her relation to Jenova. Jenova is also a medium of a kind. It too presents itself to the bereaved in the persons of their dead, and in that sense it practises a counterfeit *kuchiyose*, borrowing the faces of the dead to infect the living. Aerith is the true medium of which Jenova is the forgery. She lets the dead speak through her without wearing their faces; Jenova wears their faces and says nothing that is theirs. The anamnetic and the counterfeit modes meet in this opposition as directly as anywhere in the game.

Two further traditions frame her prayer. In Christian practice, intercession is prayer offered on behalf of others, above all by saints and by the Virgin, whose prayers are believed to be efficacious beyond death; Aerith's church, her flowers and her final kneeling posture invite this reading, and the game draws on Christian iconography as freely as it

draws on Kabbalistic and Norse names. In the Pure Land Buddhism that shaped Japanese religious life from Hōnen and Shinran onward, salvation comes through the *nembutsu*, the invocation of Amida Buddha, in which the practitioner entrusts herself to a power not her own, the Buddha's vow, rather than to her own merit. Aerith's prayer has this structure. Holy is not her power; it is the Planet's, and she is its conduit. She does not save the world; she asks to be the means by which the world saves itself.

6.5 The prayer that outlives the one who prays

As Aerith falls, the White Materia slips from the ribbon in her hair, falls onto the altar, rolls down its steps with a small clear sound and sinks into the water. It is dull, almost colourless, and for most of the following disc it is forgotten. Only when the party returns to the Forgotten Capital, searching for a way to stop Meteor, do they find it on the bed of the lake, glowing. Aerith's prayer had reached the Planet before she died. Holy was summoned; it is being held back by Sephiroth's will at the Crater.

The structure is philosophically exact. Aerith's act was completed before her death and is fulfilled after it; her death neither voided it nor completed it. J. L. Austin distinguished performative utterances, which do something in being said, from statements, and analysed the conditions under which a performative succeeds or misfires (Austin 1962). A prayer is a performative whose felicity condition lies outside the speaker: it succeeds if it is heard. Aerith's prayer was heard, and its success is independent of whether she survives. In Hannah Arendt's account of action, deeds are irreversible and their consequences unpredictable, outrunning their agents into a web of relations no one controls (Arendt 1958). Aerith's prayer is the purest case of action in Arendt's sense in the game: an act whose meaning is realized only after its agent is gone. And it is the counterpart, in the feminine register the game assigns it, of Cloud's promise. He keeps his word across the destruction of his identity; she keeps hers across the destruction of her life.

6.6 The burial

After the battle Cloud carries Aerith's body to the lake that surrounds the altar. The party watches as he wades in and releases her; she sinks slowly, her hands at rest, and the surface closes. No stone, no inscription, no rite but the return of a body to water.

The image gathers a long Western iconography of the drowned woman. In *Hamlet* (IV.vii), Gertrude reports Ophelia's death in the brook, *her clothes spread wide; / And mermaid-like awhile they bore her up*, an image John Everett Millais painted in 1851–52. Malory's Elaine of Astolat, who dies of unrequited love for Lancelot, is laid in a barge and sent downriver to Camelot (*Le Morte Darthur*, 1485), and Tennyson's *The Lady of Shalott* (1832, revised 1842) refashioned her as the woman who floats dead to the city she could only see in a mirror. Arthur himself passes by water to Avalon. Aerith's love, first for Zack and

then, unresolved, for Cloud, places her in the line of Elaine, and her passage by water places her in the line of Avalon.

The scene also reverses a central image of Christian art. In Michelangelo's *Pietà* (1498–99) the mother holds the body of her dead son across her lap. Here a man holds the body of a dead woman and gives her to the water. The iconography of grief is retained and its genders exchanged, as the descent of Chapter Five exchanged the genders of Orpheus and Eurydice. And the burial is itself a figure of the Lifestream. The dead return to water as all the dead return to the stream; the lake receives her as the Planet will. Shortly after the burial the first disc ends, and the player must remove it from the console, a material caesura in the act of play that Chapter Nine considers further.

6.7 The Phoenix Down problem

Within weeks of the game's release a question circulated among players that has never stopped circulating: why could the party not revive Aerith with a Phoenix Down, the common item that restores fallen companions in battle? The question is usually treated as a joke about the conventions of the genre. It is in fact the sharpest philosophical question the game provokes.

The battle system possesses its own concept of death, and it is reversible. A character reduced to zero hit points is incapacitated, removed from the turn order, and can be restored by an item, a spell or a summoned phoenix. The two versions of the text name this condition differently. Where the English localization speaks of restoring life, the Japanese system names the status 戦闘不能, *sentō funō*, "unable to fight": not death, but incapacity. The game thus contains two ontologies of mortality. In the system, death is a status: reversible, quantified, anonymous, the same for every character and every enemy. In the narrative, death is an event: irreversible, unquantifiable, singular. Aerith's death is the moment the second ontology breaks through the first.

Heidegger's analysis of everyday talk about death clarifies the distinction. In the idiom of the They, death is something that happens to "one": *man stirbt*, one dies, an event in the world that concerns everyone and therefore no one in particular (*Being and Time* §§51–52). The battle system's death is the They's death. Aerith's is not. It cannot be generalized, cannot be undone and cannot be borne by anyone but the one who died and the ones who lost her. The Phoenix Down cannot touch her because it belongs to a different order of being. The game's refusal to allow revival is not an inconsistency in its rules; it is the moment the rules confess their limit.

6.8 The mourning of the players

The audience did not accept the loss. Rumours of a hidden method to revive Aerith circulated for years in magazines, schoolyards and early online forums; players searched for

secret items, impossible conditions and unseen scenes. Others, using cheat devices and data editors, restored her to the party in the second disc, reanimating her in code. Freud would recognize the shape of the response. Denial and bargaining are the first movements of a mourning that has not yet begun; a fandom that technically reanimates its dead has built, in miniature, a laboratory of the kind Hojo kept.

Yet the long mourning of the players also became something else. The decades of discussion, commemoration, art and exegesis that the death provoked constitute a commons of memory in which a fictional person is remembered by millions who never knew her and who know that she never lived. Chapter One noted that this archive is itself an instance of the anamnetic commons the game imagines. The players were taught by the game to grieve, and they have kept the promise.

6.9 The storyteller and the authority of death

In "Der Erzähler" (1936), Walter Benjamin argued that death is the sanction of everything the storyteller can tell: the storyteller borrows authority from death, and the reader of a novel seeks in the death of a character the meaning of a life that, in his own case, remains incomplete. *Final Fantasy VII* borrows its authority from Aerith's death. After it the story means in a way it did not before; the journey acquires a debt, and every subsequent scene is played in her absence.

The borrowing raises the question this dissertation poses to every relation with the dead. A narrative can treat a death combustively, burning it for pathos, or anamnetically, honouring it as a loss that remains a loss. Kitase's refusal of spectacle, the absence of a speech, the denial of catharsis, the forced combat under the lament, tilts the original toward the anamnetic. The game does not dwell on her body; it gives her to the water and moves on, as the bereaved must. Whether the later franchise, which has returned to this death again and again, honours or spends it is the question Chapter Nine takes up.

6.10 The dead who act

Aerith's agency does not end with her life. Her prayer summoned Holy. When Holy is finally released at the Crater and proves unable alone to stop Meteor, the Lifestream itself rises from the Planet, and the closing sequence grants her a fleeting presence within it. The dead, led in some sense by the one who prayed, act to save the living.

Benjamin's second thesis on the concept of history speaks of a secret agreement between past generations and the present one: each generation is endowed with a weak messianic power on which the past has a claim. The game stages the agreement in both directions. The dead have a claim on the living, to be remembered rightly and not burned; and the living are saved by the dead, who act when the living have exhausted their own

power. The ending is, in the terms of Chapter Two, a planetary Obon: the dead return from the other side to visit the living, and on this visit they save them.

Aerith is also, finally, a figure of natality. She is the gardener of the only flowers in Midgar; she saves Barret's daughter Marlene from the falling plate and entrusts her to safety; her prayer is answered in an epilogue whose final image is a family of newborn cubs running toward a city overgrown with green. Arendt held that the faculty of beginning, grounded in the fact of birth, is the miracle that saves the world from its normal ruin. Aerith joins the two halves of the anamnetic mode: she is the dead who act and the one who tends what is born.

6.11 Death as the proof of selfhood

The chapter can be gathered into a single claim. Aerith's death converts the narrative of *Final Fantasy VII* from a contest of powers into a rite. Before it, the story is a pursuit, a struggle of factions and wills for control of the Promised Land and the Black Materia. After it, the story is a work of mourning: a party of the bereaved carrying a dead woman's prayer to its completion. And the rite contains the answer to Sephiroth's denial. He told Cloud that a puppet cannot grieve. The rest of the game proves him wrong by restoring to Cloud the capacity to mourn, which is to say the capacity to be a self. The next chapter turns to the company of mourners who carry the prayer, and to the politics their mourning implies.

CHAPTER SEVEN

VII

AVALANCHE and the Politics of the Planet

Terror, Complicity and the Fellowship of the Bereaved

The political philosophy of *Final Fantasy VII* is neither the eco-revolutionary politics of AVALANCHE nor the technocratic order of Shinra but a politics of mourning, in which legitimacy is measured by a community's relation to its dead. This chapter reaches that conclusion by way of the game's violence: the bombing with which it opens, the state terror with which Shinra answers, and the ambiguous divine violence with which it ends. It then examines the party member by member, showing that every one of them is constituted by a relation to the dead, and argues that the party is the game's counter-institution to Shinra: an association founded not on the use of the dead but on their remembrance.

7.1 The opening bomb

The game begins with an act of terrorism, and the player commits it. A train pulls into a station in Midgar; a small armed cell emerges; the player, as a hired mercenary, guides it into a mako reactor and plants a bomb. The reactor explodes, fires spread through the surrounding sector, and the cell escapes through streets filled with frightened civilians. No prior mass-market game had placed its player, in its first minutes, in the role of a bomber of urban infrastructure, and the moral position of the protagonist is compromised from the start. Cloud claims indifference; the cell's members register unease at the destruction they have caused; Barret justifies it in the name of a dying Planet.

AVALANCHE belongs to a recognizable lineage. Edward Abbey's novel *The Monkey Wrench Gang* (1975) gave the sabotage of industrial projects its popular name; Earth First!, founded in 1980, made direct action against logging and dam construction part of environmental politics; the Earth Liberation Front, formed in 1992, turned to arson. The philosophical position behind the most radical currents was Arne Næss's deep ecology (1973), which distinguished the "shallow" environmentalism concerned with pollution and resources for human benefit from a "deep" ecology affirming the intrinsic value of all living beings. Næss himself was committed to Gandhian nonviolence; the movement's militant fringe was not. Barret's rhetoric, in which the reactors are sucking the life from the Planet, is deep ecology in its most compressed form.

The ambient discourse of 1995 gave the opening a charge no Western comparison supplies. Less than two years before the game's Japanese release, members of Aum Shinrikyō had released sarin on the trains of the Tokyo subway. Murakami Haruki's oral history of the attack's victims, *Underground*, appeared in March 1997, two months after the game, and documented a society shaken by the discovery of how vulnerable the arteries of its capital were. The game's first image of Midgar after the opening cinematic is a train arriving at a station and a cell of terrorists stepping off it. No claim of intention is made; the claim is that Japanese players in 1997 could not have received the scene as Western players did.

7.2 Three violences: Benjamin's critique

Walter Benjamin's "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921) remains the most searching analysis of the relation between violence and law, and its categories distribute the game's violence with precision. Benjamin distinguished law-making violence, which founds a new legal order (the violence of revolutions and wars), from law-preserving violence, which administers and enforces an existing order. Both belong to what he called mythic violence. Against them he set divine violence, which neither makes nor preserves law but destroys it, which is expiatory rather than founding, and which, in his difficult formulation, strikes without spilling blood.

Benjamin reserved particular contempt for the police, in whom the separation of the two forms of mythic violence is suspended: the police both issue decrees and enforce them, intervening wherever the state can no longer secure its ends through the legal order, a formless and spectral presence throughout civilized life. Shinra's department of public security, commanded by the executive named Heidegger, and the Turks, its agents of abduction and assassination, are police in this sense. The collapse of the Sector 7 plate is police violence at its purest. It makes law, by deciding that a district and its inhabitants shall cease to exist; it presents itself as preserving law, by attributing the act to terrorists; and it founds a new order, in which AVALANCHE is destroyed and the company's narrative of events is uncontested.

AVALANCHE's violence aspires to be law-making, the founding violence of a revolution, but it cannot found anything. The cell is too small, its strategy too improvised, its support among the people it claims to defend too thin. The game registers the futility without contempt: after Sector 7 the cell effectively dissolves into the party, and its political project gives way to a pursuit of Sephiroth that no longer concerns reactors at all.

Holy, finally, has the formal properties of divine violence. It is not an instrument of any party; it founds no order; it is summoned by prayer rather than wielded; it threatens to annihilate whatever endangers the Planet, without regard to the law of any human polity. Benjamin's concept has been read with alarm, and Jacques Derrida's "Force of Law" (1990) warned of the dangers latent in any doctrine of a violence that sanctifies itself by its transcendence of law. The game knows the danger. It is Bugenhagen, the sage of the Planet, who warns that Holy may judge humanity itself to be the threat. Divine violence in *Final Fantasy VII* is not a solution; it is a risk that the Planet takes and that the ending leaves unresolved.

7.3 Deep ecology and its critics

Murray Bookchin's social ecology answered deep ecology with a historical argument: the domination of nature arises from the domination of human beings by human beings, and ecological crisis is therefore a consequence of social hierarchy rather than of humanity as such (Bookchin 1982). In a polemic of 1987 he attacked the biocentrism of deep ecology

for drifting toward misanthropy, and he named its targets. The Earth First! co-founder Dave Foreman had said in a 1986 interview that the best response to famine in Ethiopia was to let nature seek its own balance and let the starving die; and a 1987 article in the movement's journal, signed "Miss Ann Thropy" and later attributed to Christopher Manes, had suggested that AIDS might serve as a welcome check on human population. Foreman and Bookchin later debated their differences in a public dialogue published in 1991 (Bookchin and Foreman 1991), and after the late 1980s Earth First! became associated chiefly with nonviolent direct action.

The game takes Bookchin's side more consistently than its opening suggests. Its sympathy lies with the slum, not with an abstract Planet set against humanity. The people of Sector 7 depend on Shinra's electricity; AVALANCHE's bombings threaten their livelihoods; Barret's own daughter lives beneath the plate. Shinra's crime is presented as social at every scale, the plate above the slum and the company above the people, as much as it is ecological. Yet the misanthropic temptation is lodged in the game's cosmology itself, in the immune logic of the WEAPONs and in Holy's indifference to the distinction between invader and inhabitant, and the epilogue, which shows no human being, declines to dispel it. The game refuses both the anthropocentrism that treats the Planet as a resource and the misanthropy that treats humanity as a disease. It holds open the question of whether humanity can learn to be something other than a pathogen, and it locates the answer in the relation to the dead.

7.4 Barret: complicity, prosthesis and the shadow

Barret fights not from purity but from complicity. Chapter Three described his history: he championed the reactor that destroyed his town, and his war against Shinra is in part a war against his own past judgment. The game's most militant ecologist is a man who once accepted the bargain he now opposes, and his militancy is inseparable from his guilt.

His body bears the history. In place of his right hand he wears a gun, fitted after the massacre at Corel. Donna Haraway's cyborg (1985), the boundary figure of organism and machine, and Marshall McLuhan's account of media as extensions of the human body (1964) both illuminate the prosthesis: grief has extended Barret's body into a weapon. The game, characteristically, also makes the prosthesis an item of inventory, purchasable and exchangeable in weapon shops, so that the player equips Barret's grief from a catalogue.

Barret's shadow is Dyne, his closest friend, who lost his hand in the same massacre and believed his wife and infant daughter dead. Dyne went mad in the desert prison beneath the Gold Saucer and now wants only to destroy the world that took everything from him. In Nietzsche's terms he has passed from passive nihilism, the exhaustion of values, to active nihilism, the will to destruction; in Jung's, he is the shadow, the repressed dark potential of the personality, met as another person (Jung 1951). Barret must fight him. Dyne, defeated, asks Barret to give a pendant to the daughter he believed lost, and then takes

his own life, stepping backward off the cliff. Freud observed in "Trauer und Melancholie" that the melancholic, having installed the lost object within himself, turns against himself the hostility the object provoked, and that this is what makes self-destruction possible for him; Dyne, who has turned his losses into a will to destroy the world, ends by destroying himself. That daughter is Marlene, whom Barret has raised as his own since Corel.

The detail completes a structure of the greatest importance to this dissertation. Barret's fatherhood is an inheritance from the dead: he raises his dead friend's child, openly, as a gift and a charge. Cloud incorporated his dead friend's identity in secret, in place of mourning him. Barret received his dead friend's daughter in public, as a form of mourning him. The same relation to a dead friend appears in its pathological and its healthy forms, in the protagonist and in the man who first hired him.

A critical note is required. Barret is the only Black-coded member of the cast, and his characterization draws on imported stereotypes: a resemblance, often remarked, to the actor Mr. T in his role as B. A. Baracus in the American action series *The A-Team* (1983–87), which belongs to the original character design, and, in the 1997 English localization, a rendering of his speech as an exaggerated, stereotyped version of African American English, which belongs largely to the translation. John G. Russell's study of the Black Other in Japanese mass culture (1991) analysed the circulation of such images in Japan's postwar media, and Barret belongs to that history. The game gives him the moral centre of its ecological plot and the most explicit story of guilt and repair in its cast, and it renders him through a lens it did not examine. Both facts belong to the record.

7.5 Reeve and Cait Sith: conscience inside the apparatus

Reeve, Shinra's head of urban development, is the board member who hesitates. He operates, from his office in Midgar, a remote-controlled robot: a fortune-telling cat that rides a giant stuffed moogle, called Cait Sith after a fairy cat of Scottish and Irish folklore. Cait Sith joins the party at the Gold Saucer and is later revealed to be a Shinra spy, holding Marlene and Elmyra hostage to secure the party's cooperation, while quietly ensuring their safety. In time Reeve turns fully against the company.

Hannah Arendt, returning in her late essay "Thinking and Moral Considerations" (1971) to the problem posed by Eichmann, asked whether the activity of thinking, the silent dialogue of the self with itself, might condition people against evildoing. The banal functionary does not think; he performs a role. Reeve thinks. His double agency is the form that thought takes within an apparatus that forbids it: complicity and resistance carried on at once, with the risk of both.

Cait Sith also offers the game's most surprising lesson about the dead. In the Temple of the Ancients, the first Cait Sith is crushed retrieving the Black Materia, and a second, identical unit soon arrives to take its place. The replaceable body is a comic counterpart

to the numbered clones of Chapter Four; a mass-produced puppet should be the one being in the game that can die without being mourned. Yet the scene of the first unit's destruction is given unexpected pathos, and the party treats the loss as a loss. Japanese practice has a rite for exactly this: *ningyō kuyō*, the memorial service for dolls, in which dolls that have served their owners are given thanks and ritual release before disposal. In mourning a doll, the game extends the anamnetic mode to the very category of the copy.

7.6 Wutai: the defeated nation

The nation of Wutai, in the far west of the world map, fought a war against Shinra and lost; it was in that war that Sephiroth became a hero. Wutai is now a small town of pagodas, souvenir shops and decorated streets. Its lord, Godo, has accepted defeat and peace. His daughter Yuffie, a ninja and a thief, steals the party's materia because she dreams of restoring Wutai's strength and pride.

The parallel with postwar Japan is difficult to avoid: a nation defeated in 1945 by the United States, an industrial power of overwhelming scale, occupied until 1952 and given a constitution whose ninth article renounces war; its leadership accommodating the victor, its martial culture converted into tourism and commerce, and a younger generation torn between the accommodation and a revanchist nostalgia it does not fully understand. Iwabuchi Koichi argued that Japanese cultural exports have often been *mukokuseki*, "without nationality", their characters and settings stripped of marked Japaneseness in order to circulate globally (Iwabuchi 2002). *Final Fantasy VII*'s world is largely *mukokuseki:* Midgar, Junon and Costa del Sol are nowhere in particular. The single exception is Wutai, the one place marked as Japanese or East Asian, and it is marked as defeated, comic and exoticized. The national self returns in the only place it is visible, as the vanquished other. The structure is a form of self-orientalism, the adoption of an outside gaze upon one's own tradition.

The Wutai War also supplies Sephiroth's origin as a public figure. Cloud idolized him as the hero of the war, known through Shinra's publicity; the hero of an imperial war becomes the destroyer of the world. The hero cult produced by an expansionist corporate state returns, in the end, as a vengeful spirit.

Japan's own institution for its war dead makes the stakes of this reading concrete, and it is the most contested site in modern Japan of the relation between the living and the dead. Yasukuni Shrine in Tokyo, founded in 1869 as the Tokyo Shōkonsha to enshrine those who died fighting for the imperial state and renamed in 1879, venerates some 2.46 million war dead as *kami*. On 17 October 1978, in rites conducted without public announcement by its chief priest, Matsudaira Nagayoshi, it enshrined fourteen men convicted or indicted as Class A war criminals by the International Military Tribunal for the Far East, among them the wartime prime minister Tōjō Hideki. The Shōwa emperor, who had last visited in 1975, never returned, and a memorandum kept by a former head of the

Imperial Household Agency, published in 2006, recorded that the enshrinement was his reason. Visits by sitting prime ministers, above all Koizumi Jun'ichirō's annual visits from 2001 to 2006, have drawn protests from China and South Korea and divided Japanese opinion. The shrine's defenders, among them the Japan War Bereaved Association, hold that it is where the nation honours those who gave their lives for it, that the bereaved have a right to mourn them there, and that leaders who visit come to mourn and to pray for peace rather than to glorify war, as Koizumi repeatedly insisted. The shrine also holds that the spirits of the enshrined have merged into a single divine presence, like drops of water in the sea, and cannot be separated; on that ground it has refused requests from families in Taiwan, South Korea, Okinawa and elsewhere in Japan, some of them pursued in the courts, to remove their relatives' names, including names entered without the families' knowledge or consent. The philosopher Takahashi Tetsuya has described the shrine as an "alchemy of emotion" that turns the anger and loss of the bereaved into pride and gratitude toward the state (Takahashi 2005); defenders such as Nitta Hitoshi have offered a passionate defence of the shrine and of prime-ministerial visits (both are represented in Breen 2007). In the terms of this study the dispute is a dispute over necrometabolism: whether the shrine performs acknowledgment and the pacification of the dead (*chinkon*), as its defenders hold, or incorporates the dead into a sovereign narrative, as its critics argue, and whether a family may claim the release of its own dead. The dissertation does not adjudicate the political controversy. It notes that the game's Wutai War, whose decorated hero becomes a vengeful spirit, is set in the territory of that dispute, and that the question the game poses about its own dead, whether they are to be held or released, is the question on which the dispute has turned.

7.7 Rocket Town: earth alienation and its reversal

Cid Highwind was to have been the first human in space. Shinra's rocket stands in his town, its launch aborted years earlier when his assistant Shera insisted on a final inspection of an oxygen tank; Shinra then cut the space programme's funding in favour of mako. Cid has never forgiven Shera, and he treats her with contempt.

Hannah Arendt opened *The Human Condition* (1958) with the launch of the first artificial satellite in 1957 and the relief with which it was greeted, as a first step toward humanity's escape from its imprisonment on earth. Arendt took the reaction as a symptom. The earth, she argued, is the very quintessence of the human condition, and the wish to escape it expresses an alienation from the world that modernity had been deepening for centuries. Shinra's abandoned space programme and Sephiroth's plan to ride the Planet through the cosmos are two forms of earth alienation, one technological, one Gnostic.

The game reverses the trajectory. On the second disc Shinra relaunches the rocket, loaded with Huge Materia, to destroy Meteor; Cid is aboard. The rocket built to leave the Planet is aimed instead at defending it. In space, facing failure, Cid learns that Shera's

caution about the oxygen tank had been justified, and he acknowledges it. He and his companions escape in a pod, and the Planet appears below them, whole. James Lovelock, it will be recalled, conceived the Gaia hypothesis while working on NASA's planetary missions, and the Apollo photographs of the whole earth (1968–72) gave environmentalism its emblem; Frank White later named the transformation reported by astronauts who saw the planet from space the overview effect (White 1987). Cid's dream of leaving the Planet is fulfilled only as a vision of it, and the vision converts him. The care that he despised, Shera's patient attention to the oxygen tank, is vindicated against the heroism he worshipped.

7.8 Cosmo Canyon: the recognition of a father

Red XIII, whose name is the designation Hojo gave him and whose true name is Nanaki, grew up believing that his father Seto had fled when the Gi tribe attacked Cosmo Canyon, abandoning his mother and his people. His grandfather Bugenhagen leads him into the Cave of the Gi, where they find Seto, standing alone at the pass he defended, turned to stone by the poisoned arrows of the Gi. He had saved the canyon and been forgotten. As Nanaki understands, the stone figure weeps.

Aristotle defined recognition, *anagnōrisis*, as a change from ignorance to knowledge (*Poetics* 1452a), and the canyon scene is a recognition in his strict sense, but its object is unusual: not the identity of a living person but the truth of a dead one's deed. The episode is the correction of a false memory of the dead, and it rhymes with Cloud's correction of his own. Both recover the truth of a death that had been misremembered; both restore to a dead man the deed that was his. Justice to the dead, in this game, takes the form of accurate memory.

Cosmo Canyon is also the home of the Study of Planet Life, a community of scholars gathered around an observatory, and of the perpetual flame at its heart, around which the party sits on the eve of the descent into the cave and speaks of what each has lost. Against Midgar's combustion the canyon keeps a fire that burns for hospitality and memory. Its sage bears the name of the Wittenberg reformer, and the Study of Planet Life is, in this register, a reformation: a reconstitution of religious consciousness around the Planet and its dead. The canyon's visual coding borrows from the imagery of the American Southwest, with the attendant risk of the noble-savage trope; the game mitigates the risk by presenting the canyon as a cosmopolitan scholarly community rather than an ethnic enclave, but does not wholly escape it. Bugenhagen dies near the end of the journey, with Nanaki beside him. In the epilogue it is Nanaki, five hundred years older, who witnesses what the Planet has become.

7.9 Vincent Valentine: the crypt made literal

In the basement of the Shinra Mansion, the party finds a coffin, and in it a man who has been sleeping there for decades. Vincent Valentine was a Turk who loved Lucrecia Crescent and failed to stop the experiment that made her the mother of Sephiroth; Hojo shot him and used him as a subject, and he has since slept in the coffin as penance.

Abraham and Torok's crypt, the sealed intrapsychic tomb in which an unmourned loss is preserved in secret (Chapter Five), is here made literal. Vincent lives in his own tomb, in the basement of the house of science, preserving a loss he has never mourned. His transformations in battle make him an archive of the horror genre's monsters: his Limit Breaks turn him into a lycanthropic beast, a stitched giant in the image of Frankenstein's creature, a masked killer wielding a chainsaw in the image of the 1970s slasher film, and finally a winged demon. The Gothic tradition, from Shelley's *Frankenstein* to Stoker's *Dracula* (1897), with its coffins, its undead and its scientific monsters, is carried in a single body. Behind a waterfall, Vincent finds Lucrecia herself, encased in crystal, grieving the son she never held. He can do nothing for her. His atonement is never completed, but he leaves the coffin and joins the living. His arc runs from crypt to company.

7.10 The fellowship of the bereaved

The survey yields a pattern too consistent to be accidental. Every member of the party is constituted by a relation to the dead. Cloud carries Zack, his mother and Aerith. Barret carries Myrna, Dyne and Corel. Tifa carries her father, killed by Sephiroth, her mother, lost in childhood, and Nibelheim. Aerith carried Ifalna, Gast and the whole Cetra. Nanaki carries Seto and, at the end, Bugenhagen. Vincent carries Lucrecia and the life he forfeited. Cid carries a dead dream, the rocket that never flew. Yuffie carries the war dead of a defeated nation and their lost pride. Cait Sith carries his own replaceable death, and Reeve the people of Sector 7 whom his company killed.

Émile Durkheim, in *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912), analysed mourning as a piacular rite: an obligatory collective observance through which a group, struck by death, reaffirms its solidarity. The party's solidarity is constituted in exactly this way. It is not an army, a company or a movement; it is a company of mourners, bound by shared loss and by the shared work of carrying a dead woman's prayer to its fulfilment.

On the night before the final descent, aboard the airship Highwind, Cloud tells his companions to leave, to find whatever it is they are fighting for, and to return only if they find it. Each departs: to a daughter, to a grave, to a home, to a memory. All return at dawn. The scene has the structure of Obon in miniature: departure to one's dead and one's living, and return. Paul Ricoeur described the duty of memory as the duty to do justice, through memory, to an other than the self (Ricoeur 2000). The night on the Highwind is the party discharging that duty before it goes down into the Crater.

The party is therefore the counter-institution to Shinra. Shinra is an organization that uses the dead. The party is an association constituted by mourning them.

7.11 A politics of mourning

The game's political philosophy can now be stated. It rejects AVALANCHE's terror, which cannot found an order and harms the people it would defend, and it rejects Shinra's technocratic order, which founds itself on the combustion of the dead and the manufacture of enemies. It proposes instead, without ever stating it, a criterion of legitimacy: a community is legitimate in the measure that it stands rightly toward its dead and its unborn. Shinra burns its dead; Sephiroth would devour them; Jenova counterfeits them; the party remembers them.

The criterion has an unexpected ancestor. Edmund Burke, defending inherited institutions against the French Revolution, described society as *a partnership not only between those who are living, but between those who are living, those who are dead, and those who are to be born* (*Reflections on the Revolution in France*, 1790). Burke's sentence is the charter of a conservatism, and *Final Fantasy VII* is in many respects a radical work, hostile to concentrated corporate power, sympathetic to the dispossessed and to the eco-saboteur's grievance if not to his methods. Its politics joins what are usually opposed: Bookchin's critique of hierarchy and Burke's partnership with the dead. The game is radical in its account of what has gone wrong and ancestral in its account of what would make it right. Chapter Ten argues that this combination is not a confusion but the precise content of an ethic of planetary *kuyō*.

CHAPTER EIGHT

VIII

Cosmography and the Japanese Apocalyptic Imagination

The world of *Final Fantasy VII* is a cosmogram, its ending an eschatology, and its place in the history of speculative fiction is that of a synthesis. It binds three apocalyptic idioms that had developed largely apart: the eco-apocalyptic, in which a wounded nature turns on those who wound it; the techno-gnostic, in which science manufactures a false god or a false salvation; and the corporate-dystopian, in which a private power administers a ruined world. The binding agent is its theory of the dead. This chapter reads the game's cosmography through Norse eschatology and Mircea Eliade's history of religions, its handling of myth through the summoned gods, its millennialism through the Japanese apocalyptic imagination of the late twentieth century, and its originality through a comparative field that runs from Wagner and Shelley to Miyazaki, Tomino and Anno.

8.1 The world map as cosmogram

The names on the world map compose a cosmology in miniature. Midgar is the enclosed world of humans; Nibelheim, a realm of mist and of buried treasure; Gaea's Cliff, the face of the earth goddess; Junon, Shinra's military harbour and the site of its great cannon, bears the name of the queen of the Roman gods, patroness of the state; Cosmo Canyon is named for order itself. Between them lie places whose names describe relations to the dead. The Forgotten Capital is a necropolis, a city of the Cetra preserved in silence, its houses shaped like shells. The Temple of the Ancients, once its puzzles are solved, folds itself into a single materia: an architecture that becomes a crystal of memory. Bone Village is a settlement of excavators whose economy is digging in the earth for what the past has buried, a village that lives by exhumation.

The opening sequence states the cosmology in a single movement of the camera. It begins among stars, the sky from which the calamity and the meteor will come; descends to the face of a young woman holding flowers in an alley lit by green mako, the last of the Cetra and the medium of the dead; draws back over the streets and the plates until the whole disc of Midgar fills the screen, the anti-mandala of Chapter Three; and only after the title follows a train into the station where the bombers wait. Sky, flower, city, terror: the first minute of the game is a cosmogram of the whole.

At the top of the world lies the Northern Crater, and it is the game's sacred centre in the sense Eliade gave the term: the *axis mundi* at which heaven, earth and underworld communicate (Eliade 1957). It is the place where Jenova fell from the sky two thousand years ago, where the Planet has gathered its Lifestream ever since to heal the wound, where the real Sephiroth sleeps, and where the final descent takes place, down through cavernous strata glowing with the current of the dead. It is navel and wound at once. The game's cosmic centre is not a mountain of the gods but an impact scar, and the descent into it is a descent into the place where the world was injured.

8.2 Norse eschatology: a world made from a corpse

The Norse cosmology from which Midgar takes its name is itself a necrometabolic cosmogony. In Snorri Sturluson's *Gylfaginning* (c. 1220), the gods Odin and his brothers kill the primordial giant Ymir and build the world from his body: the earth from his flesh, the sea from his blood, mountains from his bones, the sky from his skull; and Miðgarðr, the dwelling of humans, is enclosed by a wall made from his eyebrows. The human world is built from a dead body. Comparable cosmogonies, in which the cosmos is made from a sacrificed primordial being, include the Puruṣa of the Ṛgveda and the Chinese Pangu. *Final Fantasy VII* inherits the deep structure of this mythic type and makes it modern: Midgar is built not from a single slain giant but from the current of all the Planet's dead, and the dismemberment is ongoing, conducted by eight reactors.

Norse eschatology also supplies the shape of the ending. At Ragnarök the gods fall, the wolf swallows the sun, the fire-giant Surtr burns the world and the earth sinks into the sea. The *Völuspá* then sees the world reborn: *Sér hon upp koma / öðru sinni / jörð ór ægi / iðjagræna*, she sees come up a second time the earth from the sea, ever green. The fields bear without being sown. Two humans, Líf and Lífþrasir, "Life" and "Life-striver", survive the conflagration hidden in the wood of Hoddmímir, nourished by the morning dew, and from them the world is repopulated (*Vafþrúðnismál* 45; *Gylfaginning* 53).

The epilogue of *Final Fantasy VII* is a post-Ragnarök vision. After stone from the sky and white fire, the city of humans lies green, reclaimed by vegetation. What the epilogue withholds is Líf and Lífþrasir. No human appears. The question the Norse myth answers, whether humanity survives the end of its world, the game leaves open in 1997; *Advent Children*, eight years later, answers it by setting its story two years after the crisis among the survivors. The original's refusal to show the surviving pair is its most daring formal decision about the future. It is examined in the Conclusion.

8.3 Eliade: the centre, the eternal return and the terror of history

Eliade argued that archaic societies abolished history by periodically re-enacting the cosmogonic myth, returning to the time of origins and thereby renewing the world; and that modern humanity, having lost this recourse, stands exposed to the "terror of history", the experience of catastrophic events that possess no transhistorical meaning (Eliade 1949). Japan in 1995 had just experienced the terror of history in concentrated form: an earthquake that destroyed a city, an attack on the capital's subway by a religious movement, a nuclear accident concealed by its operator.

The game articulates three temporalities and assigns them to its powers. The Lifestream lives in cyclical time, the time of return. Shinra lives in linear time, the time of progress, which is also the time of depletion. Sephiroth lives in eschatological time, the time of an end he means to hasten and occupy. The ending does not choose among them. It introduces a fourth: the natal time of a beginning, shown in an epilogue whose last im-

age is of newborn creatures running toward the future. In Eliade's terms, the game offers its players a cosmological frame within which catastrophe is not meaningless, without pretending that the frame abolishes history.

8.4 The monomyth inverted

Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949) described a monomyth of departure, initiation and return: the call to adventure, the crossing of a threshold, the road of trials, the meeting with the goddess, atonement with the father, apotheosis, the ultimate boon, and the return of the hero as master of two worlds. Game design absorbed Campbell's scheme, often directly, in the decades after 1977. *Final Fantasy VII* inverts it point by point.

The call to adventure is a paid contract. The meeting with the goddess ends with the goddess dead. Atonement with the father is impossible, because the paternal figures are the villains: Sephiroth, the hero Cloud idolized, and Hojo, Sephiroth's father. The apotheosis is the antagonist's ambition, not the hero's achievement. The hero's descent to the underworld is a nervous collapse, and his rescue comes from without, through a woman who descends after him. The return occurs five hundred years later, and the hero is absent from it. Most tellingly, the monomyth's summit, the hero's apotheosis, is assigned to Sephiroth and repudiated. Cloud's achievement is the refusal of apotheosis: the acceptance of mortality, of failure, of a self constituted by others and by the dead. The monomyth is the story of a man who becomes a god; *Final Fantasy VII* is the story of a man who learns that he is not one, and of a man who would not learn it.

8.5 The summoned gods

The player's inventory contains a pantheon. The red summon materia call down Shiva, named for the Hindu god of destruction; Ifrit, a jinn of Islamic tradition; Titan, of the Greek giants; Odin, the Norse All-Father; Leviathan, the sea monster of the Hebrew Bible; Bahamut, the great fish of Arabic cosmology, refashioned by the series as a dragon king; Kujata, the cosmic bull which, in the same cosmology, bears the world upon its back; Alexander, named for the conqueror; Phoenix, Hades and Typhon from the Greek; and, in the longest animation of the game, the Knights of the Round from Arthurian romance. The world's religions are gathered, reduced to red crystals and slotted into armour, their powers expressed as quantities of damage and their invocation priced in magic points.

The operation performed on the gods is the one Shinra performs on the dead. Weber's disenchantment converts mysterious powers into calculable ones; Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technical reproducibility (1935–36) described the loss of aura, the unique presence of a thing in time and space, under mechanical reproduction; Heidegger described the reduction of beings to standing-reserve. The summon is the god

reproduced on demand, its aura replaced by animation, its being reduced to a function available whenever the player has the points to spend. The game's own system thereby enacts on the world's mythologies the combustive logic its narrative condemns. Chapter Nine pursues the point.

Yet the summons are also a museum of dead gods, kept in circulation, whose names a generation of players learned from them. The ambivalence can be stated in the terms of Chapter Six. The *itako* practise *kuchiyose*, summoning the voice of the dead so that the dead may speak; the summoner borrows the god's power so that the summoner may act. The first lends a voice; the second takes a force. The summon materia sit precisely on the line between remembrance and use.

8.6 Millennial Japan

Gotō Ben's *Nosutoradamusu no daiyogen* (1973) and its sequels, together with the Tōhō film adapted from it in 1974, made Nostradamus's prophecy of a great King of Terror descending from the sky in the seventh month of 1999 part of the common imagination of postwar Japan. For a generation the year 1999 carried an expectation of catastrophe; Aum Shinrikyō drew on the same expectation in its apocalyptic teaching. The early, abandoned concept for *Final Fantasy VII* was reportedly set in 1999, and the game that was made, released at the end of 1990s Japan's most catastrophic years, is organized around a calamity from the sky.

The image of celestial impact had acquired new scientific authority. The Alvarez hypothesis (1980) attributed the extinction at the end of the Cretaceous to an asteroid; the identification of the Chicxulub crater in 1991 confirmed the site; the collision of Comet Shoemaker–Levy 9 with Jupiter in July 1994 was watched around the world. Japanese cinema had imagined such a collision long before: Tōhō's *Gorath* (1962) depicted a rogue star on course for the earth and humanity's project to move the planet out of its path. *Final Fantasy VII*'s Meteor preceded by a year the Hollywood impact films of 1998.

Susan Napier described an apocalyptic mode running through postwar anime, shaped by the memory of 1945, when American atomic bombs destroyed Hiroshima on 6 August and Nagasaki on 9 August and killed well over a hundred thousand people by the end of that year, and alternating between elegiac and festive registers, between apocalypse mourned and apocalypse enjoyed (Napier 2001). *Final Fantasy VII* belongs to the elegiac register. Its catastrophes are mourned, not savoured; its spectacle of planetary destruction, Supernova, is assigned to the villain as a sign of his kitsch.

The founding monster of Japanese cinema belongs to the same memory. Honda Ishirō's *Gojira* (1954) was made months after the crew of the tuna boat *Daigo Fukuryū Maru* were contaminated by fallout from the American hydrogen-bomb test at Bikini Atoll on 1 March 1954; the boat's radio operator, Kuboyama Aikichi, died that September. Its monster, awakened and transformed by nuclear testing, rises from the sea to level a coastal

capital. The WEAPONs, which rise from the Planet's seas and wastes to attack the harbour city of Junon and the capital Midgar, belong to this lineage of the *kaiju*: bodies given to the retaliation of a world injured by the energies modernity released.

8.7 The Japanese comparative field

Miyazaki Hayao's manga of *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* (1982–94) is the most important comparison in the Japanese field. In its world a toxic forest, the Sea of Corruption, spreads across a land poisoned by an ancient industrial war, and the giant insects called Ohmu defend it. Nausicaä discovers that the forest is purifying the poisoned soil, and then, in the manga's final volumes, that both the forest and the present human race were engineered by the ancient civilization: the forest to cleanse the world, the humans to live only in the poisoned world, so that they will die when the purification is complete and be replaced by a stored, purified humanity. At the Crypt of Shuwa she destroys the system that preserves the plan, choosing impure, mortal life over an engineered purity, and affirms that life is light shining in darkness. *Final Fantasy VII* shares the manga's structure of planetary purification and its suspicion of purity, but diverges at the decisive point: in Miyazaki the purification is a human design, in Kitase's game it is the Planet's own immune response, and its verdict on humanity is left open rather than refused.

Laputa: Castle in the Sky (1986) imagines a floating city of an ancient civilization, raised by a crystal of levitation stone and armed with terrible weapons, sought by Muska, a descendant of its royal line who would rule the world. The heroine Sheeta answers that power severed from the soil cannot sustain life, and the castle, its weapons destroyed, rises into the sky carried by the roots of a great tree. Muska and Sephiroth are both heirs of a vanished people who would use its powers to dominate the world; the crystal is a materia. *Princess Mononoke*, released in July 1997, six months after the game, sets Irontown, an ironworks that clears the forest and arms itself with guns, against the Forest Spirit, a deity that gives and takes life; when the Spirit is decapitated, its headless body spreads death across the land until the head is returned, and the land greens. Lady Eboshi, the ironworks' leader, extracts and kills, yet also shelters lepers and women freed from brothels: a Shinra with a conscience, a complication the game assigns instead to Reeve.

Neon Genesis Evangelion (1995–96), whose cinematic conclusion *The End of Evangelion* followed in July 1997, is the contemporary with which the game is most often paired, and the pairing is just, provided influence is not claimed. Both deploy Kabbalistic iconography: the Tree of Life is painted on the ceiling of the commander's office in Anno Hideaki's series. Both turn, at their climaxes, into the interior of a protagonist whose self has collapsed. Both imagine the dissolution of individual egos into a collective sea: Evangelion's Human Instrumentality Project would merge all human souls into a single undifferentiated whole. The comparison clarifies the Lifestream. Instrumentality is a dissolution of all into all, imposed by a secret organization as the final step of human evolution;

the Lifestream is a dissolution of all into all that occurs naturally at death and periodically gives life back. Sephiroth's project is neither: it is the dissolution of all into one. And both works end with a protagonist who chooses to return from collapse into a world of other people, accepting the pain of separate existence: Shinji Ikari on the shore of the red sea, Cloud Strife beside Tifa.

Ōtomo Katsuhiro's *Akira* (manga 1982–90; film 1988) set in a rebuilt Tokyo a government programme that numbers and drugs psychic children, and a boy whose involuntary apotheosis destroys the city. Tomino Yoshiyuki's *Mobile Suit Gundam: Char's Counterattack* (1988) provides the closest structural antecedent to the ending: Char Aznable attempts to drop the asteroid fortress Axis onto the earth in order to force humanity into space and let the planet recover, and the asteroid is turned aside when the collective will of many pilots, amplified by a psychoreactive frame, emerges as a great aurora of light that pushes against it. An eco-motivated meteor is repelled by collective will made visible as light. In *Final Fantasy VII* the collective will that repels the meteor belongs not to the living but to the dead. Tomino's earlier *Space Runaway Ideon* (1980–81) and its film *The Ideon: Be Invoked* (1982) had made the collective will of an extinct civilization's dead the power behind a giant machine, and ended with the death of every character and the passage of their souls to a new world to be reborn. Ideon is the Lifestream's darker ancestor: the dead as agent, without the ancestral consolation.

8.8 The Western comparative field

Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) built a planetary ecology around a resource, the spice melange, that is at once an economy and a medium of consciousness, produced by a cycle involving giant sandworms; it gave its ecology a scientist-sage, the planetologist Liet-Kynes; and it described a centuries-long breeding programme designed to produce a superhuman, whose success Herbert presented as a catastrophe, warning against the charismatic hero. Mako, Bugenhagen and the Jenova Project correspond point for point, with one inversion: Herbert's messiah succeeds and his success is the danger; Sephiroth fails, and his failure is the world's survival.

Tolkien supplies the fading elder race, the industrialization of Isengard and its forest felled for fuel, and the Ents whose wrath at the destruction of their trees resembles the WEAPONs' intrusion. Le Guin supplies Omelas (Chapter Three) and *The Word for World Is Forest* (1972), in which colonists log a forest world and the dreaming natives are transformed by learning to kill, as AVALANCHE is shadowed by what its violence makes of it. C. S. Lewis's *That Hideous Strength* (1945) supplies a closer parallel than is usually noticed: a technocratic institute whose scientists keep alive the severed head of an executed colleague, through which alien intelligences speak, and one of whose members dreams of an earth cleansed of organic life, its trees replaced by metal. Jenova's severed head, Shinra's science and Hojo's contempt for life are prefigured there. John W. Campbell's and H. P.

Lovecraft's polar mimics stand behind Jenova (Chapter Four). Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981), the masterpiece of modern Gnostic science fiction, describes a revelation that the world is a prison maintained by a false order, and leaves undecided whether the revelation is true; Sephiroth's revelation is decided, and it is forged. William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984) and Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982), with its pyramid headquarters and its manufactured beings, supply the cyberpunk grammar of corporate sovereignty from which Midgar's upper plate is drawn.

8.9 The comparative field at a glance

Work	Year	Structure shared with Final Fantasy VII	Decisive divergence
Shelley, *Frankenstein*	1818	A made being learns its origin from its maker's papers and answers with fire	The Creature reads truly; Sephiroth misreads
Wagner, *Der Ring des Nibelungen*	1876	A natural treasure seized for power; the curse lifted by return to the source	The gods burn; in the game the dead rise
Campbell, "Who Goes There?"	1938	A polar alien that imitates what it absorbs	Jenova imitates the dead in particular
Lewis, *That Hideous Strength*	1945	A technocratic institute; a severed head speaking for alien powers	Christian supernatural against planetary immanence
Herbert, *Dune*	1965	A resource ecology; a breeding programme for a superhuman	Herbert's messiah succeeds; Sephiroth fails
Le Guin, "Omelas"	1973	Prosperity founded on hidden suffering	The party walks away and then returns to fight
Tomino, *Ideon*	1980–82	The collective will of an extinct people's dead as an agent	Ideon ends in universal death; the game in salvation by the dead
Dick, *VALIS*	1981	Gnostic revelation of a false order	Dick's gnosis may be true; Sephiroth's is forged
Miyazaki, *Nausicaä* (manga)	1982–94	Planetary purification; refusal of an engineered purity	The game's purification is the Planet's own, its verdict left open
Ōtomo, *Akira*	1982–90	Numbered experimental children; an apotheosis that destroys a city	Tetsuo's apotheosis is involuntary; Sephiroth's is willed
Miyazaki, *Laputa*	1986	A crystal-powered ancient civilization; an heir seeking dominion	Muska wants weapons; Sephiroth wants godhood
Tomino, *Char's Counterattack*	1988	An eco-motivated meteor turned back by collective will made light	The will of the living against the will of the dead
Oshii, *Ghost in the Shell*	1995	Implanted false memory of a life never lived	Cloud is partly the author of his counterfeit
Anno, *Evangelion*	1995–97	Kabbalistic iconography; dissolution of egos; the protagonist's interior	Instrumentality is imposed; the Lifestream is natural; Sephiroth would invert both

8.10 The binding of three idioms

The comparison yields the game's place. The eco-apocalyptic idiom, running from Tolkien and Herbert through Le Guin to Miyazaki, imagines a wounded nature turning against its wounders. The techno-gnostic idiom, running from Shelley through Dick to *Evangelion* and Square's own *Xenogears*, imagines science manufacturing a false god or a false salvation. The corporate-dystopian idiom, running from Lang through Gibson to *Blade Runner*, imagines a private power administering a ruined world. *Final Fantasy VII* contains all three, and its originality lies not in any element but in the principle that binds them. The eco-apocalypse is the combustion of the dead. The techno-gnosis is their incorporation. The corporate dystopia is their counterfeit: the rebuilt village, the propaganda broadcast, the hero cult. Each idiom names a mode of necrometabolism, and the game's ending, in which the dead themselves rise to answer all three, is the point at which the idioms meet. The next chapter turns from the world the game depicts to the game as a system that the player operates, and asks whether the form of play confesses what the story condemns.

CHAPTER NINE

IX

Ludic Form as Argument

The Materia Economy, the Body in Battle and the Franchise as Lifestream

The systems of *Final Fantasy VII* confess what its story condemns. The player who equips and cultivates materia performs, in miniature, the combustive relation to the dead; the player who breeds chocobos for a summon performs Hojo's; the player who walks through Cloud's false memory performs Jenova's. The game does not resolve this complicity; it makes it available to reflection, and in one decisive sequence it moves the player from the position of the counterfeit to the position of the witness. This chapter reads the game's rules as arguments, then follows the structure outward to the franchise that grew from the game, which has reproduced the problem of necrometabolism at the scale of an industry and, in the Remake project, has made that problem its explicit subject.

9.1 Systems as arguments

Ian Bogost's procedural rhetoric holds that rule systems persuade by modelling processes the player must enact (Bogost 2007); Espen Aarseth's ergodic literature requires nontrivial effort to traverse (Aarseth 1997); Jesper Juul places the meaning of games in the interplay between real rules and fictional worlds (Juul 2005). Clint Hocking's influential term "ludonarrative dissonance" (2007) named the incoherence that arises when a game's mechanics contradict its story. The present chapter proposes a distinction. Dissonance is incoherence: the system and the story pull apart without meaning anything by it. Irony is meaningful tension: the system makes the player enact what the story asks them to judge, so that the judgment is formed from inside. *Final Fantasy VII*'s tensions are ironies. Whether they were designed as such is a Tier I question the evidence cannot settle; that they function as such is a Tier III claim this chapter defends.

9.2 The materia economy

Weapons and armour carry slots, some of them linked in pairs; materia set into the slots grant spells, summons, commands and passive enhancements; materia gain ability points in battle, grow through levels, and at mastery give birth to a new materia while the original remains. Materia can be bought in shops, found in the world, won from enemies and manufactured by Shinra. They can also be stolen: in Wutai, Yuffie strips the party of its entire collection, a reminder that the player's hoard is a property relation that can be expropriated in its turn.

The player's practice is the cultivation of crystallized Lifestream. Battles are fought, often repeated for no other purpose, so that the condensed knowledge of the dead will grow and multiply. Ability points convert the dead's knowledge into increments of power; mastery converts accumulated power into reproduction. Marx's general formula for capital, M–C–M′, in which money passes through the commodity to return as more money, has an exact analogue in the materia economy, in which materia passes through battle to

return as more materia. The player who grinds the materia to mastery is, in the precise sense the narrative has taught, a small Shinra: harvesting the condensed dead for power.

Three readings of this irony are possible, and they are not exclusive. The first is commercial: the genre requires a progression system, and the materia economy is the form that requirement took. This reading is true and explains nothing about meaning. The second is pedagogical: the player learns the attraction of extraction from inside, so that the game's critique of Shinra is not a sermon delivered by the innocent but a recognition offered to the complicit. The player knows the pleasure Shinra knows. The third is Lurianic. In the Kabbalah of Safed the sparks scattered in the breaking of the vessels may be raised in repair, *tikkun*, or further degraded, depending on the use to which the material world is put (Chapter Two). The materia the player gathers are spent, at the end, in defence of the Lifestream; the knowledge of the dead is turned against the forces that would consume the dead. The difference between Shinra and the party lies not in whether they use the knowledge of the dead, since every living thing does, but in the end for which they use it and in whether the use is acknowledged.

The second disc dramatizes the distinction. Shinra condenses Huge Materia in its reactors for a weapon to fire at Meteor; the party seizes them, one by one, and carries those it recovers to Bugenhagen's observatory at Cosmo Canyon. The crystals pass from the company's arsenal into the keeping of the Study of Planet Life: from combustion to custody.

9.3 The Limit Break: suffering into power, suffering into care

Each character's Limit gauge fills as that character takes damage; when it is full, a special technique becomes available. Suffering is converted into power. Nietzsche's maxim *Was mich nicht umbringt, macht mich stärker* (*Götzen-Dämmerung*, 1889, "Sprüche und Pfeile" 8) is the gauge's motto, and Bataille's general economy describes its release: accumulated pain spent in a single extravagant burst.

The Limit Breaks also distinguish the characters' economies of pain. Cloud's culminate in Omnislash, a storm of blows; Barret's in artillery; Vincent's, as Chapter Seven noted, in transformation into the monsters of the horror tradition. Aerith's are different in kind. Her Limit Breaks heal, purify and protect: their names include Healing Wind, Breath of the Earth, Planet Protector, Pulse of Life and, at the last, Great Gospel, which restores the whole party and renders it briefly invulnerable. Her suffering is converted not into force against others but into care for them. Within a single mechanic the game sets the combative economy of pain beside the anamnetic one, in which what is endured is returned as life.

9.4 KO and death: return without resurrection

Chapter Six described the battle system's reversible death and the narrative's irreversible one. The distinction can now be stated in the terms of the Lifestream. The battle system is a utopia of return without loss: the fallen rise when touched by a feather or a summoned phoenix, unchanged, as themselves. The Lifestream returns life, but it does not return persons; the dead go back into the current and come out again as other lives. The battle system's fantasy is resurrection. The Lifestream's truth is return.

Aerith's death is the moment the Lifestream's truth breaks into the battle system's fantasy, and it teaches the lesson of Yanagita's ancestors and of Freud's mourning at once. The dead do come back, as protectors, as gifts, as the medium of new life, but they do not come back as themselves. The player who demanded a Phoenix Down was demanding resurrection; the game answers with return.

9.5 Bodies in three registers

The technical conditions of 1997 gave every character at least three bodies: a blocky, super-deformed figure for the field screens, a more proportioned model in battle, and a photographic body in the full-motion video sequences. The player's hero is never a single image. Cloud is a small, stocky boy on the streets of Midgar, a lithe swordsman in combat, and a cinematic hero in the cutscenes, and the player passes among these bodies hundreds of times.

Ernst Kantorowicz's study of medieval political theology, *The King's Two Bodies* (1957), described the doctrine by which the monarch possessed a mortal body natural and an immortal body politic. Cloud's three bodies stand in a comparable relation: the field figure is the boy, the battle body the function, the cinematic body the legend, the SOLDIER of his imago. The game's technical multiplicity echoes, at the level of form, its thematic preoccupation with copies: clones, Jenova's borrowed shapes, the second Cait Sith. The Remake's photographic consistency, which gives each character a single body throughout, gains fidelity and loses this formal irony.

9.6 The playable false memory and the position of the witness

Paradoxically, the most important mechanic in the game may be a sequence in which very little happens mechanically. In Kalm, the player plays Cloud's false memory of Nibelheim. In the Lifestream at Mideel, the player guides Tifa through the fragments of Cloud's psyche toward the true one. Between the two sequences, the player's position moves from the counterfeit narrator to the witness.

Paul Ricoeur's *Time and Narrative* (1983–85) described narrative understanding as a threefold mimesis: a prefiguration of action in practical life, its configuration in emplotment, and its refiguration in the reader's appropriation of the plot. In Kalm the player

does not only read a configuration but performs one, and so acquires, in a sense, quasi-memories of a Nibelheim that never existed. The correction at Mideel therefore requires the player to refigure not only the understanding of Cloud but the player's own past play. The anagnorisis is shared: the player, too, remembered wrongly, and the player, too, must work through the memory scene by scene in the company of a witness. The game produces in its audience the experience it depicts. It is difficult to name another work of 1997, in any medium, that made its audience perform a false memory and then perform its mourning.

9.7 Space: from striated to smooth

The first act of the game confines the player to Midgar: corridors, sectors, checkpoints, trains, a linear progression from district to district. It is striated space in Deleuze and Guattari's sense, partitioned, measured and controlled. Leaving Midgar opens the world map, and the game then grants the means of traversing it in a steady progression: on foot, by buggy, by boat, by chocobo, by submarine and at last by the airship Highwind, which can fly anywhere. The arc of play restores, by degrees, the smooth space of the nomad. It reverses the Cetra's fall: Ifalna's history told how the settlers abandoned the journey and lost the Planet's voice; the player's journey begins in the most settled city on the Planet and ends free to wander all of it.

The chocobo stables complicate the restoration. To reach the game's most remote places the player must breed chocobos, feeding them selected nuts and mating pairs of chosen quality until offspring of new colours appear, each able to cross a further kind of terrain, and at last a golden bird that can cross the ocean. The reward awaiting the golden chocobo on a remote island is the Knights of the Round, the most powerful summon in the game. To attain a god, the player conducts a breeding programme. The minigame is Hojo's laboratory with a benign face, and the irony is as exact as any in the work.

9.8 The Gold Saucer and intimacy quantified

The Gold Saucer offers races, an arena, games of chance and a theatre, a spectacle built, as Chapter Three noted, above a prison. It also hosts a date. Midway through the first disc, Cloud spends an evening at the park with one companion, and which companion appears is determined by a hidden variable: an affection value that has risen and fallen with the player's dialogue choices since Midgar. Intimacy is quantified and concealed. The game does not show the player the number; it presents the outcome as a natural consequence of a shared history. The design can be read as a further instance of the spectacle, relationship administered as a statistic, or, more generously, as an honest model of how attachment accumulates from small acts that no one counts. Either way, the counting is hidden, and the player experiences as choice what was computed as score.

9.9 The material caesura

The game shipped on three compact discs. Shortly after Aerith's burial, the first disc ends, and the player must open the console and replace it. The interruption had a technical cause, but its placement gives a material act the shape of a rite. The player closes one container and opens another; the era of the journey in which she lived is physically set aside. Few works have made the end of a period of mourning a gesture of the hand. The compact disc, already superseded as a medium, preserves in the memory of a generation the tactile memory of a funeral.

9.10 The afterlives: the Compilation and the media mix

Between 2004 and 2007 Square Enix expanded the game into the *Compilation of Final Fantasy VII*: a mobile game (*Before Crisis*), a computer-animated film (*Advent Children*), an action game centred on Vincent (*Dirge of Cerberus*), a prequel centred on Zack (*Crisis Core*), and accompanying novellas. The world became a transmedia reservoir from which new stories were drawn.

Japanese media theory had anticipated the structure. Ōtsuka Eiji's theory of narrative consumption (1989) took as its example a collectible sticker campaign whose cards each revealed a fragment of a hidden mythology: consumers bought the fragments in order to reach the "grand narrative" or worldview (*sekaikan*) behind them, and the logical end of the process was consumers producing their own narratives from the worldview. Azuma Hiroki argued that postmodern otaku culture had moved beyond grand narratives altogether toward a database of characters and affective elements, consumed and recombined without need of an overarching story (Azuma 2001). Marc Steinberg traced the anime media mix as a system of character-driven transmedia circulation (Steinberg 2012).

The Lifestream is an allegory of the database. It is a reservoir of dissolved stories and persons from which new works are drawn: Zack, a figure of a few minutes' screen time in 1997, returns from it as the hero of *Crisis Core*; Vincent, an optional companion, returns as the hero of *Dirge of Cerberus*; Sephiroth returns from it again and again. The fan community, with its art, fiction and exegesis, feeds the reservoir from the other side. The franchise is a Lifestream, and the question this dissertation has posed to every relation with the dead can be posed to it: is the reservoir tended, as a commons of memory, or tapped, as a reactor?

9.11 The Remake project: canon, fate and the revenant

Final Fantasy VII Remake (2020) retold only the Midgar section, vastly expanded, and introduced a new element: spectral beings called Whispers in English, Arbiters of Fate, which intervene whenever events threaten to depart from the course they took in 1997, restor-

ing the original plot by force. Sephiroth appears to know what is coming. In the finale the party confronts and defeats the Whispers' harbinger at a place outside time, breaking their enforcement of destiny, and a closing image suggests a world in which Zack survived. *Final Fantasy VII Rebirth* (2024) carried the story to the Forgotten Capital and staged Aerith's death in a manner that splits Cloud's perception from that of his companions, leaving the status of her death deliberately unsettled.

The Whispers are the canon's immune system: the 1997 text, personified, defending itself against revision, as the Planet's WEAPONs defend it against intrusion. They are also an image of collective memory, the expectations of an audience that remembers what happened and insists that it happen again. Sephiroth, in this frame, is the reader of the canon, the villain who knows the story and seeks to exploit it, and the franchise's *goryō*, the dead will that, as *Advent Children* had him vow, refuses to become a memory and returns in every iteration.

The Remake can therefore be read in each of the four modes. It may be combustive: a re-selling of the beloved dead, in which the franchise's most valuable memory, Aerith's death, is burned again for pathos and revenue. It may be incorporative: the new work swallowing the old, absorbing its authority until the remake stands in its place. It may be counterfeit: wearing the original's face while altering what lies behind it, which is the Whispers' complaint. Or it may be anamnetic: a work of mourning that revisits the past scene by scene, as Cloud revisited Nibelheim in the Lifestream, in order to release it rather than repeat it.

This dissertation does not offer a verdict on a project that, as of its writing, remains incomplete. It offers a criterion. A remake is a rite if it returns the original to its singularity, acknowledging it as past and letting its dead be dead; it is a reactor if it burns the original to light the present. What can be said already is that the Remake has made the question its subject, by personifying fate as the enforcement of the past and by staging the struggle against it as a struggle over whether a death may remain a death. The franchise, in other words, has begun to think about its own necrometabolism, in the terms the 1997 game supplied.

9.12 The confession of form

The game's form contains its confession. Its systems make the player a small Shinra in the materia menu, a small Hojo in the chocobo stables, a small Jenova in the Kalm flashback and a summoner of gods reduced to equipment. This is not hypocrisy but the condition of a critique worth having. A work that condemned extraction while sparing its audience the pleasure of extracting would teach nothing about why extraction prevails. *Final Fantasy VII* teaches the pull of the combustive mode from inside, and then, in the Lifestream and at the end, it moves the player into the position of the witness and the

mourner. The player learns the anamnetic mode by having first practised its opposite. The next chapter gathers the argument into a theory.

CHAPTER TEN

X

Synthesis

Toward a Theory of Necrometabolism

The preceding chapters read *Final Fantasy VII* at every scale, from the cosmology of the Lifestream to the materia menu, and found at each the same structure: a relation between the living and the dead whose form decides whether a world, a city or a self is sick or whole. This chapter formalizes that structure as a theory, places it among the philosophical positions it most closely engages (Hans Jonas, Heidegger and Hölderlin, Hannah Arendt, Shinran, Ricoeur), extends it beyond the game to the ecological situation of the present, answers the strongest objections to it, and states the argument in thirteen theses. Its claim is that *Final Fantasy VII* proposes, in fictional form, an original ethics, here called planetary *kuyō*, whose reach exceeds the game.

10.1 The formal theory

A necrometabolism is the totality of processes by which a living system incorporates, stores, transforms and returns the energies, remains and memories of its dead. Any necrometabolism can be analysed into four moments. In *intake*, the dead enter the system: through death itself, through burial, through inheritance, through memory, or through extraction. In *storage*, the dead are held: in the Lifestream, in soil, in an archive, in a crypt, in a reactor's tank. In *transformation*, the dead are changed into something the living can use: energy, knowledge, identity, power, story. In *return*, something is given back, to the commons from which the dead came, to the future, or to the singular dead themselves in the form of acknowledgment; or nothing is.

The ethical character of a necrometabolism is decided at the fourth moment. The first three moments are common to every mode, because every living system takes in, holds and transforms its dead. What distinguishes a healthy relation from a pathological one is what is returned and in what form. This may be called the *reciprocity criterion*. The four modes identified in the Introduction differ precisely on it.

Mode	Exemplar in the game	What is taken	What is returned	Fate of the dead's singularity	Temporality	Psychic analogue	Philosophical analogue
Combustive	Shinra	Energy	Nothing: exhaust, rubble, barren ground, a lie	Erased into fuel and number	Linear: progress as depletion	Disavowal: the dead are used, not mourned	Heidegger's *Bestand*; Marx's metabolic rift
Sovereign-incorporative	Sephiroth	Everything	Nothing	One singularity absorbs all others	Eschatological: the hastened end	Melancholia: incorporation of the lost object	Gnostic acosmism; the immanentized eschaton
Mimetic-counterfeit	Jenova	Faces, memories, grief	Masks	Falsified	Parasitic: repetition without difference	The crypt; the false self	Baudrillard's simulacrum

Mode	Exemplar in the game	What is taken	What is returned	Fate of the dead's singularity	Temporality	Psychic analogue	Philosophical analogue
Anamnetic-reciprocal	The Lifestream, Aerith, the party	Remembrance	Gift, agency, new life	Honoured, then released into a commons	Cyclical and natal: return and beginning	Mourning: introjection	Yanagita's ancestors; Ricoeur's promise; Arendt's natality

10.2 The fractal structure

The four modes recur at every scale of the work, and the recursion is the source of its coherence. The Planet is drained by Shinra, wounded by Sephiroth, haunted by Jenova and saved by its own dead. Midgar is a combustive city whose district of Sector 7 is crushed under the incorporative logic of necropolitics, whose catastrophes are rewritten as counterfeits, and which is reclaimed, in the epilogue, by green. Nibelheim is burned, rebuilt as a simulacrum and finally remembered truly by the two survivors who return to it in the Lifestream. Cloud passes through all four modes (Chapter Five). Barret's town accepts a reactor, his grief fuses with a weapon, his shadow wants to destroy the world, and he receives his dead friend's daughter as an inheritance. Vincent lives in a literal crypt and leaves it for the company of the living. Nanaki misremembers his dead father and recognizes him. The franchise, finally, faces the same four possibilities in its treatment of its own past (Chapter Nine).

The structure is self-similar, in the sense in which a fractal repeats its form at every magnification, and it is the formal realization of the oldest doctrine of correspondence in Western esotericism, the Hermetic axiom of the *Tabula Smaragdina* that what is below is like what is above, and of the microcosm-macrocosm analogy that runs from Plato's *Timaeus* through Paracelsus. It is because one relation recurs at every scale that the game's ecology and its psychology are not two subjects but one.

10.3 The Jonasian triad

No single philosopher anticipates the structure of *Final Fantasy VII* as closely as Hans Jonas (1903–1993). A student of Heidegger and of Rudolf Bultmann, Jonas began his career with a monumental study of Gnosticism (*Gnosis und spätantiker Geist*, 1934; *The Gnostic Religion*, 1958), turned after the war to a philosophy of the organism (*The Phenomenon of Life*, 1966) and concluded with an ethics for the technological age (*Das Prinzip Verantwortung*, 1979). His three projects correspond to the game's three axes.

The first is *gnosis*. Jonas showed that the Gnostic experience of the cosmos as alien and hostile, and of the self as a stranger in it awaiting liberation by secret knowledge, anticipates modern nihilism. Sephiroth is a Gnostic of exactly this kind, whose secret knowledge is a forgery and whose acosmism would drain the Planet and abandon it (Chapter Four).

The second is *life*. Jonas located the root of selfhood in metabolism: the organism maintains its identity only by continuously exchanging the matter of which it is composed, a needful freedom in which independence from any particular material is purchased at the price of dependence on material exchange as such. On this account, selfhood is not a substance but a metabolism, and Cloud's counterfeit self is a metabolic disorder: a self sustained by an intake it does not acknowledge and a return it does not make. The Lifestream is Jonas's metabolic self raised to planetary scale (Chapters Two and Five).

The third is *responsibility*. Jonas's imperative for the technological age requires that human action be compatible with the permanence of genuine human life on earth, and he proposed, as the archetype of all responsibility, the newborn child, whose mere breathing addresses to those around it an unrefusable demand to be cared for. The epilogue of *Final Fantasy VII* ends with newborn creatures, and the whole game can be read as an inquiry into what the living owe to the unborn when they draw on the dead.

Jonas's biography adds a fourth correspondence. His mother was murdered at Auschwitz. In his lecture "Der Gottesbegriff nach Auschwitz" (delivered 1984, published 1987) he proposed that God, in creating the world, renounced omnipotence, and is a suffering and becoming God who cannot intervene in history but must be helped by human beings. The Planet of *Final Fantasy VII* has the attributes of Jonas's God. It is not omnipotent; its saving power, Holy, fails when acting alone; it needs a prayer to set that power in motion and the cooperation of its dead to complete it. Benjamin's weak messianic power (Chapter Six) and Jonas's weak God converge in the game's theology of a Planet that saves only with help.

10.4 Danger and the saving power

Heidegger closed "Die Frage nach der Technik" with two lines from Hölderlin's hymn "Patmos" (1803): *Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch*, but where danger is, the saving power also grows. He read them to mean that enframing, the supreme danger, harbours within its own essence the possibility of a turning in which the truth of being might again come to light. In the interview he gave *Der Spiegel* in 1966, published at his request only after his death in 1976, he put the same thought more darkly: only a god can still save us (*Nur noch ein Gott kann uns retten*).

Final Fantasy VII stages Hölderlin's lines with startling literalness. The danger is a wound: the impact of Meteor, which Sephiroth summons precisely so that the Planet will gather its Lifestream at the point of injury, where he waits to absorb it. But the gathering that Sephiroth intends to seize is the saving power itself. Where the danger is, at the wound, the healing current grows; and it is that current, at the last, that rises to drive Meteor back. The danger and the saving power are the same gathering, seen from the side of the one who would consume it and from the side of the one who would be healed by it.

The game corrects Heidegger's last word, however. It is not a god that saves. Holy, the nearest thing in the work to a god, proves insufficient when acting alone. What saves is the dead, rising from the Planet in their multitude; and what follows the salvation is not a god's reign but a birth. Here the game takes the side of Heidegger's most important student against him. Hannah Arendt's concept of natality, developed in *The Human Condition* (1958), was set deliberately against the centrality of being-toward-death in *Being and Time*: human beings, though they must die, are not born in order to die but in order to begin. The game joins the two positions rather than choosing between them. The anamnetic relation to the dead, the side of mortality and mourning, is the condition of natality, the side of beginning. The dead, properly mourned, become the conditions of birth. Mortality and natality are not opposed; they are joined by the stream.

10.5 *Tariki*: a soteriology of other-power

The Japanese Pure Land teacher Shinran (1173–1263) radicalized the distinction between self-power (*jiriki*), salvation sought through one's own practice and merit, and other-power (*tariki*), salvation received through entrusting oneself to the vow of Amida Buddha. The *Tannishō*, a record of his sayings compiled by his disciple Yuien, preserves the most famous consequence of the doctrine: if even the good attain birth in the Pure Land, how much more the evil. Those who know they cannot save themselves are nearer to salvation than those who believe they can.

The soteriology of *Final Fantasy VII* is *tariki* at every level. Aerith's prayer invokes a power that is not hers but the Planet's. The Planet's power alone is insufficient, and the dead must act. Cloud is healed not by his own effort but by Tifa's descent. The final duel, weighted so heavily in his favour that it reads as a rite, delivers a victory that is given rather than won. Against this soteriology stands Sephiroth, in whom *jiriki* is raised to apotheosis: the self that would save itself by becoming everything, the self-power that refuses every other power.

Shinran's paradox finds its echo in the composition of the party. Barret championed the reactor that destroyed his town; Vincent failed to prevent the experiment that made Sephiroth; Cloud delivered the Black Materia and summoned Meteor through his own hands; Reeve served the company that crushed Sector 7. The party is composed of the complicit, and it is they, knowing their guilt, who are capable of the anamnetic relation. The one figure who believes himself pure, the heir of a wronged and innocent people, is the one who cannot mourn.

10.6 The anamnetic self

The account of the self developed in Chapter Five can now be stated as a theory. The anamnetic self is constituted, first, by the acknowledged inheritance of the dead: intro-

jection rather than incorporation, in the terms of Abraham and Torok; mourning rather than melancholia, in Freud's. It is constituted, second, by fidelity to a promise across the failure of sameness: Ricoeur's *ipse* without the support of *idem*. It is constituted, third, in the presence of a witness who remembers with it: memory as a dialogical and testimonial practice, in which two partial recollections correct each other. And it is constituted, fourth, as a node of relations rather than a substance: Nishitani's field of emptiness, Watsuji's betweenness, the revolution at the basis by which, in Yogācāra, the storehouse is converted into a mirror that reflects without distortion.

The result is a self that is a commons. What is most one's own is held with others and received from the dead. This account corrects both poles of the analytic debate. Against the essentialist, it denies that a true self lies intact beneath the false; against the reductionist, it denies that psychological continuity is all that matters, since continuity can be pathological. What matters is the form of the relation through which continuity is received: whether the dead are acknowledged as given or swallowed as owned.

10.7 Planetary *kuyō*

The ethics the game proposes can now be named and defined. Planetary *kuyō* is an orientation of the living toward the dead (human and nonhuman, recent and deep-time) consisting of four acts.

1. **Acknowledgment.** Naming what has been taken from the dead and who took it. Its opposites in the game are Shinra's broadcast blaming AVALANCHE for Sector 7, the rebuilt Nibelheim and the counterfeit memory.
2. **Return.** Giving back what can be given back. Its figures are the gold returned to the Rhine, the Huge Materia carried from the arsenal to the observatory, the truth of Seto's deed restored to Seto, and Zack's history restored to Zack.
3. **Release.** Letting the dead be dead, allowing singularity to dissolve into the commons in its time. Its figures are the final memorial after which the ancestors are no longer individuals, Aerith given to the water, and the refusal of Sephiroth's vow never to become a memory.
4. **Protection of the conditions of birth.** Ensuring that the commons of the dead remains able to nourish what is not yet born. Its figures are Aerith's flowers, Barret's adoption of Marlene, Jonas's newborn and the epilogue's cubs.

The term adapts a living Japanese practice whose scope already exceeds the human: *kuyō* is performed for ancestors, but also for animals, for laboratory animals, for broken needles and for discarded dolls. Its lineage in this dissertation includes Yanagita's ancestral commons, Lurianic *tikkun*, Freud's work of mourning, Ricoeur's duty of memory, Burke's partnership of the living, the dead and the unborn, Jonas's responsibility and

Arendt's natality. It is called planetary because its household is the Planet and its ancestors are all that has lived.

10.8 The Anthropocene as a necrometabolic crisis

The theory reaches beyond the game. Paul Crutzen and Eugene Stoermer proposed in 2000 that humanity had become a geological force and that the present epoch should be named the Anthropocene. Dipesh Chakrabarty argued that the climate crisis collapses the old distinction between natural history and human history (2009). Andreas Malm traced the fossil economy to the nineteenth-century choice of a stock of energy over a flow (2016).

The stock in question is the dead. Coal is the compressed remains of the swamp forests of the Carboniferous, three hundred million years and more in the past; petroleum and natural gas derive largely from marine microorganisms buried and transformed over hundreds of millions of years. Industrial civilization lights itself by burning the deep-time dead, and returns to the commons from which they came principally their exhaust. Midgar is this civilization without the metaphor, or rather with the metaphor reversed: the game imagines as fantasy what the industrial world does in fact.

Timothy Morton's hyperobjects, entities so massively distributed in time and space that they cannot be perceived whole, such as global warming, are viscous, nonlocal and temporally undulating (Morton 2013). Meteor, hanging in the sky above every location in the world for two discs, approaching too slowly to be seen to move, too vast to be grasped and impossible to escape, is a hyperobject made visible. The game gives the hyperobject a face, which the climate crisis lacks, and in giving it a face makes it thinkable as something one lives beneath. Isabelle Stengers's intrusion of Gaia (Chapter Two) finds its figure in the WEAPONs.

Necrometabolic critique adds to climate ethics a question that the accounting of emissions does not ask: how a civilization stands toward the dead whose remains it burns, and toward the unborn whose world it consumes. Planetary *kuyō* is not a policy and implies none in particular. It is an orientation, which asks of any energy order whether it acknowledges what it takes, returns what it can, releases what it must and protects the conditions of birth.

10.9 An alchemical coda

The following reading lies at the outer edge of the third evidentiary tier and is offered as an instance of the surplus of meaning the work sustains, not as a claim about its making. Jung read the alchemical opus as a symbolic process of individuation, whose classical stages are the *nigredo*, a blackening of dissolution and death; the *albedo*, a whitening of purification; the *citrinitas*, a yellowing of dawning light; and the *rubedo*, a reddening of

completion, in which the philosopher's stone is achieved (Jung 1944). Chapter Two observed that the Black Materia that summons Meteor and the White Materia that summons Holy reproduce the first two stages. The colour of the Lifestream supplies a third: the greening, *viriditas*, which the alchemical emblem books figured as a green lion devouring the sun, an image reproduced in the *Rosarium philosophorum* (1550); and the green current does, at the last, engulf the fire falling from the sky. The *rubedo* would then be the epilogue's red beast, Nanaki, running with his offspring toward a world reborn: the red lion of the completed work. The opus is achieved not in a man made god, the false stone of Sephiroth's apotheosis, but in a red creature and his children. In this reading the philosopher's stone is natality.

10.10 Objections and replies

Anachronism and overreading. The makers did not read Vasubandhu, Heidegger or Jonas. *Reply:* The dissertation claims influence only at Tier I, and none of these figures is claimed at that tier. Some of its frames, the Yogācāra storehouse, the ancestral cult and the practice of *kuyō*, belong to the diffuse heritage of the culture of production. The remainder are justified by anchoring and generativity: each illuminates particulars of the game at more than one scale, and each could have been contradicted by the game and was not.

Conflation of metaphor and mechanism. Necrometabolism, the objection runs, conflates energy, memory and identity, which are different things joined only by figure. *Reply:* The game's cosmology literalizes the conjunction; its third axiom makes energy and memory one substance. Beyond the game, the term is literal at the geological scale, since fossil fuels are the dead, and structural at the scale of the self, where it names the form of a relation rather than a quantity of matter.

Essentialism and self-orientalism. Privileging Japanese frames risks treating "Japan" as a timeless essence. *Reply:* The frames are plural, and the Japanese materials are treated as history. Yanagita's account of a continuous Japanese ancestral religion is itself a modern construction, shaped by the anxieties of a modernizing and, later, a defeated nation, as Marilyn Ivy's study of the discourses of the vanishing in modern Japan has shown, attending to both Yanagita and the *itako* of Osorezan (Ivy 1995). The dissertation uses Yanagita as a modern discourse on the dead belonging to the ambient field of the game, not as a window onto an unchanging tradition.

Gender. The game routes the work of memory through women and the will to power through men. Aerith is the medium, Tifa the witness and custodian, Lucrecia the grieving mother, Ifalna the testifier, Shera the caretaker, and the cosmic enemy is named "Mother". *Reply:* Partly conceded. The necrometabolic frame makes the pattern visible: the anamnetic mode is gendered feminine, the incorporative masculine. The game partly criticizes this assignment (Cid learns that Shera's care was right; Tifa's descent is an act, not

a passivity; Aerith's prayer is the decisive deed of the work) and partly reproduces it. A complete account would require reading the game's maternities, Lucrecia, Ifalna, Elmyra and Jenova, as a single system, and this dissertation marks that task for further work.

Gender, continued: the anima. Jung described the anima, the feminine figure in a man's psyche, as passing through four stages, which he named after Eve, Helen, Mary and Sophia (Jung 1946). The game invites the mapping, and its reception has long practised it: Tifa as the earthly companion of the first stages, Aerith as the intercessor and figure of wisdom of the last. The mapping exposes the limitation conceded above, the reduction of women to stations in a man's individuation. The game exceeds the scheme where Tifa acts as a witness carrying losses of her own and where Aerith's prayer is offered for the world rather than for Cloud, but the scheme is present in its structure, and it should be named as a limit of the work rather than read as its wisdom.

The history of *kuyō* itself. The practice from which this study takes its central term has its own history of abuse. *Mizuko kuyō*, memorial rites for the children of miscarriage, stillbirth and abortion, spread rapidly in Japan from the 1970s. William LaFleur read the practice as a Buddhist accommodation of grief and responsibility (LaFleur 1992); Helen Hardacre documented how some religious entrepreneurs marketed it by warning women that unmourned foetuses would bring misfortune on them, turning grief into fear and fear into revenue (Hardacre 1997). *Reply:* Conceded, and incorporated into the theory. Planetary *kuyō* is defined by the reciprocity criterion, not by the name; a rite that extracts payment from the grief it provokes is, on this study's own terms, combustive. The history shows that a rite can become a reactor, which is the risk Chapter Nine identified in the franchise's returns to its dead. The term is adopted for its structure of acknowledgment, return, release and protection of birth, not as an endorsement of every practice that has borne it.

Misanthropy. The epilogue shows no human beings; does the game endorse humanity's disappearance? *Reply:* No. It withholds Líf and Lífþrasir but shows natality; its sympathies throughout lie with the slum, the bereaved and the guilty who repair; and its measure is not human survival as such but whether humanity can become something other than a pathogen. That is a question of how human beings stand toward the dead and the unborn, which is the question the whole game asks.

10.11 Thirteen theses on the weight of the dead

I Every living system is a metabolism of its dead. The ethics of a person, a city or a civilization is legible in how it takes, keeps, transforms and returns them.

II In *Final Fantasy VII*, energy, memory and identity are one substance in three phases: flowing as the Lifestream, crystallized as materia, embodied as persons. Every act of power is therefore an act of remembrance or of forgetting.

III Shinra's crime is not technology but combustion without return. It burns the dead for light and gives back nothing but exhaust, rubble and the lie that someone else was responsible.

IV Sephiroth's crime is the refusal of mourning raised to sovereignty. Having incorporated a counterfeit mother, he would incorporate all the dead and become a counterfeit Omega, the convergence of all life into one.

V Jenova's crime is the counterfeit of the dead. It wears the faces of the beloved to colonize the living. Every false memory is a small Jenova.

VI Cloud's false self is Midgar in miniature: a structure of borrowed light, lit by a dead man's memories, consumed without mourning.

VII Cloud's healing is not the excavation of an authentic origin but the institution of a fidelity. Selfhood is the keeping of a promise in the presence of a witness, amid the dead one has acknowledged.

VIII The counterfeit self cannot grieve. The capacity to mourn is the proof of selfhood, and Aerith's death is its test.

IX The Planet saves itself only through its dead. Holy fails alone; the Lifestream must rise. The saving power is weak, plural and other: *tariki*, not *jiriki*.

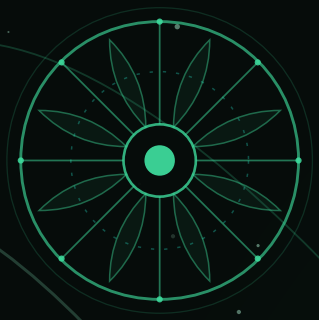
X Where the danger is, the saving power gathers: at the wound. But what saves is not a god but the dead, and what follows is not a god's reign but a birth.

XI The player is implicated. To equip materia is to burn the dead in miniature; to breed chocobos for a god is to keep Hojo's laboratory; to walk the Kalm flashback is to tell Jenova's lie. The game's form is its confession, and the confession is the condition of its critique.

XII The franchise re-enacts the problem it depicts. Every return to the dead is either a reactor or a rite, and the measure is whether the dead are permitted to remain dead.

XIII Planetary *kuyō* (acknowledgment, return, release and the protection of the conditions of birth) is the ethical proposition *Final Fantasy VII* bequeaths to a civilization that lights itself by burning the deep-time dead.

CONCLUSION



Five Hundred Years Later

After the final battle, after the white light and the green current, after the credits, the screen announces that five hundred years have passed. A red beast runs across a canyon of stone, and behind him run his cubs. It is Nanaki, whose kind lives for centuries and who has outlived every companion of his youth. He stops at the edge of a cliff and looks out. Below, where Midgar stood, the outlines of the plates and the reactors are still visible, but they are covered in green: the city of the reactors has been taken back by the commons from which its light was stolen. No human being appears.

The epilogue gathers the dissertation's argument into a single image composed of three figures. The first is a witness. Nanaki has crossed the five centuries that separate the party from this moment; he carries their memory, and he is not human. The game gives the last look at the human city to a creature who was once a numbered specimen in a human laboratory, and who learned in a cave of stone the truth of a misremembered father. The witness of the end is the one whom the game taught what it means to remember the dead correctly. The second figure is natality: the cubs, newborn creatures running toward a world that the dead have saved. They are Jonas's archetype of responsibility and Arendt's miracle of beginning. The third figure is the green city itself: the Lifestream's return made visible, the stolen light restored to the source, Wagner's gold given back to the river, the earth of the *Völuspá* risen evergreen from the sea.

What the epilogue refuses is equally precise. It refuses a verdict on humanity: neither the surviving pair of the Norse myth nor the extinction that a vengeful Gaia might have decreed. It refuses a hero: Cloud, through whose eyes the player saw for three discs, is absent. It refuses a god: neither Sephiroth's apotheosis nor Holy's judgment presides over the scene. It refuses a reign: there is no city, no company, no polity, only growth. What remains is a witness, a birth and a stream.

These refusals are the conclusion of a single argument, which the preceding chapters have traced through every register of the work. *Final Fantasy VII* builds a world in which energy, memory and identity are one substance in three phases, and in which every act of power is therefore an act of remembrance or of forgetting. It distinguishes four ways in which the living can metabolize their dead: by burning them for light, as Shinra does; by swallowing them whole in order to rule, as Sephiroth would; by wearing their faces in order to colonize the living, as Jenova does; and by remembering, returning and releasing them, as the Lifestream, Aerith and the party do. It makes its protagonist a microcosm of its world, so that the counterfeit self lit by a dead man's memories is Midgar in miniature, and it heals both in the same medium, the current of the dead. It turns the death of its heroine from a spectacle into a rite, makes the capacity to mourn the proof of selfhood, and composes its party as a fellowship of the bereaved and the complicit. It confesses, in its own systems, the pull of the modes it condemns. And it ends by entrusting salvation not to a god but to the dead, and the future not to a hero but to a birth. The ethics these

choices imply has been named here planetary *kuyō*: acknowledgment, return, release and the protection of the conditions of birth.

Walter Benjamin's angel of history faced the past and saw a single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage. He wanted to stay, awaken the dead and make whole what had been smashed, but the storm called progress drove him backward into the future. The epilogue of *Final Fantasy VII* shows what Benjamin's angel could not see: the moment after the storm, when the wreckage has become a garden and a witness stands before it, unhurried, able at last to look. The game does not claim that the storm has ended in history. It imagines its ending, and in imagining it identifies the condition under which it could end: not progress, not apotheosis, not the counterfeit consolation of a restored past, but the right relation of the living to the dead.

A study of a work about the dead stands toward its object in a relation the object has taught us to name. A reading can be combustive, consuming a work as fuel for an argument; incorporative, swallowing it into a system until nothing of it remains unassimilated; counterfeit, making it say what it does not. Or it can be anamnetic, returning the work to itself enlarged, its dead acknowledged, its singularity honoured and then released into the commons of interpretation from which other readings will be drawn. This dissertation has tried to be a reading of the last kind, which is to say a *kuyō*: for a game made, by its producer's account, in grief, and for the dead it imagined, a flower seller in a ruined church, a soldier killed within sight of the city, a village burned and rebuilt by strangers, and a Planet whose cry an old man once let a few travellers hear.

Final Fantasy VII ends by handing the world to a witness who was never human and to children who were not yet born, and between them flows everything that died to make the passage possible. That is the shape of its ethics. The dead are not fuel, not throne, not mask, but stream; and a civilization will be judged, as Midgar was, by whether it can learn to let them flow.

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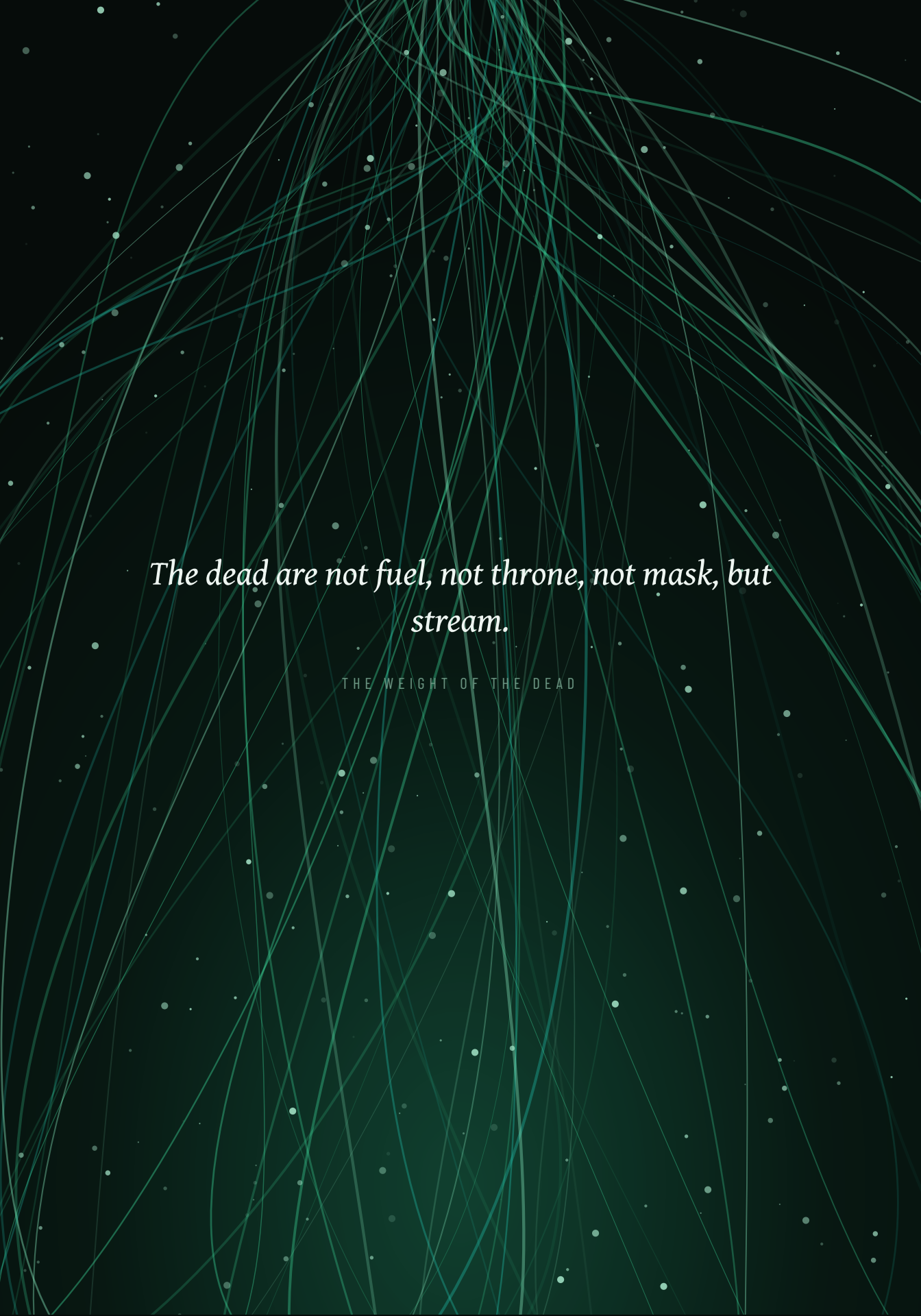
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APPARATUS

Keywords

Final Fantasy VII; Square; Yoshinori Kitase; Hironobu Sakaguchi; Kazushige Nojima; necrometabolism; planetary kuyō; Lifestream; mako; materia; Midgar; Sephiroth; Jenova; Cloud Strife; Aerith Gainsborough; work of mourning; melancholia; crypt and phantom; personal identity; quasi-memory; narrative identity; ipse and idem; Kyoto School; śūnyatā; Yogācāra; ālaya-vijñāna; ancestral cosmology; Yanagita Kunio; itako; goryō; tariki; Pure Land Buddhism; Gaia hypothesis; anima mundi; Heidegger; Gestell; metabolic rift; fossil capital; Anthropocene; hyperobjects; Gnosticism; Kabbalah; Lurianic tikkun; Hans Jonas; natality; Hannah Arendt; Walter Benjamin; divine violence; necropolitics; deep ecology; social ecology; Wagner's Ring; Norse eschatology; Frankenstein; Japanese apocalyptic imagination; Nostradamus boom; Aum Shinrikyō; Miyazaki Hayao; Neon Genesis Evangelion; procedural rhetoric; ludonarrative irony; ergodic literature; media mix; database consumption; Final Fantasy VII Remake; ecocriticism; game studies.



The dead are not fuel, not throne, not mask, but stream.

THE WEIGHT OF THE DEAD